

THE WRONG CATHEDRAL

Fourth Wall Gaming

CHAPTER 1 — THIRD DAY OUT



It was the third day out and the sun was up and that was the trouble.

Vek lay in the scree on the north shoulder where the goat track came out of the treeline and had to bend around the rock. It was the best watching place on that side of the mountain and everyone knew it. He had come up to it two hours before dawn and he had not moved since.

He kept his hood pulled forward and worked in the strip of shadow it made. His eyes watered anyway. Dusk was four hours off and he had been counting them since the light came.

Khorvenn was half a day behind him and it was eight years old.

The other riders were a ridge east. They could not see this, and whatever he decided he would decide by himself, and Ghazrek would only ever hear the version he told him.

What's Ghazrek told me to do in this type of situation, he thought. Think what he'd want.

He did not have to think hard. Ghazrek drilled it into every rider until it was shorter than a sentence, and Vek could hear him saying it, squatting on his heels at the fire, not looking at anyone, the way he did.

See first. Be seen never.

That was the whole of it, the way he gave it. Everything else hung off it. *Count them. Count them twice, because you'll get it wrong the first time* — and he said that part looking at Vek, and Vek had stopped minding. *Anything on the track gets watched until it's past or turned.*

And then the last one, which he said quietly, which was how you knew it was the real rule.

If they saw you. If they saw a gobbo — not a bandit, not a shape, a gobbo — then it's not a watching problem any more.

There was another thing under that, and Vek had half-noticed it for a year and never said it out loud. What came down from the caves through Vharza was *turn them back, don't touch them, a body is a thing people come looking for*. Ghazrek repeated it. He repeated it with his mouth doing something at the corner. And what Ghazrek actually said, after, when it was just riders, was *one of them, on foot, nobody behind, nobody waiting on them at the far end for a month* — and then he did not finish it, and everybody laughed, and that was the end of the lesson.

Vek had never had a lone one before.

Vosh lay against the rock beside him with her chin on her paws. She looked asleep and she was not.

He was sixteen and he had come out wrong.

Goblins were the clever ones. Everybody knew that, including the orcs, who said it the way you say a thing you have decided not to be jealous of. Goblins read. Goblins counted. Goblins knew what a load was worth before the driver did. Vek was as strong as a goblin gets, which he had been told twice by people who measured such things, and he was slow, and he had known it a long while. People finished his sentences for him. He had stopped minding about six years back.

What he had instead was that he could lie still on a mountain for nine hours. And he had worked at seeing until he was adequate at it, which took him four years and a great deal of being laughed at, and merely adequate was what it got him.

The wolf did the rest.

She came down off the mountain three years ago on his first ride out alone. He had not raised her. Nobody had raised her. She came at him out of the scree half wild and full grown and he shouted the first word that arrived, which was *vosh*, which means stop.

She stopped.

He called her that afterwards because he had nothing else to call her. It still worked. It had never worked for anybody else. He tried it once in front of Prek to see what would happen, and she ignored Prek entirely and looked at Vek and waited, and Prek had a great deal to say about it for about a week.

He had never told anyone the rest of it. Nobody in the caves talked about their wolves that way and he was not going to be the first one to start.

Ghazrek was not loud. He was just right, constantly, about everything on a mountain, and everyone in earshot had learned it the hard way. Vek did what Ghazrek told him because Ghazrek was right about mountains. That was a good reason and he could say it out loud to anybody.

He did not have a reason like that for the wolf.

He was angry and there was nothing to be angry at. He had gone through it that morning the way he went through everything, slowly, one thing after another. Prek. The wolves. The ration split. What Vharza had said before they rode out. None of it fit. It sat under his breastbone like a stone he had swallowed and it made the rock insulting and the light insulting.

Ghazrek said that was what waking up felt like. Ghazrek said the ones in the caves had stopped feeling it years ago and that was the whole problem with them.

Then Vosh stopped breathing.

Her ears came forward and her nose worked and the shoulder under the harness went tight. Vek followed her line down the track.

There was a person on it. Coming up.

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One of them, alone, on foot. No mule. No second anything. Eight hundred feet below him and a long way down, working up the switchbacks.

Nobody came up that track. It went nowhere anyone wanted to be. It went to him.

Vosh did not growl. She growled at strangers. She growled at Prek most mornings. She lay with everything she had pointed down the slope and made no sound at all.

Vek looked at the notch in the rock forty feet along and slightly down. From there he would have a clean lane onto the bend and the sun would be off his left instead of in his face. Forty feet of loose stone to get to it.

He went.

The slab under his right heel was bigger than it looked and it was not sitting on anything. It went with a crack and then a long rattling wash of stone down the shoulder. Twenty feet of scree finding somewhere lower to be. In that air a sound like that carried.

He froze half in the open with one hand flat on the rock.

Vosh was already gone. She had flowed into a fold in the ground while the slide was still going and he could only see her because he knew where to look.

Down the slope the figure stopped walking.

She stood on the switchback and her head came up and she turned her face toward the sound. She put a hand up to shade her eyes and held it there.

She had no bow. Nothing across her back at all. Something long and straight in one hand and cloth moving at her arms and legs. No armour anywhere. At that hour worked steel would have been shouting.

She did not crouch. She did not get off the track.

Then she called out.

The sound came up thin and stretched and it was a word and then several words. A woman's voice, pitched to carry, and cracked. He did not understand any of it. It was not Goblin and it was not Hobgoblin and it was not Orc. It was the other kind, the flat round noise the low-country people made, and nobody in the caves had ever thought he would need it.

She waited. Then she called again and the sounds had changed, like a second key tried in the same lock.

He did not need the words. That was not a challenge. He had heard gobbos challenge and he had heard gobbos afraid and it was neither. It went up at the end.

Beside him Vosh put her ears forward.

The woman lowered her hand and shifted the long straight thing to her other hand and started climbing again.

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He let her come.

He lay in the scree with a stone in his fist and watched her work up the last of the switchbacks. She was labouring. She stopped every dozen paces with one hand on the rock. Whatever she had been doing to get there she had been doing too long and on not enough water.

She passed below the notch. She passed the bend. She did not look up again.

Then her back was to him and every scrape of her boots covered the sound of his.

When he shifted his weight Vosh did not come. It was half a heartbeat. She looked at him and did not move and then she was up and with him and low and silent the way she always was.

He went down the fold like water finding a crack. Eighty feet, angling below the bend, and this time his feet did what he told them. Not a stone moved. Somewhere in it he stopped thinking about it, which was when he was best.

She never turned around.

He came up onto the track eight paces behind her and Vosh came in on his left.

Up close she was smaller than she had looked. A human woman, not young, in travelling robes that had been good once and were torn at the hem and filthy to the knee. The long straight thing was a walking staff worn pale where her grip had been. No knife. No bow. A satchel and a water skin that hung flat.

Her hair was coming out of its binding. The back of her neck was burnt raw.

She had stopped in the middle of the track and she was not resting. She stood with her face turned up toward the pass and both hands on the staff and her shoulders were going.

She was crying. Alone on a mountain, out of water, weeping at a gap in the rock.

Then she said three or four words to the empty air ahead of her and she laughed.

Vosh came up level with his knee and stopped there.

She did not take the flank. She had taken the flank every time for three years without being asked. She stood beside him with her ears forward and her tail doing something slow that he had never seen her do on a hunt.

He gave her the signal low at his hip where nothing above could catch it. Hand out and rolled in a half circle away from the body. Go wide. Come at it from the other side.

Nothing happened.

She looked at his hand. Then she looked at him. Twenty-two stone of dire wolf with her ears forward and not one muscle moving, and he was looking at an animal that had understood him and was not doing it.

He gave it again and put his knuckle into her shoulder the way he would if she had gone stupid on a scent.

She went.

She went up the bank onto bare stone in full sun and stopped. Twelve feet from the woman. Standing square in the open with her tail low and slow.

She did not drop into the broken ground on the uphill side where he would have put her. She put herself where the woman would see her the moment she turned around, and then she stood there in the light and waited to be seen.

Vek covered the eight paces and drove the spear in with everything he had.

It went low. He was four foot four in his boots and she was a head and a half taller and he was coming uphill at her on loose track. The point that was meant for the base of her skull took her through the back of the left thigh, in and out, a hand's breadth above the knee.

The noise she made was not a word in any language.

The leg folded. She went down sideways onto the scree and the staff clattered away downslope and the blood came out of her fast and dark all over the pale grey cloth.

She rolled onto her back and looked up at him from three feet away.

He put his shoulder against the shaft and shoved and the spear went nowhere. The point was through the meat and lodged against something that would not give. All his weight ground it a half inch and dragged a sound out of her.

The spear stayed in her leg.

She did not pass out. She got her breath and her jaw locked and she stayed there with her hands hovering either side of the shaft and did not touch it.

Then she stopped screaming and looked at him properly.

He knew fear. He had made a good many people afraid and he knew what it looked like from that side. It was not that.

Her mouth worked. She tried three times and the pain took the words each time and what came out was the flat round low-country noise and it meant nothing to him.

Then she stopped trying. She took her hand off the shaft of his spear and held it out toward him, palm up and open and empty.

He had seen that from one end of the Kazhrun to the other. It meant the same thing in every language there was.

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Vosh came down off the bank.

She came at a walk with her head level and she went past his shoulder close enough that her fur brushed his arm and she did not look at him. She walked up to the woman lying on the track and she lay down beside her.

Chin between her paws. Facing out down the slope. The way she did at the mouth of his sleeping hole every night of his life.

The woman turned her head and looked at the wolf from six inches away and began to cry again without any noise.

Vek stood over them with the spear stuck in her leg and the sling loaded in his left hand.

He knew that posture. He had looked at it from inside a blanket every night for three years. She had not abandoned a hunt. She had put something in the place where his things went and sat down in front of it and turned to watch the slope, because that was her job.

Her breathing had gone long and slow. The muscle along her shoulder that stayed hard the whole time they were outside the caves had let go.

Her tail was going. She was not braced for him to be angry. It had not occurred to her.

She had never been wrong about a stranger. Not once in three years.

“Vosh,” he said in Goblin. “Vosh. What the fuck are you doing.”

She did not lift her head.

The woman flinched at the sound of his voice and stared at him and understood nothing.

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He went over and knelt in the bloody scree and pushed his hand into the ruff at the side of her neck, deep, past the guard hairs into the hot dense underfur where he could feel her pulse against his palm.

She turned her head and let him.

He looked at her straight on, eye to eye, which was a thing he did not do to wolves and had not done to this one since the day she came off the mountain.

She held it. She did not blink and she did not look away.

Then she leaned her weight into his hand and turned back to face down the slope and put her chin on her paws.

Fuck me, Vosh, he thought. Ghazrek is going to kill me.

He moved to the woman.

She got an arm up across her face and he took her wrist and put it down. The leg was bad. The blood came in a slow steady welling and there was already a great deal of it and his spear was in the middle of it.

He put his boot against her hip and got both hands on the shaft. She worked out what was coming half a second before it came and got her hand into Vosh's fur and Vosh let her.

It came out on the second haul. She made no sound that time. Her fist closed so hard that a handful of grey fur came away in it.

He threw the spear behind him and got his hands on the wound.

She took his wrists and moved his hands and put them where she wanted them and pressed down on the backs of them to show him the weight. Then she tore at her own hem one-handed and fed him a strip of cloth and tapped his knuckles twice when she wanted him to lift so she could get it underneath.

She talked the whole time. He did not understand a word of it.

He got the weight right and got the cloth under and hauled it tight the way her hands had told him and the blood came through the binding in four breaths and kept coming, warm over his knuckles.

His hands were too small and too clumsy and he could not make them do it.

She felt it too. He watched her feel it. She looked down at the leg and then at his hands on it and her face did something tired.

Then she stopped directing him and took her hands away and put them together under her chin and let her head go back onto the scree and closed her eyes.

He had never in his life seen anyone do anything that stupid.

Keep the pressure on, he thought, because there was nothing else to do, and he leaned on it.

Then she began to sing.

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It was thin and cracked and it kept breaking where the pain got in. It was a song and the shape of it was the same warm shape her voice had made when she called up the slope at him.

The notch above them took the sound and gave a piece of it back half a beat late. Then the rock behind her did the same. It was not loud. The sound went somewhere and came back changed, the way it did in the deep galleries at home when someone was fool enough to sing down there.

The hair on his arms stood up.

Beside him Vosh lifted her head off her paws and listened.

And Vek was not having it.

He had one thing left and he spent it there, on the leg, because if she stopped that blood herself while he knelt in it doing nothing then he did not get to be the reason she was alive.

He wiped his palms down his front and got a fresh grip and went back in, and this time he did not do it the way she had shown him. He did it the way he would close a torn wolf. Knee jammed above the wound. Both thumbs deep. The binding twisted round the shaft of a javelin and cranked until the cloth creaked.

It was ugly. It was not how a physician would have done it.

His thumbs were too short to reach across the wound. The javelin twisted out of true. The blood came through the cloth in a slow dark bloom while he was still cranking it.

She saved herself.

While he was still swearing at the binding the song finished, and under his hands the leg went warm, strangely and unpleasantly warm, and the flow stopped. Not because of anything he had done. The edges of the hole drew in from the inside like a mouth closing and what was left was a raw seam and a great deal of blood already spilled and a leg that was not going to carry her anywhere.

He sat back on his heels with his hands out in front of him, red to the elbow.

She opened her eyes. She was grey and soaked and shaking. She looked at the leg and at his binding, still knotted round her thigh with a javelin through it, and then at his face.

Then she laughed. One cracked note of it. Her hand came over and landed on the back of his bloody wrist and stayed there.

Vosh put her chin back down.

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He worked it out on his heels in the drying blood.

Nobody in the caves could do what she had just done. When Prek came off the scree two springs ago with his forearm bent the wrong way he got Vharza's aunt and two sticks and a strap and a great deal of shouting, and the arm still did not straighten. When the coughing went through the deep galleries the winter before that, four people died and the answer was that some people died.

This one had put a hole in her own leg back together by singing at it. He had watched it happen with his hands inside the wound.

That was not a prisoner. That was not meat. That was a tool nobody else in the Kazhrun had, lying on a track, alive, because he was the one who found her.

Bitch is a healer, right? Could be useful. He could hear how he would put it to the idiots back at the caverns, too. *She sings and holes close.*

Ghazrek would find out. It was Ghazrek. And it did not matter, because it was not a watching problem, and it was not even any kind of problem, because he had solved it.

She was not a witness. She was a thing that could not leave.

She's not going anywhere and she's ours now.

Not spared. Not let off. Claimed, the way you would claim a good knife off a corpse and dare anyone to take it out of your hand. Let Ghazrek call that going soft. Going soft was giving things away, and he had just taken something nobody else in the Kazhrun had got.

He was grinning when he stood up. He felt it happen and did not stop it.

Two javelins from the saddle quiver and her staff and the hide off his bedroll and the harness straps he had been meaning to restitch for a year. It took a quarter of an hour. It came out square and tight, the one thing his hands had got right all day. Low and wide and it would take her weight over broken ground if he went slow and picked the line.

She worked out what it was while he was lashing the second crosspiece and went still. Then she started helping, one-handed, from the ground, feeding him strap ends.

Getting her onto it hurt her badly and she made no sound the whole time. When it was done she lay back with her arm across her eyes and breathed.

Vosh stood up and walked over and put herself in front of the drag poles.

She had never worn a hauling harness in her life. She stood and waited for him to rig her.

Fuck me, he thought. That was the third time that day.

He was on his knees knotting the trace when her head came up sharp, and it was the old signal, the real one.

Not toward the pass. East.

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Five riders along the shoulder in the low sun, strung out at the trot. The one in front was big even at that distance and sat his wolf the way nobody else did.

They had heard her scream. Sound carried up there. He had been counting on that his whole life.

Prek got there second because Prek always got there second. He took it in and started to do something with his face.

“Shut it,” Ghazrek said. He did not look at him. Prek shut it.

The other three fanned out without being told. One up the bank, two down the track. Nobody looked at the woman. They looked at the ground she had come up.

Ghazrek swung down. He walked past Vek first and crouched and put two fingers in the blood on the scree and rubbed them together. Then he stood and looked at the drag. The crosspieces and the lashings and the way the hide was dished so she would not slide. He looked at it a long time.

Then he looked at Vosh standing in the trace.

Something went across his face and was gone.

Last of all he looked at the woman. She was up on one elbow, grey as ash, filthy with her own blood, one leg strapped to a javelin. She looked back at seven feet of orc with an axe on his back and did not look away and did not beg. Her chin came up.

Ghazrek made a small sound.

"You were meant to watch the track," he said. "Tell me what I'm looking at. Think about it first. Prek's going to tell this one round the fire either way and you get to pick which version."

Vek stood up with his hands still red.

"Vosh said to keep her," he said. "So we fucking keep her."

Prek made a noise. Somebody up the bank laughed once and cut it off.

Ghazrek did not laugh. He turned his head and looked at the wolf standing in a hauling harness in front of a drag with a human on it, ears forward, at ease.

He shook his head once.

"No."

He said it almost kindly.

"Vosh didn't say anything, Vek. Vosh is a wolf. A wolf that's been drinking that water eight years, same as the rest of you. Same as the

ones back in the hole who share their meat now and think that makes them clever.”

He let it sit. Up the bank somebody shifted their weight.

“You went down there to put a stone in her and you came back with a stretcher. That’s not you deciding. That’s you being decided at.”

Prek was looking at his hands with great care.

Ghazrek turned to the drag.

“Rek. Solm. Take the poles.”

Two riders swung down.

“She’s coming in.”

He glanced back and his mouth did the thing at the corner.

“She lives. She lives all the way to the caves and up the deep gallery and into the middle of the floor where everyone can see her.” He picked the spear up off the scree and wiped the point on his thigh and handed it back haft first. “Then Drakmoor gets to stand in front of every gobbo in that hole and say out loud what we do with a human who walked up to our front door singing.”

He swung up onto his wolf.

“He’ll say keep her. Course he will. He’ll find a reason. She’s useful, she’s a healer, she’s got two hands. And every one of them will hear him say it.”

He looked down.

“That’s a better raid than anything I’ve taken in three years, lad. And you brought it to me.”

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They moved out at dusk. Rek and Solm on the poles and the woman insensible on the drag and the line strung out along the shoulder with the light going red behind the pass.

Vek walked. Vosh walked beside him, out of harness, her shoulder against his knee the way she always was.

She was alive. He had done that.

And she was not his, whatever he had said to himself on the track, and the story Prek would tell round the fire tonight was not the one he would have picked, and somewhere ahead of him in the dark a chief he had never spoken to was about to be handed a decision in front of his whole settlement.

He would have followed Ghazrek off a cliff that morning.

Just then it sat in him like a splinter.

CHAPTER 2 — THE RULING



They brought her down off the shoulder on a drag and it took most of the night.

Rek and Solm had the poles and swapped out every half hour without being told, six swaps in three hours. Ghazrek rode at the front on his wolf and had not said a word since the shoulder. Every so often there was a bump, and a small sound from the woman on the hide.

Prek talked the whole way.

He had the story already and he was working on it. Vek went down the slope to kill a human and his wolf would not let him, so he came home with a stretcher and a face like a smacked arse, and Ghazrek had to sort it out. By the third telling it would be the version that happened.

Vosh walked at Vek's knee the whole way and did not once go up front with the others.

"Is she gonna die?" Vek said.

Nobody answered, so he worked it out himself, the way he worked everything out. She had not passed water once since he found her. He knew that off wolves. An animal that stops passing water is an animal that is running out.

So the spear would not kill her. The march might.

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I don't give a shit what Pricky Patel says, he thought, listening to Prek build it. Ghazrek had said *you brought it to me*, and that was what mattered, and he would be the one laughing when the chief got bragging rights out of this.

He had a water skin. There was one, and it was his, and it was not for prisoners.

He went up alongside the drag with it held down against his leg, and he put a finger to his lips.

She got it in under a second. On a drag, half dead, in the dark, with no shared word between them, she saw the finger and the skin and understood at once that this was not sanctioned, and her eyes went past him to Prek and came back.

Then she weighed the skin in her hand. She looked at the weight of it, and she looked for a second one, and there was not a second one.

She took two swallows out of three and pushed it back at him, and closed his fingers over it with both her hands.

She was the one dying of it and she was rationing.

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He kept walking and watching, because staying still in the cold and the wet was the thing he was good at.

Four things came up out of the dark at him.

Vosh did not leave that side of the drag. Not once. When the trail narrowed and there was no room she dropped in behind the drag rather than come round to him. Like something bolted to it.

The woman had started humming. Thin and cracked and low, on and off, for hours.

The wolf's ears moved *with* the tune. Not toward it, the way ears go toward a noise. With it. And when the humming stopped, Vosh turned her head and looked at the woman until it started again.

And the woman was getting sharper. Not vaguer. Whatever the two swallows had bought her, she was spending it on paying attention, and when the wind came down off the caves ahead of them she turned her face into it and breathed it in and she was glad.

He went over and took her hand off his wolf.

She had been resting it on Vosh's head. He lifted it away and put it back down on the hide and looked her in the eye to make sure she understood. *She's my wolf.*

The woman looked back at him. Then she pointed at Vosh. Then at him. Then she put her hand flat on her own chest and shook her head, once.

Yours. Not mine.

And Vosh turned round, came off the drag, shoved her head under Vek's hand and leaned all twenty-two stone of herself against his leg.

She had never been choosing. He was the only one on that mountain who had thought there was a choice to be made.

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At the low crossing he checked his gear because it was something to do with his hands.

Sling in the left pouch. Three javelins, one of them gone into her thigh strapping. His spear with her blood dried down the shaft, and he scraped at it with a thumbnail and a bit of grit and got most of it off, and kept going after he noticed she was watching him do it.

He made her drink properly at the stream. He put his hand under the bottom of the skin so she could not stopper it early, which is what she tried to do. She gave him the flat palm on her own chest afterwards, and he decided that meant *understood* rather than *thank you*, because *thank you* was not a thing that happened there.

She stopped shivering within a mile.

And at the crossing Ghazrek said about six words to Solm, and Solm rode on ahead alone, fast.

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He paid more attention to Ghazrek after that, and Ghazrek told him three things without opening his mouth.

He had slowed the line. Not much. Enough to give Solm time.

He was rehearsing. His jaw was going, and he kept making the small flat gesture with one hand that he made before a fight he was not sure of.

And four times in the last mile he checked for Vosh at Vek's left knee. The fourth time, he saw Vek see him do it.

All right then, Vek thought. Just make sure I can grab Vosh and get the fuck out if it all goes to shit.

He worked the ground out before they came into the light. Down-hill side, four strides to broken cover, then the goat track east under the shoulder. He whistled Vosh in, one short one, low, and put his hand in her ruff and left it there.

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The mouth of Khorvenn was awake and lit.

They had the big lamps out of the store, the ones they used twice a year. There were goblinoids on the ledge and on the slope below it and up on the rocks either side with their legs hanging down, and more coming out of the throat as word ran back inside.

Eighty-odd. Everyone. Old ones who never came out. Kids up past any hour they should have been. Somebody already had a cook pot going, because that was what happened.

Solm was up on the ledge looking pleased with himself.

The noise went out of it in pieces. It went up the slope the way water finds its level, and it took about four breaths, and at the end of it the only sound was one small kid up on the left-hand rocks who kept asking a question and kept getting shushed.

Somebody said one word. It was not a nice word.

A mother pulled a child back without looking at it.

And the woman on the drag propped herself up on both elbows and looked back at eighty faces with her chin up and her hands open on the hide where everybody could see they were empty.

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Drakmoor came up out of the throat and they heard his boots before they saw him.

He was the biggest thing in the pass. Seven feet of hobgoblin, grey through the hide at the jaw, white scars where the hide had gone and not come back. He was in a night-shirt and a cloak with his boots unlaced, and he did not look ridiculous, which was somehow worse.

Eighty people got out of his way without being asked.

He did not look at Ghazrek. That was deliberate and everybody saw it.

He walked to the drag and stopped and looked down at the woman on it for a while.

Then Magnificus Drakmoor got down on one knee in the wet rock beside a human woman, in front of every single person he ruled, and he said something to her.

In her own language.

It was terrible. Four or five words, ground out wrong. But it was hers, and she heard it, and her whole face changed, and she answered him.

He lost the thread about a sentence in. He put two more words at her, slower, and she nodded.

The mouth of Khorvenn made a sound. Eighty people inhaling at once.

Vek stood there with his hand in his wolf's fur and thought: *where in all the hells did the chief learn to talk to humans, and how long has he been able to do it, and who else knows.*

Drakmoor put two fingers against the side of her throat and held them there and counted. Then he took the cloak off his own shoulders and put it over her.

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Then he straightened up and looked for the rider.

Vek came forward past Rek and tried to swagger, because it was that or nothing.

“Course I put the spear in the human,” he said. “I was supposed to fucking kill it, right?”

His voice went on *kill*.

It climbed half a step in the middle of the word and came out thin, and in front of eighty people on a cold slope it sounded exactly like what it was, which was a sixteen-year-old.

Prek laughed.

Two or three went with him.

Drakmoor let it run. He did not stop it and he did not look at Prek. He let the laugh go all the way out to the end of itself and stood there while it did, and it took a while.

And then, somewhere in the middle of it, the slope worked out what Vek had actually just done, which was ask the chief, out loud, in front of everybody, whether the order still stood.

The laugh died off wrong, in the middle.

Prek stopped first.

*
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“Yes,” Drakmoor said.

“That is the order. Anything that sees us and can carry it away does not go away. I gave it eight years ago and I have never taken it back and I am not taking it back tonight.”

Then: “Look at her leg.”

Eighty heads turned.

“That woman will not walk out of this pass. Look at her leg and tell me what she carries anywhere.”

He let it sit.

“The order was obeyed.”

And Vek stood on the cold rock and understood that the chief of Khorvenn had just said out loud, using a leg Vek had personally ruined as the evidence, the exact thing Vek had said to himself on the track. In the same order. For the same reason.

“Why is she alive?” Drakmoor said.

And before Vek could open his mouth: “Think first. I’ll not ask twice.”

*
**

“Errr.”

He heard it come out of himself and there was nothing to be done about it.

“I got her leg. Then... well... Vosh seemed to like her.” He was aware of eighty people. “And she healed herself, and I thought she could be useful — you know — like a healer. Or something.”

Healer went across that slope like water going into sand.

Every single person standing there had buried somebody they had not needed to bury.

And when Vek said *she healed herself*, Drakmoor’s left hand closed. Just that. Vek caught it and filed it and did not know what it was for.

“Vosh,” Drakmoor said. “That’s the wolf.”

“...Yeah.”

“The one that came off the mountain at you. Two winters back. Grey bitch, full grown, nobody’s.”

Vek said nothing, because the chief had just told him a thing about his own life that Vek had never told him.

*
**

“Right,” Drakmoor said, to all of them.

“She’s not a guest. She’s not a prisoner. She’s property, taken on the screen, and she belongs to the rider that took her.”

He put a hand out at Vek without looking at him.

“His.

“He feeds her. He waters her. He answers for where she is, every hour of the day and night, to me. She goes nowhere he doesn’t go. If she’s ever anywhere I don’t expect her to be, I don’t come looking for her. I come looking for *him*.

“And she works. She’s a healer, so she heals. First one of you that goes to her with something broken, she fixes it or she stops being worth her food, and then we’ll have this conversation again and it’ll be shorter.”

He turned to go.

“That’s it. That’s the whole thing. Go to bed.”

Somewhere up on the rocks one voice said “*him?*” in a tone Vek would be hearing about for months.

Then Drakmoor came past him, close, and said it quietly and without turning his head.

“Whatever your captain thought he was going to get tonight, he’s not getting it.”

*
**

Ghazrek came and stood in front of him and did not make him look up.

He stood there until Vek had had long enough to feel it.

“He didn’t give you a prize, lad.”

Vek did not meet his eye.

“He gave you the thing that gets us all killed, and he did it in front of eighty witnesses so everyone knows exactly whose it is.” A pause. “You want to think about who he’d have to hand over. If it ever came to handing someone over.”

He turned away.

“Watch that animal, Vek.”

*
**

Getting her inside took a quarter of an hour for two hundred feet.

She was a head and a half taller than him and the first attempt nearly put them both on the rock. Her staff was eight hundred feet up the mountain where he had left it.

So he gave her his spear.

She took it and got it under her arm and looked at the shaft, at the part where he had scraped her blood off with his thumbnail, and then she looked at him, and then she used it.

They went in past two hundred feet of people who had come out to watch and did not help. Somebody made a joke about the height difference and got a laugh.

She tapped the back of his hand twice when she was ready to move again. She had worked that out on the drag.

He had known this woman eleven hours and they already had three signals. He had ridden with Prek two years and they had one, and it was rude.

*
**

The first gallery hit them like a wall of warmth off the screen, and she stopped on the threshold to breathe it.

Vharza was standing between them and the passage down with her arms folded.

Seventeen stone of hobgoblin, Drakmoor's second, who ran the watch rota and the grain count and the discipline, and who was the reason the settlement had never yet eaten itself. Flat as the grain count.

"Third gallery's no good," she said. "Your hole's two foot high and she'll not get down the ladder on that leg."

She led the way herself.

The seed store was a dry cut off the second gallery. A real little room, plank door on leather hinges, nothing in it but folded sacking.

"It's got a door, Vek. You'll want that. Half this hole's going to want a look at her by breakfast."

And at the door: "Water's at the cistern head. Fire's banked. Don't let her have the door shut on her. I want to be able to look in."

Then she went.

*
**

He got llenne down onto the sacking.

"Guard," he told the wolf.

Vosh was already lying down before he finished the word. It was not clear that he had given her a command so much as told her a thing she already knew. He said it anyway, because saying it made it his.

Then he went for his gear. Four ladders and a crawl, ten minutes each way. He took Prek's spare bedroll. Four people spoke to him on the way and one of them asked what a human smelled like. Old Grishnak, who was ninety and mostly deaf, wanted to know if it was true that Ghazrek had got told off, and Vek said yes, because it very nearly was.

Nobody offered to help him carry anything.

*
**

There was somebody at the door when he got back.

A young orc woman with a bundle held against her shoulder, and the bundle was coughing.

“What do you want?” Vek said.

“I got four days’ ration saved.”

She said it first. Before the asking. Before she had said what she wanted or who she was.

“And I do six turns in the beds a week and I’ll do yours as well, whatever you’re down for, for the whole winter.” She swallowed. “Both. You can have both.”

Vek stood in the doorway and did not say anything, because he had never in his life heard anybody do that.

You did not pay first. Nobody paid first. You held what you had and you argued and you paid at the end, less than you said you would, and the other one took it because taking it was better than nothing. That was trade. That was everything he had ever seen.

“Murga. Off the last band. That’s me.”

The bundle coughed again.

“It’s the same one,” she said. “The same cough as the galleries.”

*
**

Behind him, Ilenne was trying to get up.

She had been flat on her back four minutes with no blood left in her, and she had heard the cough through a plank door, and she was dragging herself upright toward the sound and saying one word he did not have. The word meant *bring me the child*.

Fuck me. Stupid human.

He waved her down the way you turn a wolf off a scent, arms out, flat, and she lay back and propped herself on the folded cloth against the rock so she was half upright, and held both hands out.

He jerked his chin at Murga.

“In. Not past the wolf’s shoulder till I say.”

Murga came in sideways with one eye on Vosh, and Vosh did not move, and a young orc off the last refugee band put her baby into a human’s hands.

He watched it cost her.

*
**

And the healer’s hands stopped being the hands of somebody dying and became the hands of somebody doing their job.

She turned the child over. She got her ear against its back and shut her eyes. She held it up to the fire-pot and looked down its throat by a guttering orange light that was not enough, and she was shaking, and the shaking would not stop.

Then she sat back and shook her head.

Not *no*. The other one. The *I don’t know* shake.

Her hands would not hold still and there was no light in that room and she could not do it.

But she was not finished.

She took Murga’s wrist and moved her arms and showed her the hold. Upright, against the shoulder, not flat. She cupped her hand and patted up the ribs, twice, and made Murga do it until she did it right. She mimed a bowl and steam and a cloth over the head. Then she pointed at the door, and at the light that was not there yet, and made the sun come up with one hand.

Bring it back in daylight.

*
**

Murga stood in the doorway with her baby back against her shoulder.

“She never fixed it,” she said. “That’s what he said, weren’t it. The chief. Fixes it or she’s not worth her food.”

Vek looked at her.

“Fuck off,” he said. “Do the thing with the water and bring it back tomorrow like she told you. And if it dies, then you can start talking shit.”

Murga looked at him a second.

Then she crouched and put a twist of cloth down on the floor just inside the door.

Vek looked at it.

“What’s that.”

“Two days’.”

“She never fixed it.”

“She done work,” Murga said, “and work gets paid, and I’m not having it said I took work for nothing off a—”

She stopped. She had no word for what llenne was.

“Off her.”

“It’s not four.”

“No.” Murga got the baby higher on her shoulder. “Four was for fixing it.”

And she went.

*
**

He banked the fire-pot.

He put Prek’s bedroll across the doorway, because Vharza had said not to shut the door, and lay down on it. Vosh turned round twice and lay against the small of his back with her spine along his.

He looked at the twist of cloth on the floor for a while.

Then he got up on one elbow and picked it up.

It was heavier than it looked. Somebody had rolled it tight and knotted it twice, the way you do when you are not going to open a thing again for a while.

He put it on the ledge above the sacking, next to his fire-pot, where anybody coming through that door would see it.

“We’ll take it when it gets better,” he said, out loud.

The wolf did not move. The human did not wake up. Nobody heard him say it.

Not if.

He noticed that after it was out, and did not take it back.

Then he lay down on Prek’s bedroll in a doorway he was not allowed to shut, with a dire wolf against his spine and a stranger’s rations up on the ledge where he could not reach them without sitting up.

Somewhere below him a very tired hobgoblin would shortly get up and go and do the thing he did at dawn, the way he had done every single morning for eight years.

Vek did not know that.

He was asleep in under a minute.

CHAPTER 3 — THE COUGH



Neither of them had eaten since the day before yesterday.

Murga's two days of ration were on the ledge above his head where he had put them. The human was awake on the sacking with her leg out straight. Outside, faintly, a baby coughed.

Then boots in the passage, heavier than the rest and unhurried, everyone else getting out of the way, and Vharza put her head round the door without knocking.

"She living?"

"Yeah."

"Good." She looked Ilenne over the way she would look over a grain sack for damp. "The orc girl's outside with the babby. Been out there an hour. I told her to sit down and she wouldn't." A pause. "Half the second gallery's found a reason to walk past this door since first bell. I've moved two of them on. I'll not be doing that all day, Vek, I've a rota to run."

She jerked her chin at the human.

"Get on with it. And one thing—" and here she came into the room and dropped her voice, which from Vharza was alarming. "She said she wanted daylight. There's no daylight down here. If she wants to see that babby proper you've two choices and you'll not like either."

"Lamps," Vek said.

“Lamp oil’s counted. Grishnak counts it. You’d be asking the chief.” She let that sit. “Or you take the child up to the mouth, where it’s cold, and where—” she tipped her head back at the passage and the four sets of feet in it “—everybody gets to watch.”

She went.

So there it was before he had stood up. The healer could not work in the dark. Lamp oil meant going to Drakmoor with his hand out on his first morning of owning her. The mouth meant doing it in front of the whole settlement, in the cold, with a sick baby, and if she failed she failed in public.

Vosh got up, stretched, and went to the door.

Fuck it, he thought. Let’s do this one for show.

*
**

He put his head into the passage and the four loiterers scattered about six feet and then stopped, because they were not really going anywhere.

“Who props the second gallery?”

That got him Ghesh.

Ghesh was an old orc, grey through the bristles, with hands like bundled roots and a lifetime of shoring up wet rock behind him. He came down with a bundle of prop-timber on his shoulder because he was on his way to work anyway, and he did not ask one question about why a sixteen-year-old outrider wanted a crutch.

He looked at Ilenne. He looked at the height of her, and at Vek’s shoulder, and back at her. Then he took a length of prop-pine, put his boot on it, and broke it over his knee at the length he wanted without measuring anything.

It took him eleven minutes.

Split fork at the top, wedge driven in cold, two lashings, a pad of folded sacking bound over the fork with strips off his own belt-cloth.

The bottom he charred in the fire-pot and ground flat on the rock so it would not skid on wet stone.

It was not good work. The grain was wrong and the fork would split eventually and one of the lashings was already sitting proud. It was also a crutch, an hour after anybody thought to want one.

He handed it over and stood there.

“What do you want for it,” Vek said, because everything there was a transaction and he had nothing.

Ghesh scratched his jaw.

“Want a look at her.”

So Vek stood aside, and an old orc timber-setter came into a grain store and looked at a human woman for about four seconds, up close, with his hands behind his back like he was at a shrine.

“Huh,” he said.

Then he picked up his timber and went to work.

Ilenne took the crutch. She got it under her arm and tested it and shifted the pad and tested it again, and something in her shoulders let go. It was the first time in eighteen hours she had put her weight on something that was not Vek or a spear with her own blood in the grain.

She looked at it a moment. Then she said something short and quiet, not to him, with her eyes shut.

He took his spear back off the wall.

*
**

The walk out was the longest two hundred feet of his life.

She could do it herself now, slow and badly and stopping, which meant he was not holding her up. He was just walking beside her. Which meant everybody got a proper look.

They came out for it. Not a mob. Worse. They came out and stood in their doorways and along the gallery wall with their arms folded, quiet, in twos and threes, and watched a human woman on a

homemade crutch hop the length of Khorvenn with a goblin at her shoulder and a wolf out in front.

Somebody's small child broke loose and ran three steps into the gallery to get a better look and was hauled back by the collar without a word.

Nobody said anything to him. Two people said something to each other.

Up at the front of it Vosh walked like she was leading a procession, which, he worked out about halfway along, she was.

*
**

The mouth of Khorvenn was bright and bitterly cold and full of morning.

Ilenne stopped on the threshold and it hit her. Sun off wet rock, the whole throat of the pass opening below, the peaks the other side going gold. She had been underground eleven hours and before that she had been on a stretcher in the dark. She stood in the wind on one leg and looked at it, and she did not look at it the way a prisoner works out sightlines.

Murga was already there in the lee of the rock, on her feet where she had been an hour and a half. The bundle was against her shoulder. Upright, he noticed. Not flat.

Behind them, twenty or thirty had followed up the throat and were arranging themselves on the rocks.

Ilenne lowered herself onto a flat stone in the full light and put both hands out for the child.

Vek caught Murga's eye and jerked his chin at the healer.

She did not move for a second. Handing your baby to a human in a dark room at the end of the night was one thing. Doing it out here in the light with thirty gobbos on the rocks was something else, and he watched her weigh it. Then she crossed the rock and put the bundle into Ilenne's hands and stepped back exactly one pace and stopped.

*
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Ilenne did it all again, and this time slowly.

She got the wrappings right off, and the child was naked in the cold for a moment and did not like it and everyone on the rocks heard about that. She turned it over in the light and looked at the whole of it. Front, back, the colour of the hands, the colour under the nails. She pressed a fingertip on its chest and watched how long the white mark took to go.

She counted its breathing against her own pulse. Twice, with her eyes shut.

Then the ear against the back again. Left, right, low down, up under the shoulder blades, and this time she stayed there so long that somebody up on the rocks started to say something and was shushed hard by three people at once.

She sat up. She thumbed an eyelid and looked and tilted the head to the sun. She opened the mouth and looked in properly, with the light going down the throat this time instead of a fire-pot's guttering orange.

She went back to the chest one more time.

Nobody on that slope was talking. Even the wind seemed to have got out of the way. Murga had both hands over her own mouth.

Then she sat back.

And the first thing she did was not look at the baby, or at Murga, or at Vek. She turned her head and looked into the cave mouth, down the throat, into the dark, at the warm air coming up out of it. She looked at that for a long moment.

Then she tipped her head back and looked at the sky.

*
**

She held the baby up. Pointed at it. Then pointed down into the dark of the mountain and shook her head. Hard, twice, three times, with her whole upper body, so there was no mistaking it.

Then she pointed at the baby again, and up at the open sky and the cold bright morning, and nodded.

Then she did it again. Dark, no. Sky, yes. Dark, no. Sky, yes.

Murga made a small confused noise.

Ilenne was not finished. She took a big deliberate breath of the outside air and let everyone see her do it, and held it, and let it go. Then she put her hand over her own mouth and nose and made a face and mimed coughing and jabbed her finger down the throat of the cave.

Then she cupped her hands round her mouth like she was holding smoke, and pointed at a cook fire, and pointed down, and shook her head again.

She took the baby's hand and opened the small fingers out flat in the sunlight and held them there, and pointed at the light on the skin, and nodded.

Vek got it before Murga did. He got it because he had been outside for two years and everyone else in that hole had not.

It was the air.

It was the deep galleries. The warm ones, the still ones, the ones past the third where the smoke sat and the damp never went and the mushroom beds threw that fine dust that made your eyes itch walking through. The good places. The safe places. The places you put a sick child, because it was warm down there and out of the wind.

Four died two winters ago and every one of them was nursed as deep and as warm as their mothers could get them.

*
**

Murga had worked it out too, about four heartbeats behind him, and she had gone white.

“She’s saying take it *out*,” she said. Her voice went up. “Out in the *cold*. It’s got a cough and she’s saying take it out in the—”

Up on the rocks, thirty gobbos who had been silent for ten minutes started talking at once.

He caught about six words of it. *Freeze. Kill it. Human. Told you. What’d she say.*

Somebody laughed, and it was not a nice one.

Ilenne looked up at him. Just him. She was holding a naked orc baby in the sunlight on a cold rock with thirty people shouting behind her, and she knew exactly how mad it sounded, and she could not say one word to any of them.

She lifted her chin at him very slightly.

Well?

*
**

He stood up on the rock.

“OI! GOBBOS!”

“SHUT THE FUCK UP.”

Some of them did. Enough.

“Any of you healers?”

Nobody.

“Any of you?”

Nobody.

“No. Right.” He jabbed a thumb at his own chest. “I’m not smart. Everybody here knows I’m not smart. So I fucking *listen* to people who are, which is more than you lot manage.”

Somebody on the rocks laughed. It stopped on its own halfway out.

“How many babies have we buried? How many—”

“—out in the *cold*, is what she’s—” somebody started, up on the left.

“SHUT THE FUCK UP.”

They did.

“Four. Two winters back. Four. Every one of them nursed down deep where it’s *warm*.”

Nobody said anything to that.

He pointed at Ilenne, sitting on the rock in the wind with somebody else’s child in her arms.

“And whose cloak was she sleeping under last night? Eh? Go on. Whose?”

He waited.

Somebody up the back said it, quietly, to the person next to them. It went along the rocks like a dropped stone.

“The **CHIEF’S**. In front of all of you. So do what she fucking says, stop whining, and stop fucking about.”

Then, because he was already up there:

“And if any of you tries to kill her, me and Vosh will rip your fucking throats out. Got it?”

At his knee, on cue and entirely by accident, Vosh stood up.

*
**

Thirty gobbos looked at him and nobody said one word.

There was no shuffling in it. He knew what shuffling sounded like; it was what happened round Ghazrek, and it was not this. Somebody’s boot moved on the scree and stopped.

Then Murga came forward and took her baby back off the healer.

She did not wrap it up. She did not run for the throat.

She turned round with it held upright against her shoulder, out in the open, in the wind, and stood there facing the rocks.

“Right,” she said. Her voice was not steady. “Right. Out it is, then.”

Nobody answered her.

She stayed where she was. The child coughed twice against her neck and she did not move.

Then, from the left-hand rocks, a hobgoblin woman said: "Mine's been barking since the turn of the moon."

And got up off her arse, and came down the slope.

"Is it the smoke," somebody said, "or is it the damp?"

"It's the beds. It's that dust off the beds, I've said—"

"You've never said."

"Deep galleries have always been bad," said old Grishnak, to nobody in particular, at a volume for everybody. "Always said it. Nobody'd have it."

He had never said it. Nobody corrected him.

Two more came down off the rocks with children on their hips.

Ilenne watched all of it with an expression he could not read, and then turned and looked up at him standing on his rock, and put her palm flat on her chest and held it there.

Vosh sat down against his leg, having done nothing at all except stand up at the right moment, and took full credit.

*
**

They did the charcoal in the afternoon.

There was plenty of it. The first gallery fire had been burning eight years. He brought back a fistful of cold ends and she took one and sharpened it on the rock, which had not occurred to him.

He started drawing the mountain — mouth, throat, first, second, third, the beds — and he was four lines in when she took the charcoal out of his hand, not rudely, and did it again underneath, and hers was better. Cleaner. She put the galleries in proportion and marked the ladders as little rungs and the cistern as a square with a wiggle in it, and looked at him to check.

He nodded. She had it in one.

Then she started pointing.

She pointed at the first gallery and looked at him. He thought about the fire and forty people at any hour and everyone staring, and he nodded. She pointed at the second. He nodded. She pointed at the third, and he thought about her leg and the ladders and shook his head, and she nodded at once and did not argue. She had not been asking permission so much as mapping it.

She pointed at the mushroom beds. He shook his head. She tapped the drawing twice and mimed coughing and rolled her eyes, and he snorted before he could stop himself.

Then she put the charcoal tip on the very bottom of the drawing. Below the beds. The blank part, where the rock went down and nothing was marked because there was nothing to mark.

And she looked up at him.

He shook his head.

She did not move. She stayed exactly where she was with the charcoal touching the stone, and raised her eyebrows a fraction. *Why?*

And he had no answer.

Nobody went down there. That was the whole of what he knew. He had lived in that mountain eight years and had never once heard a reason, and standing there with a human waiting for him to give her one, he noticed for the first time in his life that there was not one.

He took the charcoal off her and drew a hard line across the bottom of the map and tapped it twice.

She sat back and looked at the line.

She looked at it a little longer than she needed to.

Then she did the palm-flat-on-the-chest thing and picked up a fresh piece of charcoal, and the subject was closed. But she had looked, and he had seen her look.

**

Then she did a thing he was not ready for.

She pointed at the wolf and said, quite clearly, “Vosh.”

He stared at her.

She pointed again. “Vosh.” Then she pointed at him and waited with her eyebrows up.

Oh.

“Vek,” he said.

“Vek.” She got it wrong, put the wrong weight on it, made it longer than it was, and then said it again and got it right, and tapped her own chest. “Ilenne.”

“...Ilenne.”

She nodded, and grinned at him for the first time since the mountain, and it turned out she had a chip out of one of her front teeth.

Then she picked a strip of dried fungus off the rock and held it out and looked at him expectantly, and he understood with a sort of slow horror what the rest of the afternoon was going to be.

They spent two hours on it. She learned *fungus, water, fire, rock, wolf, cold, leg, hurt, up, down, no, yes, and shut the door*. She learned them once. Each of them once, and then she had them, and when she was not sure she said it back with her eyebrows up until he nodded.

He was teaching a woman his own language and he could not keep up with her.

That’s a joke, he thought. Me. Teach anyone anything.

Except that what he had done for two hours was hold something up, and say the word, and wait. When she got it wrong he said it again the same way, not louder and not slower, and waited again. When she got it right he nodded once and moved on and did not make a fuss about it.

He never got annoyed. It did not occur to him to get annoyed.

It was exactly how he had taught a half-wild wolf off a mountain to lie still in scree for nine hours. Same method, same patience, same refusal to change the signal because it did not land the first time. Nobody had ever told him that teaching was not a clever-person job, so he sat in a grain store thinking *me, teach* and finding it funny.

She noticed, though. Somewhere in the second hour she stopped in the middle of *cold* and looked at him, and then reached over and tapped the back of his hand twice, the ready signal, the one from the mountain. Then she pointed at herself, and at him, and held her hand flat and level and moved it up in three small steps, like something climbing.

Then she tapped the fungus and waited, because the lesson was not finished and she wanted the next word.

Vosh had fallen asleep against his back with her paws in the air, which she only did indoors, and which she had not done once since the two of them got home.

*
**

He found Ghazrek at the wolf-lines, going down the line with his hands in each animal's coat, checking for burrs and cuts the way he did every morning of his life.

He did not look up.

"Thought you'd be along."

Vek stood there a minute. Vosh went down the line to say hello to two of the others and got snapped at by the big brindle, which was normal.

"Am I still yours?" Vek said.

Ghazrek worked a burr out of a shoulder and flicked it away before he answered.

"No."

He straightened up.

“You want it straight or you want it kind? Straight, then. You’re not on my roster as of last night and I’ve not had to take you off it, because he never put you on anything — he made you answer to *him*, hourly, in front of eighty witnesses.” He wiped his hands down his thighs. “You answer to the chief now, lad. Directly. There’s about four of us in this hole who do and you’re the youngest by twenty years.”

He said it flatly. Not bitter. It was the position of the pieces.

“So no. You’re not mine. And before you get pleased about it, that’s not a promotion. That’s a rope with a very short length on it.”

He moved down to the next wolf.

“And here’s the bit you’ll not have worked out yet, so I’ll give it you for nothing.” He glanced back. “He took my best young screen-rider off the line and made him a nursemaid, and he did it in the same breath as taking my prize off me, and he did *both* of those things while looking like he was doing you a favour.”

He went back to the wolf’s leg.

“That’s what he is. That’s what he’s always been. You’ll not out-think him, so don’t try. You’ve not got the equipment and neither have I.”

“So what do I do?” Vek said. “I can’t ride out. She can’t walk and he said she goes nowhere I don’t go and I’m not leaving her in a room.”

“No, you’re not.” He said that quite hard. “Whatever else, you’re not doing that. First time she’s alone in that hole for three days somebody’ll cut her throat to prove a point and then it’ll be *you* he asks about it.”

“Then what?”

Ghazrek stood up and looked at him properly for the first time.

“You go and ask him.”

Vek must have pulled a face, because he snorted.

“Aye. I know. But he’s the one who tied the knot, and he’s the only one who can untie it, and the longer you leave it the more it looks

like you're happy where you are." He picked up his brush. "Go while you've still got this morning behind you. Half the hole's talking about you telling everyone you're thick, and—" and something went across his face that Vek could not read "—it's working. Whatever that was, it's working. That'll not last a week. Use it."

He turned back to the line and that was the end of it.

Then, when Vek was eight paces off, without turning round:

"Vek."

"Yeah?"

"You did right by the babby." A pause. "Doesn't mean I'm wrong about the rest of it."

And he went back to his wolves.

Vek said it fast, before he could think about it.

"Ghaz. Before I go." He did not turn round. "I'm still yours, boss. Nobody rides like you. Nobody handles the wolves like you do. I'm inside now but I'm still on your team."

And then he walked away without waiting, because waiting would have ruined it and because he had never once in his life known what to do with the second half of a conversation like that.

He did not see what Ghazrek did.

He did hear, about twenty paces on, the brush stop for a moment on the brindle's flank. Then start again.

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The cloak was in the seed store, folded over Ilenne's legs where it had been since the night before.

He pointed at it and mimed handing it over and pointed up and out, and she worked it out in about two seconds, because she had been under it since the chief put it there and had known whose it was the whole time. She lifted her leg herself, wincing, so he would not have to drag it out from under her.

Then she stopped him with a hand on his wrist.

She folded it. Properly, corners squared, edges in, the way you fold a thing belonging to somebody who matters, and she smoothed it flat with her palm before she put it in his arms.

She looked at him and tapped the folded cloak once.

Do it right.

He asked Vharza where the chief was. She had a slate and a stub of chalk and forty things to do and she did not look up from any of them.

“Below.”

“Below where?”

Now she looked up.

“Below, Vek.” She held his eye a second longer than was comfortable. “He’ll come up. He always comes up.”

Then she went back to her slate, and he noticed, because he noticed things, that she had stopped writing and was not reading it either.

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So he went down.

Third gallery. The ladders. Past his own hole, which somebody had already got their gear into, which was a thing for later.

Fourth. The beds, wet and warm and thick with the dust he had never thought about until that morning, and now he found himself holding his breath through it like an idiot.

And then the passage past the beds, which went down, and which he had been in exactly twice in his life and not since he was nine.

It got cold. Then it got quiet, properly quiet, the way it did not anywhere else in that mountain, and the sound of his own boots started coming back at him slightly late and slightly wrong, and he remembered all at once why he had turned round when he was nine.

There was a lamp burning on a spur of rock about eighty feet down. Just one. Nobody near it.

He stopped at it, because it was obviously a marker and because he would rather not go past it, and stood there in the cold holding a folded cloak like a fool.

After about four minutes he heard boots coming up.

*
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Drakmoor came up out of the dark and he was not the hobgoblin who had stood on the slope the night before.

He was grey. Not old-grey. Drained, like something had been taken out of him and had not come back. He was moving carefully with one hand on the wall, and when the lamplight got him his shirt was soaked through at the collar and cuffs and his sleeves were wet to the elbow.

And his boots were wet. Soaked. Fresh.

There was no water down there. There was nothing down there. Everybody knew that.

He stopped when he saw Vek, and something moved behind his face very fast and was put away.

“Boy,” he said.

His voice had nothing left in it at all.

Then his eyes went to what Vek was holding, and he saw the folded cloak, and for a moment the chief of Khorvenn just looked at it.

“She helped the babies who’re coughing,” Vek said. “Just wanted to give you this back.”

He took the cloak. He took it in both hands and held it a second, and he noticed the fold — Vek watched him notice it, the squared corners, the smoothed edge — and something in his face shifted about a quarter of an inch.

“She fold this?”

“Yeah.”

“Hm.”

He put it over his arm. He did not put it on, which given how wet he was and how cold it was down there Vek would have expected.

“The babbies,” he said. “Tell me.”

So Vek told him. Standing in a cold passage eighty feet below the mushroom beds, by one lamp, he gave the chief the whole of it. The crutch, the walk out, the light at the mouth, the way she went over the child four times, the queue that formed after.

And then, because he was waiting and because it was the actual answer:

“It’s the air, chief. It’s down here.” He gestured at all of it, the passage, the dark, the mountain. “The deep ones. Warm and still and the smoke sits and the beds throw that dust. She says take them *out*. Cold and light. She says that’s what’s killing them. All four, two winters back. Every one was nursed as deep and warm as they could get them.”

Drakmoor did not say anything.

He stood there with a folded cloak over his arm and his sleeves soaked to the elbow and looked at nothing for long enough that Vek started to wonder if he had said it wrong.

Then he said it very quietly, and not to Vek.

“The warm ones.”

“...Yeah.”

“We put them in the warm ones.” He was still not looking at him. “Because it’s warm.”

He put his free hand flat against the passage wall.

Vek had seen a great many people take bad news. Mostly they got loud. This was not that. This was somebody being handed an invoice he had been expecting for years without knowing what it was for.

Eight years he had had them down there. He was the one who brought them into that mountain. That was the whole idea. Deep was safe, deep was warm, deep was where nobody found you.

He straightened up off the wall.

“Right,” he said, and his voice had come back. “That gets acted on today. Vharza’ll not like it, she’ll say the rota won’t stand it, and she’ll do it anyway.”

He looked at Vek.

“Anything else you’d have told me if I’d asked?”

“No, chief.”

“Then say what you came for. You didn’t walk down past that lamp to bring me laundry, and I’ve not the strength for the long way round.”

*
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He was exhausted and soaked to the elbows and standing in the one part of the mountain nobody went to, and he had not offered one word about any of that. Not a joke about it. Not a lie about it. Nothing at all, which even Vek could tell was a strange thing to do when a lad had just found you in the dark dripping wet.

“I’ll take care of her,” Vek said. “I’ll make sure nobody kills her. I’ll make sure she does her job and works the way we all do.” He stopped. “But why me? What do you want me to do, really? I’m a wolf rider. Not a bodyguard. What if I fuck it up?”

Drakmoor looked at him a long moment.

“Why you,” he repeated.

He shifted the cloak on his arm and leaned his shoulder into the wall, and it was the first time Vek had seen him take his weight off his own legs.

“Three reasons, and you’ll get all three, because you’ve had a hard day and you brought me the babbies straight.

“One. It came off your captain. He walked a human into my settlement in front of the whole hole so I’d have to rule on her in public and look soft doing it. Well. I ruled. And the thing he wanted to hand me, I handed to a sixteen-year-old, and now he’s not got it and I’ve not got it and there’s nothing left for anybody to argue about.” He said it without any pleasure at all. “That’s politics, lad. It’s mostly making sure the thing everybody’s fighting over stops existing.

“Two. She’s yours by any law this hole has got. You took her on the screen. If I take a thing off the rider that took it, then nothing anybody takes is theirs, and the next time somebody finds something on that mountain they’ll not bring it in. They’ll hide it, or sell it, or bury it. I’d rather have a healer and a rule than neither.”

He stopped.

“Three.”

He straightened off the wall.

“Every single other rider on that screen would have put a stone in her and come home. Every one. Your captain would. I would have, at your age, and I’d not have thought about it twice.” He looked at him. “You didn’t. That’s the whole of it. I don’t much care *why* you didn’t — I’ve got a fair idea and it’s got four legs — but you’re the only one in this hole who has ever brought something like that home instead of leaving it on a rock.”

“And you’ll fuck it up,” he said. “Yes.”

“Then—”

“Then she dies, and I don’t come looking for whoever did it. I come looking for you. I said that in front of eighty people and I meant every word.” He let it sit properly. “That’s not cruelty, boy. That’s the *only thing keeping her alive*. Right now the sole reason nobody has cut her throat is that every gobbo in this mountain watched me say whose she is. Take that off her and she’s dead inside a week and it won’t even be anyone’s fault.

“So no. You’re not a bodyguard. You’re the rope. And you’ll stay the rope until she’s got enough of her own — until enough of them owe her something that killing her costs them personally. That’s not me being kind to you and it’s not for ever. It’s arithmetic.”

He nodded back up the passage.

“You made a start on it this morning, apparently. Shouting at people. Telling them you’re thick.” Something that was almost a smile. “That’s not the worst instinct I’ve seen.”

“So when do I ride?”

“When she can hop the length of the second gallery without you, and enough of them want her alive that I can put her under Vharza for three days without a knife finding her.” He shrugged, and it cost him. “Weeks. Not for ever. Ask me again at the turn of the moon and I might have a different answer.”

He picked the lamp up off the spur and the dark came in behind it, and he started up the passage past Vek.

Then he stopped, level with his shoulder, and did not turn his head.

“You found a thing on a mountain that nobody else would have carried home,” he said, “and you carried it home, and now it’s yours and you can’t put it down.”

A pause.

“I know what that’s like.”

And he went on up toward the light, wet to the elbows, with his cloak folded over his arm.

*
**

Skell was in the cistern trough to her waist when he went for the water, working the channel-mouth with her webbed hands, and the noise of it filled that end of the gallery so that a thing said there was said nowhere else.

“They said she healed herself on the mountain,” Skell said. “That right?”

“Yeah.”

“How.”

“She sang.”

Skell went completely still.

It took her a while to get to it. When she did she said it to the trough and not to him.

“There’s a sound in it.” A pause. “*Under* it.”

He waited.

“It goes round. It comes back. It’s got a shape to it, and it’s the same shape, and it’s been the same shape since the first week I got here.” Her hands had stopped working. “I say *I hear singing in the water down the bottom of the mountain* and what happens? Best case they laugh.”

And then the other thing, and she was not looking at him at all.

“There’s a way down there I’ve not been allowed to finish. Four times in two years. It’s always Vharza that tells me. And she’s always got a good reason, and the reason’s always true.”

She wanted one thing and she named her price for it in the same breath. Bring the human twenty feet along the passage. Sit her on the stone. Put her hands in the water. And watch her face.

And in exchange: “When you have to ride, I’ll sit with her.” She looked up. “Who’s going to come through *me*? I’m the koolinth.”

Vek thought about it for a long time.

“I’ve had one day of owning a person, Skell,” he said. “I’m not walking her down to a cistern tonight and asking her to put her hands in the dark for a favour.” He shook his head. “When she can talk. When I can ask her instead of shoving her hands in a trough and watching her face.”

Skell took that better than he expected.

“Thanks for not laughing,” she said.

“I don’t laugh much. Takes too long to work out what’s funny.”

*

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He brought her down for the meal.

It took a while on the crutch and he went slow, and Vosh walked ahead the way she had started doing, and when they came in under the arch the noise in the first gallery did what it had done at the cave mouth the night before.

It dropped. Not to nothing. About halfway.

Forty-odd gobbos round a fire with one pot, and every one of them stopped chewing.

He found a place on the outside of the ring near the wall, where she could get her leg out straight and where he could see the entrance. Old habits.

Nobody said anything to her. But three things happened in the next hour and he clocked all three.

Somebody’s grandmother, orc, ancient, name of Rukh, shuffled round the fire with a bowl, put it down in front of Ilenne without a word, and shuffled back. It was the good end of the pot. Everybody saw.

The young orc with the forearm came past with two mates and said something quick and awkward and held his arm up, and Ilenne said “Hurt no?” and he said “No — aye. No,” and went red, and his mates made a noise, and that was that. But he came over.

And Murga sat down next to her. Just sat. Did not ask for anything, did not talk. Put the baby down on her lap where the healer could see it breathing, and ate her dinner.

By the end of the hour there were four people on that side of the fire who had not been there when they came in, and the conversation had closed back over the gap, and the gallery sounded normal again.

He ate. Somebody handed him a bowl without being asked, which had not happened to him since he was about eleven.

Across the fire Prek was telling a story with his hands. He watched for a bit. It was not about him. You could tell by the hands.

Ghazrek was not there. He ate with the riders at the lines and always had.

And up the far end, half in the dark past the fire, Vharza stood with her arms folded, not eating, watching their side of the room. She had been there a while. When she noticed him noticing she did not look away and she did not come over.

She was the one who moved Skell off the lower galleries. Four times in two years. Always with a good reason, and the reason always true.

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Ilenne was warm and fed and half asleep sitting up, with a wolf against her good leg and an orc baby breathing steadily eighteen inches away.

She caught him looking and did the palm-flat-on-the-chest thing.

Then she pointed at the fire, and looked at him, eyebrows up.

Another word. She wanted another word.

“Oh for fuck’s sake — *fire*.”

She looked at the fire. She looked at him.

“Oh-for-fuck-sake,” she said carefully. “Fire.”

“No—”

“Oh for fuck sake fire.” Nodding. Pleased. Filing it away with *water* and *rock* and *shut the door*.

“No, that’s — that bit’s not—”

“Oh for fuck sake,” she said again, and patted the stone beside her, and pointed at the fire, and looked at him with an expression of perfect innocence he did not believe for one second.

Murga choked on her dinner.

Across the ring somebody had heard, and it was going round the fire, and Ilenne had worked out from the noise that she had done something and was now definitely doing it on purpose.

He put his face in his hands.

Vosh, asleep against a human's good leg with an orc baby breathing above her, did not stir.

CHAPTER 4 — THE WATER



The water in Khorvenn came from somewhere and nobody had ever asked where.

It came cold and it came always and it filled a stone trough the width of two gobbos at the head of the second gallery, and below that it ran the mushroom beds, and below that it went down into the dark where nobody went. It made a low sound at the cistern head, a hum you stopped hearing after your first week because it was always there, and Vek had lived in it eight years and stopped hearing it eight years ago.

He had woken in the seed store with the wolf against his spine and the whole mountain moving the young up out of the warm, and the human awake against the sacking watching the door, and the first thing she said to him, before light, before anything, in the twenty words of Goblin she had built since the day before, was: “Where. The water. Come from.”

She had been thinking about it in her sleep.

“Oi. Ilene,” he said. “Fill the skins will you.” And then, because it had been sitting in him since the passage: “Fuck, when is your leg going to get better anyway?”

She tapped the splint. “Spear,” she said. “Your spear.” A beat. “Weeks. Not days.”

She was not complaining. She was reminding him that the leg was a thing he had done.

He took her to the cistern to fill the skins because that was a thing to do that was not answering her, and he kept his hand on her arm the whole way and his eyes on her, because she was his and because she had a look that morning he did not like.

Skell was in the trough to her waist. Skell was always in the trough. She looked up when they came and her eyes went to the human and stopped there a half-beat too long.

The human knelt at the edge on her good knee and filled a skin one-handed, and with the other hand she cupped the water and drank, and she went still.

Then she put her hand back to the water a second time. Deliberate, not a drink — fingers spread, lowering to the surface the way you reach to feel whether a fire is still hot.

“Don’t,” Skell said to her, low, over the water. Not to Vek. In Goblin, so he had it too. “Don’t.”

And Skell shifted, easy and casual, the way you would change your weight, and now her body was between the human and the black mouth of the channel. Not fast. Not obvious. But she had put herself in the way.

Vek watched the whole of it and got nothing.

That was the thing. He was looking straight at her, the way you watch a thing you own, and he could not tell what he was looking at. Something went across her face when her fingers touched the water — a change, a catch of breath, her eyes going half shut — and it slid past him the way the ends of sentences slid past him. Pain. Fear. Wonder. He could not reach it. He was the least clever goblin on that mountain looking at the most interesting thing on it, and it would not resolve into anything he could hold.

Vosh came up off the floor onto all fours.

Not toward the human. Toward the water. Toward the black mouth of the channel where it came in, and her hackles came up along her spine in a slow ridge, and she made the sound in her chest that was not a growl, the one Vek had heard from her once before, on a mountain, the day she chose him.

Skell's head snapped around to the wolf.

Vek looked at the three of them. The human who had tasted something. The wolf who was staring at the dark water like there was a fire in it. The koolinth who did not want the human looking where the water came from.

He did the thing he did with everything he could not work out. He put a lid on it.

He leaned into the human, close, under the hum where the walls could not hear, and he put two fingers to his lips. Secret. Then he pointed the fingers at Skell. You too.

The human looked at his fingers a long time. Then she lifted her own hand, wet from the trough, and put two fingers to her own lips, back at him. Skell watched her do it and something in the koolinth's face both loosened and went tight at once, and she nodded, once, and that was the pact, three of them and the wolf, made at the water over a thing none of them had a name for.

Her kit was still on the mountain. On the scree below the north shoulder where he had put her down. The leg would knit faster with it, she said, with her own tools, and the leg was his fault and his to answer for.

He left her with Skell and he took his wolf and went to fetch it.

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It was two hours out to the north shoulder and somewhere in the second hour the morning went strange to him.

Not the mountain. Him. He had carried a wounded human up a gallery on his own arm that morning and worried about her leg and sworn three people to a secret to keep her safe, and out here, with the

wind in the wolf's fur and the pass falling away behind, he could not remember why. He was walking two hours for a bag of splints. For meat. The warm knot of it, the *ours* of it, went flat and far off, a fire he could see and could not feel.

Out here the want was simple, and he liked it simple. Khorven had been feeling soft to him for a while now. Up here he remembered he was not soft.

He did not wonder about it. He never did. It was the weather in his head and the weather was better out.

The shoulder came up under him, the notch and the bend and eight hundred feet of clear sight down to the grey thread of the low road. And the place where he had put his spear in a woman four days ago. The blood was still there, gone brown. Her staff. And up under a lip of stone, the kit, tied in canvas.

He took the kit and the staff.

Then he crouched at the bend and tried to read how she had come up it.

He got nothing. He was a rider, not a tracker — he read open ground at a lope, not four-day-old sign on wind-scoured scree. There were scuffs, and a slide-mark where she had gone down, and the drag where she had pulled herself to the rock, but the approach was gone to weather and his own hurry. He crouched there frowning at rock that would not talk to him. People finished his sentences for him. The ground was doing it now too.

But Vosh had it, or had something. She left the blood and went up the back-trail with her nose down, ten feet, twenty, following a line he could not see, and stopped, and her hackles came up in that slow ridge, and she looked up the track the way she had looked at the black water.

He went to her. He always went to her. He got down and put both hands in the ruff of her neck and his face near hers.

You all right? What's up, girl.

She was not frightened the way prey frightened her. There was no crouch in her and no flattened ears. It was the trough thing. That low chest-sound that was not a growl, and the ridge standing up her spine, and her whole body turned up-track like there was a fire burning there that she could see and he could not. She leaned into his hands and then leaned away, up the slope, wanting him close and wanting to go, both at once.

Then she made the choice herself. Three steps up the back-trail, nose down, and stopped, and looked back at him over her shoulder.

This way.

Fuck. We've got to get back, he thought, and he even turned, one step toward the pass.

Vosh did not move.

So he loosed his sling and went after her quiet.

There was water on the mountain here too.

It wept out of a cleft off the goat-track, a wet black streak down the stone and a pool no bigger than a helmet cupped in the rock, and it hummed. Faint. Almost nothing. The same voice he had heard that morning off a trough a mountain away. Where the water came from was not a question anyone in Khorvenn had ever asked, and here it was, coming out the side of the mountain in the open, where anything on the road with the right ears could hear it. And something had. There was a knee-print at the pool, four days old, where a woman had knelt and looked too close and then climbed up to get a spear through her leg.

And there was a fresh one, kneeling at it now.

Hooded. Human-sized. Vek's boot rolled a stone and the hood came round and he caught nothing of a face, only that it did not want to be seen either, and then it broke for the trees, downhill, toward the road.

Vosh did not chase it. Vosh stared at the water.

Vek put a stone in the sling and threw. It went wide and cracked off a pine.

He had the second stone seated before the first had finished ringing off the trunk. He did not think about the throw. He had been throwing since he could stand and he let his hands do it without him, which is the only way he had ever been any good at anything, and this one went *true* — flat and hard and exactly where the hooded shape was.

Where it had been.

It made the treeline a half-stride before the stone got there.

And then there was only the road, grey and empty and far below, and a human going down it who now knew that the humming water was watched and that the watchers were goblins.

He tried to put the wolf on the trail and the wolf would not come off the water.

He got down in the wet stone and put both hands in her ruff and his face against her head and gave her everything he had. Every cold dawn. Every night she had lain across his hole. The whole wordless language that had never once failed between them.

Vosh. VOSH. With me. Leave it.

She heard him. That was the worst of it. Her ear came round to him and a whine climbed up out of her that he had never heard before, and she leaned her whole weight back into his hands — wanting to come, *trying* to come — and then her head dragged round to the water again like it was on a rope he could not see and could not cut.

He had nothing left after that. He had already spent everything he had on her.

So he spent what he did not have.

He could not have said afterwards what it was. It was not shouting and it was not the signals and it was not anything Ghazrek had ever taught him. It was the thing underneath all of that, the part of him that had gone down a mountain after her three years ago when she came out of the scree half wild, and he opened it up and put the whole of it into his two hands in her fur and asked her one more time, and it was the hardest thing he had ever done with his body standing still.

Something gave.

Not in her. In the water. The rope he could not see went slack for as long as it takes to breathe out.

She came off it shaking, like a dog coming out of a river, and the moment her nose left the water she was Vosh again — the best nose on the mountain, snapping onto the fresh trail, three steps down the slope, looking back at him.

This way. And I mean it.

He was on his knees in the wet and there was something wrong with his hands and he could not work out what he had just used up.

He went up onto her back and pointed her down the slope at a pace that broke necks.

She went down. He does not know to this day what it was, a root or a rock or the slope going out from under her, but she went down and he went off, at a gallop, into the mountainside, and came down on his right leg on rock, and something in it went with a sound he felt more than heard.

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He did not black out. He decided not to and won it.

He lay in the pine litter with the leg bent wrong and roaring and he clawed back up out of the dark because he was a stubborn evil little thing and the mountain did not get to switch him off in the dirt. Vosh came up out of the leaf-mould shaking and sound, luckier than him, and put her nose in his face and whined. The runner was gone. He had lost the quiet and the shot and the shot again and the chase and a leg finding out, and the runner was down on the road carrying the whole thing into the world.

He got the human's kit open one-handed and used a healer's own tools on the leg he needed. He was a rider, not a priest. He did not fix it. He cinched it straight and strapped it to a branch and stopped it bleeding him out and killed enough of the scream to haul himself

onto the wolf with one leg, and Vosh held dead still and low and took his weight, and he pointed her nose at the pass and went home slow.

And going home, riding back up toward the water, the clean went out of his head.

The sharp simple thing that had made everything easy up top thinned with every stride toward the hum, and by the time the pass came in sight he was just Vek again, sore and cold and full of the soft heavy weight of all of it, the pact and the human and now a leg to match hers and a runner loose in the world. He had gone out empty and he was coming home full and broken, and nobody made him notice that either.

He did not ride to the human. He rode to the wolf-lines. When it was really bad you went to Ghazrek.

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Ghazrek read the wreck off him at fifty paces and went to the wolf first, hands down her legs, feeling for what was broken in the animal before he looked at the goblin. She was sound. Then his flat yellow eyes came up.

“You went off her. On my mountain. Where, and what did it, and don’t you dare make it shorter than it was.”

Vek gave it to him whole. The back-trail. The wolf that would not leave the water. The humming pool weeping out the side of the mountain. The hooded thing kneeling at it and breaking for the road. And then the part he had chewed on for two hours: they were not coming for Khorven. They were coming for the water. A thing outsiders came to, on ground the outriders owned, was not a breach to fear. It was a killing-floor waiting to be built. Put the screen on the seep and every one that came sniffing walked onto goblin spears.

Ghazrek did not move the whole time. Vek watched two things happen behind the stillness.

The first was cold. When Vek said the runner made the road, that a human had seen the water and got away down toward Valdenmark,

something went through Ghazrek like a draught through a door, because that was the one thing his eight years on the screen existed to stop. Gobtown, found. For a moment he looked every year of Rotting Bridge.

The second was the other thing. When Vek said killing-floor, said walks onto our spears, the old orc who had watched merchant trains for eight years that he was forbidden to touch, who came home and reported accurately and was nobody for it, wanted it, naked, for half a second, before the lid came down.

Then he crouched to Vek's level and looked at the ruined leg and asked the quiet question.

"How do you know it's the water they want. You said it hummed. Hummed like what, Vek. Where've you heard a mountain hum before?"

And Vek, who had never told a successful lie in his life and had a leg full of splints, answered a question the old rider had not asked so he would not have to answer the one he had. He told him about the human instead. He told him it was the water that brought her, the water she found outside, the pool in the rock, and he left the cistern and the gallery and the same voice under everyone's feet sitting behind his teeth, and he told him how she wept when she found it, on her knees at a puddle, like she had found a king's crown in the scree.

Ghazrek was a rider. He read people the way he read ground.

Nothing moved in his face and that was how Vek knew. He let a silence open and hold, long enough that Vek felt the shape of the thing he had not said sitting in the air.

"I asked where *you'd* heard it," Ghazrek said. "And you told me how the human cried."

He did not know about the cistern. Nobody in Khorvenn ever thought about where the water came from. So he filled the hole Vek left with the answer in front of him, and his eyes went down the mountain, toward the seed store, toward her.

“You rode two hours for her kit and came back on three legs and a wolf, and I ask you a straight thing and you spend your breath on how pretty she wept.” Something settled in him, cold and certain and wrong. “I took that woman as a knife to hold at Drakmoor. I didn’t take her for you to go soft over.”

He had guessed the wrong secret and Vek could not tell him he was wrong without giving him the right one. Ghazrek stood, and his hand found the hilt at his hip without him noticing, and he looked north toward the shoulder and the humming pool.

“Screen goes on the seep. Tonight. My riders, my ground.” His eyes came back down. “And you and I are going to have a longer talk about the human. When you can stand.”

Vek let him walk. He could not argue the old rider off the human without handing him the mountain. He turned the wolf downhill into Khorvenn to get his leg fixed by the one who could, and to get a straight look at the woman he had bled twice for.

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She was on her knees at his leg before she had decided to be.

She took one look at him dumped on the sacking with the leg strapped to a branch and whatever she was underneath, the healer moved. She cut his ugly strapping away and set the bone true while he swore at the ceiling, and she fixed the leg he had broken coming to fetch the bag she was fixing it with, and she did not remark on that. Her face while she worked was somewhere far away.

Skell was in the corner, wound tight, gills going fast, wrong. She had minded the human all day and it had cost her. The human had been asking her things, pointing, drawing in the dust, circling and circling the one thing Skell could not say.

“Who are you,” Vek said, through his teeth, while she worked. “What are you.”

And she told him, in her stitched-up Goblin and her hands and her wet dark eyes, and it came out of her like it had been dammed for months.

“Sister. Ilenne.” A hand flat on her chest. Then north, and east, and far, her fingers walking an impossible distance. “I walk. Moons.” Three fingers, four. “My god.” She did not have the Goblin, so she said the name, soft, like the most precious thing she owned. “Ehrendil Beldroth.”

He touched the world, she made Vek understand. Here. She felt it happen moons away, the thing her order lived its whole life for, and she walked out past the last road toward it expecting a grove, light, high voices, a spring in a hall of gold. Something lovely.

“And I find—” She looked around the seed store. The wet stone. The bones. The fungus-smell. Him. She laughed, once, and it was not a laugh. “I find you.”

Then the desperation came up in her, the thing she had been trying to make a warren full of knives understand since the day he speared her. “It is HERE.” She hummed it. Three notes, low, and his neck went cold because it was the seep, it was the cistern, it was the sound under everyone’s feet, and she watched his face while she did it. Every other goblin she had hummed it at had gone flat and blank and reached for a knife. Vek flinched. She saw him flinch. She saw him know.

She scratched a shape in the dust, fast. It was the spiral. The one cut into the rock at the cave mouth, the marks nobody in Khorvenn could read, that nobody had ever once wondered about. She stabbed her finger at it and then at the wall toward the mouth, and her whole face was a question the size of the sky. *You have this on your door. You live inside the voice of my god. How do you not know.*

Skell made a small sound in the corner.

Vek put the lid on it. He had to. He put his mouth near the human’s ear.

“Listen,” he said. “The one it touched is Drakmoor. The chief. The one who could’ve had your throat opened and shared you round the

fire.” He watched her eyes go hard and bright and file the name away like a knife under a mattress, and he was too dim and too soaked in the hum to read what that meant. He gave her the law, the real one, the beam the whole rotten wonderful place stood on. “Your god can’t be our god. You say it out loud—to Vharza, to Ghazrek, to anyone—it isn’t just you they eat. It’s me. The wolf. Skell. All of us. A mountain of gobbos living on an elf’s god is a thing that can’t be let be true, and the ones who hear it said are the ones who die for it.” He said it flat. “So shut the fuck up and do your job.”

She lowered her eyes and went back to his leg. “Yes,” she said, in careful Goblin. “I am good. At my job.” Her thumb smoothed the splint straight. She did not look up. A good healer stays useful. A good healer stays alive. A good healer is let close to things. She was agreeing to every word and telling him, to his face, in a language he barely had, that she had decided to survive this. He nodded. He heard the first part and not the second.

In the corner something broke its banks in Skell. Not fear. The awful enormous relief of a thing carried alone too long and heard, finally, said out loud by someone else. Her mouth opened.

“You saw the little water,” she said. “Outside.” A breath. “I’ve been in the big one, Vek. Under the beds. Where he goes at dawn.” Her eyes were huge. “I know what’s down there. And I’ve never told a living soul, because there was no soul to tell.”

He did not take it up. Not yet. He turned to the human instead and asked her the other thing.

“Who else? Who else might come looking for you?”

It landed on her like a second spear and went deeper than the leg had, because she knew exactly why a goblin asked it. He was not worried about her. He was building a butcher’s list.

She did not answer fast. He watched it cost her.

“I am first.” She held up one finger. “Not last.”

She made him understand it in pieces. What she had felt — the touch of her god on the world — she had not been the only one to feel. Her order felt it. Others of her faith, moons away, all of them turning north like flowers to a light, and most of them stayed home and prayed and called it a sign. She pointed at herself and gave a small bitter smile. *Few walk*. She was one of the few mad and devout enough to put boots on a road and cross half a country toward a miracle.

The Choristers, she called them. She hummed the three notes again, softer. Sisters who had believed for a hundred years that the voice of their god could be found, in the world, in singing water, and had been laughed at for it for every one of those years.

She had been right. And being right meant she was not going to be the only one who came.

“I go quiet. Too long.”

She was overdue. She had told people where she was going — a temple, a road-house, sisters at the last town before the last road. A Chorister who reports a miracle and then vanishes is a Chorister the order comes looking for. First they would send someone gentle. Someone like her, with a staff and a water-skin and no idea.

The hooded one at the seep, he thought, and did not say it, and her eyes told him she was thinking it too.

Then she looked straight at him and said the thing that made the whole day’s disaster complete.

“If one goes home—” she pointed, downhill, toward the road, toward the grey thread and the thing he had let run into the trees “—and says it is REAL. Says goblins. Says the water sings—”

She did not have the Goblin for the rest. She used her hands. It stopped being lost sisters with staffs. It became the thing a church sends when a miracle of the age turns up in the wrong hands.

Not pilgrims.

He had that one under his sling twice that day, and thrown the second one true, and it made the trees anyway.

Then he told Skell to tell him. All of it.

And she did. Two years of it, flat and half-drowned. The bottom of Khorvenn was water. Past the deep galleries, past where the orcs would follow, the rock opened and the floor became a pool, black and cold and bigger than the fire-gallery, going down farther than she had ever touched a bottom. She found it because she was koolinth and water called her and she could go where no one else could follow. She was the only living thing that had ever been in it.

“And it sings,” she said, and her hands were shaking. Not the thread off the cistern. The whole voice, filling the water, filling your chest, and it did not echo like sound in a cave should. It had a shape. And in two years the shape had not changed. Like it was saying one thing, over and over, cold and patient and enormous, waiting for someone to understand it. And when she was down in it she was not alone, and the not-alone had never hurt her, and some nights it was the only place this far from the sea she had ever felt held.

“Drakmoor goes down. Every dawn. Before the bell.” Alone. To the one shelf where a thing with no gills could reach the edge without drowning. He knelt and put his arms in, to the elbow, some mornings to the shoulder, and he spoke to it or it spoke to him, she could never tell which from underneath. Dozens of times she had watched his shape ripple from below the black surface where he would never dream a pair of eyes hung silent. He knelt, he reached into the singing water, he came up grey and shaking and soaked, and climbed up and ruled them all for another day. “He has no idea,” she whispered, “that anyone has ever seen.”

She did not know what it was. She had a shape of a guess. “I think whatever’s down there is why we don’t kill each other. I think he feeds it, or it feeds him, or he pays it, every dawn, and that’s the rent. That’s what keeps this place from flying apart the way a proper warren should.” She said it plain and did not know she had said something enormous.

And then the thing that had been rotting her. “Vharza knows.” Four times in two years Vharza had pulled her off the lower galleries, kind, a true good reason each time, always two days before she would have pushed deep enough to find the pool herself. “I only just understood it. She’s not been giving me jobs, Vek. She’s been steering me off the water. Two years. So I’d never work out I’m the one who can swim down and see what he really does at dawn.” Her eyes fixed on him. “Two of them know. Him and her. And now—” she looked around the stone room, at him, at the human, at the wolf— “there’s five of us.”

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Vek went to the wolf.

He put his forehead against the broad warm bone of hers and shut his eyes and cursed, low, filthy, only for the two of them, every god and chief and human and lucky-footed runner that had made the day the shape it was. She leaned into it. She had fought the water off for him that morning and she leaned her whole skull into his cursing now and lent him her stillness. She had never once lied to him.

That was what turned him around to the human.

“Are you true,” he said. “Or is it just human lies, like always.” He did not wait. It came out of him rough and real the way words almost never did. “Vosh chose you. On the mountain she lay down by you when she should have torn you. So I chose you too, because she’s never wrong. You know secrets now. You know Drakmoor. You heard about the god and maybe you just want us all dead, same as the men in armour will.” His forehead still against the wolf. “Or maybe it chose us. Maybe that’s why it’s here and not in your pretty hall of gold. Maybe it looked at your lot and looked at ours and it chose us.”

The seed store went quiet. For a heartbeat the thread of hum that lived in the stone of the whole place seemed to lean, and Skell’s head came up sharp, because she had felt that shape in the black water every night for two years saying one thing over and over and waiting for someone to answer it, and a one-legged goblin in a fungus-cellar had, maybe, answered.

The human went white.

Because a goblin had said the thing her order did not have the courage to think. She had carried the horror like a stone for half a year, that her faith had led her unerringly to a hole full of monsters and sworn to her it was holy, and she had spent every hour since trying to solve it as a mistake, how to get the sacred thing out of the wrong hands and back to the right ones. And a slow goblin with his head against a wolf had just handed her the reading she was too faithful and too frightened to look at straight. Not a mistake. A choice.

She wrestled it in front of him and he watched her lose, lose the church, keep the god.

"I am true," she said, and her voice cracked on it. "I did not walk for a lie. I walked because it is the only true thing I have ever—"

She ran out of Goblin and pressed her fist to her sternum, hard, once.

Then she made herself say the rest, and it was barely a whisper, and it damned her whole church out of her own mouth.

"And if I am true... then maybe you are true too. Maybe it chose you." She looked at her own hands, splinting a goblin's leg in a goblin's warren. "And then everyone I have ever prayed with is coming to kill the thing my god chose. And I am on the wrong side of the armour."

She lifted her eyes to him. There was no lie in them and no plan.

"I will not run to them," she said. "I do not know what I am now. But I will not run to them."

"You cannot just say it," she said, fierce, low, cracked. "A god is not a—you do not own him by shouting. It does not work like that." A breath. "But. If he chose you. Then there is a right way to hold him and a wrong way. And the wrong way—" she looked toward the deep water, toward Drakmoor's dawn, and something in her face went very afraid— "the wrong way, a god like this does not just leave. He breaks the ones who held him badly. Your chief has been doing it alone, in the dark, guessing, for eight years." She put her fist to her chest. "You

want a gobbo god that keeps working? Then you need someone who knows what he is. Not the chief's way. Not shouting in a cellar. Right."

Vek did not know what he had done. He knew he liked it here. He knew the chief and his right hand were doing a thing worth keeping and that the wolf was somehow part of it and that he wanted it to go on.

"This isn't an elf's god any more," he said, to her and to Skell and mostly to the mountain. "It's ours. A gobbo god, from now on. It's ours. And you're going to help us work out how to have that be true."

Five of them in a stone room. A wolf, a koolinth who could reach him, a healer who knew what he was, a chief who did not, and the one who had said the words that turned an elf's god into a goblin's. Down in the black water under everyone's feet, a sound that had not changed in two years, that maybe, that night, finally got its answer.

Vosh lay across the door with her back to the room and her eyes on the passage.

The water ran below them in the dark, the way it always had, and for the first time in eight years somebody in Khorven had asked where it came from, and begun, badly, in a fungus-cellar, with a broken leg, to answer.

CHAPTER 5 — THE RENT



He woke knowing, and that was new.

The water ran below him in the dark the way it had run every morning of his life in that mountain, and now it was not water. It was down there past the beds where nobody went, black and cold and singing the one thing over and over, and Drakmoor was at the edge of it this minute on his knees with his arms in it. Vek lay on the sacking with his leg on fire and worked that around in his head and could not make it sit still.

His leg would not carry him. Two fifths of it worked. Whatever the day was going to be, he would have to do it with his mouth.

Prek came down the passage fast and crouched at the gap in the door and would not come further because of Vosh.

“You’re wanted. Up top. Ghazrek’s back off the screen.” He was breathing hard and enjoying himself. “They took something at the little water in the night, Vek. It’s still breathing. It’s another one.” His eyes went past to the woman on the sacking and came back. “Another human. Ghazrek says bring the whelp-tender, on account of the whelp-tender owns the last one and’s got some of their words.”

Then he was gone up the passage to carry it somewhere else.

Ilenne had understood about half. Vek watched her do the sum he had already done. Her people sent the gentle ones first.

“Oi. Sister,” he said. “We’re going to do something tricky.”

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She was up off the sacking before he had finished, favouring the leg, reaching for nothing because she had nothing, and she took hold of his arm.

“Wait. Wait, Vek. Who is she. Old. Young. What she wears. If it is a *sister*, someone I know, someone from my house—”

“So what if it’s a sister?” Vek said. “If she knows you, so what? What pact? I don’t get it.”

She stopped, and worked to find the words, because he was right to ask.

“Not — the *pact* is not me and her.” She tapped her own chest, then his, then made a circle taking in the whole seed store. Him, her, Skell, Vosh. “The pact is *quiet*. About him.” She hummed the three notes, careful even then. “If she is a sister — if she came for him, like I came — then she does not know the law yet. She does not know: say his name here, out loud, in front of everyone, and goblins do not hear a prayer. They hear—” she reached for it and took the ugly plain word he had given her “—*elf*.”

She let that sit. Then she held up the splinted leg, the reminder standing right there between them.

“That is why you speared me, Vek. Not because I am dangerous. Because I said his name where anyone could hear it, and it sounded like a lie about who owns this mountain.”

She was not talking about an old friend. She was talking about a second one of them, ignorant of the law, saying the wrong word in the wrong room in front of Ghazrek.

“So. You ask, do we go up together. I say — you go first. Look at her. Tell me what she wears, what she says, if she has said *anything* yet with the word in it. Then I know how to be, before I am in the room.”

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“Nah, sister. That’s bollocks.”

He did not wait for her plan.

“Not how we do things. We pretend. Scare her to shut her up. I ask questions, you translate, but then explain, so she doesn’t fuck up. Nobody else speaks human.” He leaned on the stick. “Watch Ghazrek. He’s very smart. Sees through a lie every time.”

And then: “I’m going to try to look very scary at you too. But I’m not going to hurt you. Understand?”

Then he put his own fist to his own chest, same spot, same closed grip, and mirrored her sign back at her exactly. It was the first time he had ever made it on purpose instead of by accident.

She stopped. She had not expected him to have that.

It was a promise, in her own language, in her own hand-shape: whatever face he showed her up top, it would not be the truth.

He held it a moment longer and dropped his hand.

They went up.

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The girl was young and the robe was plain and Ilenne went stiff at his shoulder the moment she saw the face and killed it before it showed. Ghazrek stood off to the side with his arms crossed and watched the two of them arrive and watched how they arrived.

Vek came in loud. He got down in the girl’s face on the good leg and shouted questions at her in Goblin that she could not understand one sound of, and cracked the spear-butt on the stone, and Ilenne went down on her knees beside her like a beaten dog and translated in a voice that shook.

Under the shaking she said, in Common, fast: say nothing of him. Nothing of the water. You are lost. You are only lost. Say it or you die and so do I.

The girl looked at her hands and then at her face and something went across between them, and then the girl folded up and sobbed, loud and good, and gave them a lost pilgrim. A shrine. Walking too far north. Not knowing the country. Nothing with the name in it. Nothing with a hum in it.

Ghazrek watched all of it and did not move and it slid off him.

“Lost,” he said. “Same as the last one, near enough.” He looked at Vek. “Convenient, how lost they keep getting, this close to my mountain.”

“Oi. Milkskin.” Vek said it at Ilenne, loud, the word you used for a carcass. “Does this bitch know healing shit like you? Can she help you?”

Ilenne understood the rope he was throwing better than he did.

“Yes,” she said, in Goblin, loud enough to carry. “She is learning. Hands. Not good yet. Young.” She pointed at her own splint and then down the passage toward the queue that formed outside the seed store every morning. “Many sick. One healer, one pair of hands. Two is more. She carries. She holds. She boils. She does what I say.”

Ghazrek uncrossed his arms.

“Two,” he said. He was not looking at the girl. “You come up on three legs and the first sound out of your mouth is how the new one might be useful. Same word you used for the last one.” He walked a slow half circle and stopped where he could see Vek’s face. “I see a mountain that had nought but wolves and rock in it eight years, and now it’s got two of these in it inside a week, and both times you’re stood over them telling me why we should keep them.”

He said it without heat. That was the bad part.

“Drakmoor ruled on the first. His mouth, his call, everybody heard it. He hasn’t ruled on this one, and I’m not carrying a second human down into my chief’s mountain on a whelp-tender’s say-so. She’s mine till he says otherwise. Up here. Roped. In the cold.” His eyes

stayed on Vek. "And when he comes up out of wherever he goes of a morning he can look at her himself."

Vek thought about Drakmoor coming up grey and soaked into daylight and finding a second one of them stood in his own pass.

He turned his back on Ghazrek in front of everybody and shouted at the mountain.

"OI. Everyone hear that? Ghazrek's riders caught a milkskin." He let the noise start and cut it. "On the rock. In the dark. Roped up. Four of them. Very brave." He let that sit. "I caught mine on my own with a spear and she fought back."

Somebody laughed.

"So here's how it goes, because here's how it's always gone. I speared the first one. I hauled her down the mountain on my own back. I fed her out of my ration, ask Rukh, and now the whelps aren't coughing and the nurseries are up out of the smoke, and every one of you sleeping easier is sleeping easier off my kill." He slapped the strapped leg and it went through him and he used it. "And I went out and broke this fetching her tools. For your kids. So the milkskins are mine. First one, this one, and every soft pink thing that comes up that track after them. I took them. I hold them. That's the rule. That's always been the rule."

He looked at Ghazrek.

"You want one of your own? Go catch one that's awake."

The gallery roared.

Ghazrek took it standing with his arms crossed and waited the laugh out. When it was done he came in close and spoke where only the two of them had it.

"Aye. You took her." Nothing in his face. "You've got a taste for taking them, haven't you, boy."

He nodded his riders off the rope.

“You just told eighty gobbos that every human who walks up my track belongs to you. So when the next one comes, and the one after, that’s your name on all of it. Not mine.” He straightened. “I hope you thought that far ahead. I don’t think you did.”

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The girl’s name was Wenna and she was nineteen and she talked like a tap once Ilenne told her she was allowed.

They had it out in the seed store with the door shut to a hand’s width and the wolf across it. Vek made them go over it twice because he was slow and this was too big to half-get.

Ilenne had gone quiet and the order had noticed. They had sent people north. Wenna was one, and she had come the last of it on the same road, listening for the same three notes, and she had found the seep the way Ilenne found it.

She had not come alone.

There had been a man with her. Not one of theirs. Canon Aurel Vane, out of the cathedral at Valdenmark, a churchman of the big church, the one that had been laughing at Ilenne’s order for a hundred years. He had not come to find Ilenne. He had come to look at what she claimed and decide what it was, because a miracle reported by the wrong people is either the greatest thing of the age or it is a heresy, and the church has to know which before it does anything else.

They had reached the seep together two days before. Wenna knelt at the water and heard it and wept.

The canon knelt at the water and did not weep.

He went quiet, she said, and started measuring. Marking the rock. Counting his steps back to the track. Standing a long time looking down at the road.

Then the mountain made a noise and a stone came down the slope and he ran and left her there.

Vek knew the rest of that story. He had thrown twice and spent everything he had and the pines took him.

“He is a day and a night on the road,” Ilenne said. “More. He will buy a horse at the low road. The church always has coin.”

They did the sum out loud because Vek made them. A week to Valdenmark, less mounted. A canon walks into a cathedral and swears on his own name that he stood at a living god and that goblins are sitting on it. Nobody sits on a report like that. The church had no soldiers. The Duke had soldiers, and the Duke hated goblinoids the way other men hated weather.

“Three weeks,” Ilenne said. “Four, if he argues about the money. Not more.”

She looked at Vek’s leg. He looked at it too. Four weeks before it would carry him. Neither of them said that part.

Then he asked the other thing.

“How do we take this god. Proper. For us. For gobbos.”

And she stopped being a prisoner.

She sat back against the sacking and was quiet a long time, and when she started she was not talking like a healer or a captive. She was talking like somebody who had studied one thing her whole life and never once been asked about it.

“You cannot own him. You can hold him. That is the difference and it is everything.”

She counted it on her fingers so he would keep it.

A name they could say. Out loud. Not a secret, because a god held in secret was not held, he was hidden, and a hidden god did nothing for the ones hiding him. Nobody in the mountain could say what was under their feet.

A rite. A thing done the same way at the same time by many. “Your chief kneels alone. Alone is not a rite. Alone is a transaction. He is

paying, Vek. Every dawn, eight years, and he does not know what he is buying, or what the price rises to.”

Somebody who knew what he was. She put her hand flat on her own chest, and it was not the oath sign, it was only the fact of her. “You have one. That is luck you have not earned.”

And a gift he wanted. Her face changed on that one. “He is not a god of blood. He is not a god of gold. He is the maker. The singer. He wants what is made and what is sung. That is why the marks at your door are music. Somebody knew that once.” She looked at him carefully. “And it is why he has not gone. What your chief gives him is enough to keep him. It is not what he wants.”

Then she gave him the bind, plainly, because she had chosen a side.

“To take him for the goblins you must say his name out loud in front of everyone and put in his hands a thing goblins made and goblins sang. And the moment it is said out loud your chief is finished, because eighty gobbos learn he has knelt to an elf’s god for eight years and never told them. And Ghazrek will have exactly what he needs to take this mountain off him.” She let it sit. “You cannot do this quietly. And doing it loudly might kill your chief.”

Wenna said something small in Common. Ilenne did not translate it. Then she did, and would not look at him.

“She asks if he is going to eat us.”

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He went down.

Four ladders on a leg that did not work, leaning on the healer’s own staff, down past the beds to the turn above the deep passage, and he stood in the dark there with the wolf and waited like a fool.

Drakmoor came up before the bell. Grey and bent and soaked to the shoulder and dripping on dry stone, moving like something emptied out. He was most of the way past before he saw the shape, and then he was fast, faster than a heavy old hobgoblin had any business being,

and Vek was against the rock with a forearm on his chest and a knife somewhere under his ribs before the wolf had finished standing up.

“Wolf. Sit down or I open him.”

She did not sit. She did not come.

“Chief,” Vek said. “Three weeks.”

The knife stayed.

“What.”

He gave it the way Ghazrek had taught him. A human up the goat track four days back and he speared her. A second one two nights ago with a churchman out of Valdenmark. They had not come for Khorven and they had not come to rob it. They came for the water. The man knelt at the leak on the shoulder and he did not pray at it, he measured it, marked the rock, counted the steps, looked down at the road. Then he ran and Vek threw twice and missed.

“He’ll buy a horse. He tells a cathedral gobbos are sat on a living god. The Duke’s got soldiers and hates us for free.” He got his breath. “Three weeks. Four if they argue about money.”

Nothing moved. Something in the dark had gone very still.

“A leak,” Drakmoor said.

“Out the side of the mountain. Same sound as the cistern.” He said the rest because he had come down to be loyal and was too slow to be clever about it. “Same sound as whatever’s down there you’ve been going to every dawn for eight years.”

The knife came away.

Drakmoor sat down on the rock like his strings had been cut, and for a while the chief of Khorven was an old hobgoblin dripping in the dark.

“How long have you known.”

“Four days. Saw you come up wet.”

“Who else.”

“Skell. She swims it. She’s seen you kneel from underneath, years of it, never told a soul. My human. The wolf.” He left the girl out. “Nobody else. Nobody’s said a word and nobody will.”

Drakmoor laughed. One breath of it, with nothing in it.

“Eight years. Eight years I’ve gone down alone and come up and lied to every one of you with my face, and I thought I had it bound. Twelve of us came out of Rotting Bridge and I found a hole with a thing in it and made a bargain and I thought I was the one holding the rope.”

He turned his forearm over in the dark and showed him.

Vek had to lean in to see it and wished he had not. Wrist to elbow, both arms, the skin was ridged over with old cuts laid across old cuts, hundreds of them, thousands, healed and opened and healed again the way rock lies in beds. That morning’s was still weeping.

“It takes blood. First winter I cut myself hauling stone and it went in the water, and that night nobody knifed anybody over the grain. First time since we came north.” He shrugged and it cost him. “So it’s had blood every dawn for eight years. And every dawn this place holds together one more day and I come up a little emptier, and it takes more now than it did.” He looked at his own arms without much interest in them. “I’m paying it, boy. I don’t know what I’m buying. I never have. I know what happened the one morning in the second year I didn’t go down, and I’ve never made that mistake twice.”

Vek told him the last of it. That the human was not only a healer. That she had walked half a year to find the thing and knew what it was, knew its name, said the marks at their own door were music. And that she said he had been paying the wrong coin the whole time, because it did not want blood. It wanted what was made and what was sung.

The knife could have come back out there.

“No,” Drakmoor said.

Not angry. He said it the way you say a load will not go through a door.

“You’ve brought me a human who knows what I do in the dark and you want me to sit at her feet and be told I’ve had it wrong for eight years.” He shook his heavy head. “I’ve kept this place alive with my arms open every morning since before you could hold a spear. I don’t know what’s down there. She says she does. Maybe she’s right.” He stopped, and something went over his face and he put it away. “And if she’s right, I’ve bled myself half to death for eight years for nothing, and every whelp in this mountain owes its life to a thing I never understood.”

He stood up. It took him two goes.

“I’m not ready to be that. Not today.”

Then the chief came back over him like a cloak.

“The soldiers I believe. That’s a report and a good one and you brought it to me first and I’ll not forget it.” He looked up the passage toward the light. “Ghazrek gets told today. Not because I like it. Because there’s a canon on a horse with a week’s start and one gobbo on this mountain who can put riders on a road and catch him, and it isn’t you and it isn’t me. He gets the road. He gets the seep. He gets everything above the treeline and every rider he wants.”

“And the rest of it?”

“The rest of it is mine. He doesn’t get the water. He doesn’t get the dawn. He doesn’t get what your human thinks she knows.” He looked at Vek. “You tell him a churchman saw a spring on the shoulder and thought it was holy, which is true, and you tell him nothing under it. You already lied to him once about this. Now you’ll do it properly, and with my word behind you, which is the only reason you’ll live through it.”

He started up the passage and stopped.

“Keep them alive. Both. Feed them out of my store, not yours.” A pause. “And if she’s right about the singing, she doesn’t say it to me.

She says it to you. And you come down here and say it to me in the dark, where nobody sees an old hobgoblin being taught.”

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Ghazrek was at the lines with his hands in a coat.

Vek gave it to him the way he had been taught. The water on the shoulder. The churchman who knelt and measured instead of praying. The marks on the rock, the counted steps, the long look down at the road. He kept the seep and the cistern two different waters the whole way through and it was the hardest work he did all day.

“He didn’t come to pray at it. He came to price it. That water’s worth something to them, worth a cathedral sending a man a month north to put a mark on a rock. And he’s away down that road to tell a fat king in Valdenmark that gobbos are sat on something he wants.” He let the old thing carry it, because it was true and every gobbo alive knew it was true. “They don’t buy things off us. They never have. He comes back with the Duke’s men and they kill every one of us to take it, whelps and all, and call it tidying up.”

Then the ask, with the chief’s weight in it. The road was his. The seep was his. Every rider he wanted. Get the canon before Valdenmark.

Ghazrek worked his fingers through the yearling’s coat a while.

“Aye.”

He straightened and went down the line counting mounts, and Vek got one look at his face going past and it was lit. Eight years of merchant trains he was not allowed to touch, of coming home and reporting accurately and being nobody for it. Somebody had finally given him a man he was permitted to run down.

“Four riders. Best wolves. Over the shoulder and down the fall line, cut the road ahead of him instead of chasing up his arse.” He was thinking out loud in front of a rider, which was its own kind of compliment. “A soft churchman on a bought horse, day and a night

out, and he'll keep to the road because the road is fast. We'll have him inside three days."

Then he stopped and turned round and the light went off his face.

"You've got the chief behind you. I can hear it. You came up here talking like him. The road is yours, the seep is yours. That's his mouth in your face, boy, you've not got the trick of it yet." He came in close. "So Drakmoor knows. And Drakmoor sent you and not Vharza and not himself. Which means there's a piece of this that's a whelp-tender's to carry and not a chief's, and I can't think of one reason that would be true."

He did not ask. He filed it where Vek could watch him do it.

"I'll get your canon. I want him more than you do." A thin smile with nothing behind it. "But you know what's happening here. I'm being pointed. Off the mountain. Three days. Somebody always sends the outriders out when there's a thing at home they'd rather we weren't stood next to."

He whistled his four up off the line and swung onto his wolf.

"When I come back with his head, you and me have that talk. I'll have earned it by then." He turned the wolf. "Look after my mountain, whelp-tender. You've claimed enough of it."

They went out through the mouth at a lope and the pass took them.

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He spent three days doing the hardest thing he had ever done, which was think.

Ilenne started the way she had been taught because she knew no other way. The name — *Ehrendil Beldroth* — with the weight on the front of it. The three notes. The old call and answer of the Choristers, a hundred years of women in cold chapels singing at a god they had been told was not listening.

He could not do it. Not a little. At all.

She gave him a line and by the end of it he had dropped the front of it. He could not get the name's weight right. The notes came out of him like a door dragging on stone. Wenna laughed once and clapped both hands over her mouth, and he did not mind, because it had been funny and because he knew exactly what he was.

By the end of the first day Ilenne was grey with it and hiding it badly.

"It is not you," she said, and she was lying to be kind, and he could hear it.

"It is me. I'm thick. Everyone knows. Been thick my whole life." He looked at the wall. "Get the girl to do it. She can sing."

Ilenne opened her mouth to agree. He watched her nearly agree. Then she sat back and went quiet the way she went quiet before she turned a room over.

"No. Wait. Why am I teaching you this."

"Cause it's the way."

"It is my way." She said it like stepping off a ledge. "It is a hundred years of human women singing elvish words in stone rooms. That is not the rite. That is only the rite we made." Her eyes were huge. "He does not want my song. He has had my song a hundred years and he left the whole of it and came here."

She looked at him the way she had looked at the water.

"What do goblins make. What do goblins sing."

It took him a long while, because nobody had ever asked him anything like that and he had to work out it was not a trick.

Gobbos did not sing pretty. There were no chapels in Khorvenn and nothing in it was made to be beautiful. Things were made to work, fast and filthy and good enough. But at the fire at night, with the pot on and somebody with a win in them, they did the thing gobbos had always done.

They boasted.

They stood up and told it bigger than it was. The lucky throw became a throw that took two of them. The goat became a stag. It got louder and filthier and funnier every telling and the gallery shouted the good bits back, and the one who told it best got the good end of the pot. Everybody there knew it was a lie. That was not a fault in it. That was the whole of the art. He had done it himself on a rock four days ago with a joke about catching one that was awake, and eighty gobbos had roared, and the roar had got him a human.

He said all this badly, in pieces. Ilenne listened with her hand over her mouth.

“That is made,” she said. “And it is sung. And it is composed. Every telling is a new making. You do not repeat it, you build it, in front of everyone, together.” She laughed, cracked and wet. “My order sings a hundred-year-old song perfectly. You make a new one every night and put it in a room full of people and let them shout it back.” She took hold of his arm. “That is not a worse gift than mine. It is a better one.”

So that was the three days.

He learned the name. Not well. Well enough to put it in his mouth without it coming apart, and she stopped correcting him when she worked out that the god had come to a mountain of goblins and might want to be said in a goblin’s mouth.

He learned the holding by rote the way he had learned tracks. Name. Rite. Priest. Gift. Four things, until he could say them back on a stick in a cold passage.

And the two of them built one. A proper boast, made to be roared at a fire, about a mountain that took in the wrong god and kept him. Half his and half hers, filthy in the middle and enormous at the end.

On the third night Skell stood at his shoulder twisting her webbed hands.

“I can take it down. Whatever it is. I’m the only one that gets to the edge.”

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He went down on the third night and Drakmoor was waiting with his sleeves already rolled, which told him the old hobgoblin had been thinking about a door for three days.

“Say it, then.”

He said the four things in order without dropping one and was prouder of that than he would admit to anybody living.

Then he said the rest.

“It doesn’t want blood, chief. It’s not that kind. She says it’s the maker. The singer. It wants things that get made and things that get sung.” He kept going. “And I couldn’t learn her way. Couldn’t hold the words, couldn’t hold the tune. Three days and I’m still shite at it. So she asked what gobbos make. What gobbos sing.”

He let it sit.

“We boast. That’s what we’ve got. Stand up at the fire and tell it bigger than it was, and everybody knows you’re lying and everybody shouts it back and the best liar gets the good end of the pot. That’s ours. Nobody taught us that and nobody can take it off us.” He got to the thing he had carried down four ladders. “She reckons it counts. Reckons it’s better than hers, because hers is a hundred years old and sung the same every time, and ours gets made new every night.”

Drakmoor did not move.

“We wrote one. Me and her. Three days.” He looked at the arms in the dark. “It’s about a mountain that took in the wrong god and kept him. It’s about a big stupid hobgoblin who walked north when nobody walks north and found a hole with a thing in it and made a bargain and held it eight years on his own arms and never told a soul and never once let it drop.”

The water ran somewhere below.

“It’s about you, chief. First proper gobbo hymn there’s ever been and it’s a brag about you. Every gobbo in that gallery roaring it back at you. That’s the gift.”

For a long moment there was nothing.

“Say it,” Drakmoor said.

“Chief—”

“The boast.” He did not look up. “You’ve come down four ladders on a broken leg to tell an old hobgoblin he’s had it wrong for eight years. You’ve done that. Now say the thing.”

So he said it. In the dark, in a cold passage, propped on the staff of the woman whose leg he had broken, with a leg that did not work and a voice like a door dragging on stone.

He was terrible.

He lost the tune in the first four words and never found it again. He came in early on the big line because he was excited about it. His voice cracked on the filthy part in the middle, which was the best part, the part about the twelve who went north and the eleven who said it could not be done. He forgot a whole run and put it back in afterwards out of order and had to say no wait, before that, out loud, in the middle of it.

It was the worst singing that had ever happened in that mountain.

It was made, and it was sung, and it was about him.

When it was done the silence went on long enough that Vek thought he had wrecked it. Then there was a sound in the dark he had never heard in eight years, and it took him a shamefully long time to work out what it was, because Magnificus Drakmoor the Dealmaker was sitting on a rock in the deep passage with his ruined arms on his knees, crying like a whelp.

He did not apologise for it and he did not stop for a while. Vek had the sense to say nothing.

Then he wiped his face with the back of a scarred wrist and stood up and he was the chief again.

“Right. Here’s how it goes. One. The koolinth takes it down to the edge tonight. Not you. You can’t get there and you’d drown. She says it at the water and we find out if the thing wants it. And I go down

at dawn the same as always and open my arms the same as always, because I'm not gambling eighty lives on a maybe until I know.

"Two. If it takes the boast, if the price comes off my arms, then it doesn't stay a secret and it doesn't stay yours. I say it. At the fire. My mouth, in front of everybody, all of it, the water and the eight years and the lying, so everybody hears the same thing on the same night. That's how it's done here. That's the only way it's ever worked."

He let that stand, and they both knew what it cost.

"Three." His voice went flat. "Ghazrek comes back inside a day or two with a churchman's head and he's owed a talk and he'll have earned it. When I say it at the fire he'll be stood there hearing it with the rest, and he'll work out in about four heartbeats that you knew first and told him nothing." He looked at him steadily. "I can't save you from that, boy. I can be stood next to you when it happens."

He started up the passage. Stopped.

"And Vek. Nobody's ever made a song about me before."

CHAPTER 6 — AND WE KEPT HIM



He could not have got down there if he crawled, so he sent the koolinth.

“Say it at the water,” Vek told her. “Then shut up and listen. Two years it’s been making the same noise. Give it the boast and then hear what it does.”

Skell looked at him for a while.

“Nobody’s ever asked me to bring anything back,” she said.

The wolf had been wrong for three days. Not sick. Not sulking. She ate and she followed him up and down the ladders and did everything she had ever done, and every time she lay down she lay down pointing the same way, and it took him two days to work out which way that was.

Down. Into the mountain.

On the third night she took her place across the seed store door the way she had every night since he was billeted there, and she lay down with her back to the passage and her nose to the floor. Guarding the room from underneath. She had never once turned round in three years.

Her hackles were flat. That was the part he could not do anything with. Whatever was under the mountain, the wolf had never treated

it as a thing to be afraid of. She kept station on it the way she kept station on him.

When Skell went to the ladders Vosh got up and followed her as far as the top, where she could not go further, and sat, and stayed there.

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Skell came back an hour later and she was not the same.

She had to sit down on the wet stone before she could talk. Vosh pushed her big head under the koolinth's arm and stayed there, and Skell held onto her like a rail.

She had been terrible. She got to the edge in the dark and said the boast at the black water and made a worse hash of it than he had. She was no singer. She lost the tune in the second line and could not get the filthy part right because she had no timing for it and she said whole runs flat like a woman reading a tally. Halfway through she had nearly stopped from shame.

Then the water stopped.

Not quieted. Stopped. For the first time in two years the sound cut off dead in the middle of its shape and she was kneeling in silence in a drowned chamber under a mountain, and she said the silence down there was so much worse than the singing that she had nearly gone into the water and not come out.

It lasted about three heartbeats.

Then it started again, and it was different.

That was the thing she could not stop shaking about. Two years, unchanged, the same shape over and over. Now it had something new in it. Badly. Wrong, even. Like something enormous trying a sound it had never made and not quite having the mouth for it. She heard it four or five times before she ran, and each time it was a little less clumsy.

It had a piece of the boast in it.

“And it’s a call,” she said. Her teeth were going and it was not the cold. “That’s what I never had before. It goes up at the end. Every time. Up, and then a gap.” She looked at him. “It’s the first half of something, Vek. It’s been singing the first half into the dark and leaving the space for the second for two years and there’s never been anybody to sing it back.”

Vek thought about the fire-gallery, and eighty gobbos shouting the good bits at a gobbo on a rock.

A boast on its own in a cave was not a boast. It was a bloke muttering.

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Drakmoor went down at dawn and Vek did not try to stop him.

There was no stopping him and no getting there, and it was the chief and it was the thing in the water and they could sort it out between them. He sat at the top of the ladders with his leg out and his wolf and waited like everyone else who could not do anything.

Drakmoor went past without a word and was gone a long time. Longer than eight years of habit.

Vek knew before he was off the ladder, because he was not grey.

Eight years he had watched that hobgoblin come up out of the dark like something emptied out. This morning he came up steady, with colour in him, breathing like somebody who had climbed some stairs. His sleeves were rolled and his forearms were wet and there was no fresh blood on them at all. The cuts he had opened down there were closed. Not scarred over. Sealed, like the work had never been done.

He sat on the rock across from Vek and put his hands on his knees and said nothing for a while.

“It wouldn’t take it.”

He said it like somebody reporting a death.

He had knelt at the shelf and done what he had done every dawn since the second winter and opened both arms into the water, and the

water would not have it. It went in and it did not go anywhere. He put his arms in again, deeper, to the shoulder, and the cuts closed while they were under.

“It gave it back.” He looked at his own sealed forearms with something near horror in his face. “Eight years, boy. I know what a bargain is. I know what it means when a thing stops taking your money.”

Then the other half.

“And it sang at me. Not the old noise. Something else. It went through the water and through my chest and then it stopped, and it left a hole in it.” He hunted for it, a heavy old hobgoblin with no words for any of this. “Like it was waiting on me. Like a question.”

His voice went rough.

“And I knelt there in the dark like a fool with my arms in the water and I did not know what to say.”

He had not known he was being asked to sing back. He was the only one in the mountain who could not have known, because the boast was Vek’s and the four things were Vek’s and he had them in the dark from Vek and had never heard the tune.

The god had held out the first line to the one who had paid it in blood for eight years, and he had nothing to give it.

“It’s not a debt,” Drakmoor said slowly. “Is it.”

“No, chief.”

“It’s been asking me for something for eight years and I’ve been throwing money at it.” Something went across his face that was eight years wide. “And I never once asked what it wanted, because you don’t ask. You pay. That’s how you keep a thing off your back.”

He stood up. His knees cracked and this time he did not need a hand.

“Right. Tonight. The fire.”

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Two things happened before dark.

The first was that the mountain started talking. By mid-morning it was in every gallery. Does the water sound different to you. Nobody could say how. Everybody was sure. It was the kind of unease that has gobbos reaching for knives without knowing why.

The second was Vharza.

She had been Drakmoor's second for eight years and she was the only one of the Twelve who had never once asked what happened in the deep chamber at dawn, and she had not stopped asking out of a lack of curiosity. She had decided early that a chief was owed one closed door and she had held that line every day since while everyone around her guessed.

So when the water changed she did not think about the deep chamber, because she had spent eight years training herself not to. She thought about a blockage. Fouling. Something practical, in her own domain, wanting fixing.

She sent for Skell and told her to get down into the lower water and find out what was wrong with it.

Two years she had been steering the koolinth off that water, gently, four times, always with a true and good reason. She handed her the whole of it in a sentence and went back to the grain count.

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Vek spent the day on the fire, and he brought the wolf into it, because it was her god too. He could not have said why he knew that. He knew it.

The first thing Ilenne told him stopped him dead.

He had been worrying about how you teach eighty gobbos to answer a song.

"Vek. They already do it."

Every night of their lives. Somebody stood up at the fire and told it bigger than it was and the gallery shouted the good bits back, and

the better it got the harder they came in, and nobody had ever taught anybody that. It was not a skill in that mountain. It was weather. He had been trying to work out how to build a choir while living in one.

“My order spent a hundred years training women to do what your people do drunk, at a cooking fire, for fun.”

What she built was the shape. A boast was one gobbo telling it. A rite wanted somewhere for the room to come in. So she took the filthy enormous half-goblin thing they had made and cut a line into it, short and dirty and easy, landing at the end of every run.

And we kept him.

Four words. She looked ill when she had it.

“You understand,” she said, “that when eighty of them shout that, they are not describing anything. They are doing it.”

Then the wolf.

He went out to the lines in the cold with her to work out what she could even do, and she did not need working out. He hummed the refrain at her, badly, the way he did everything, just to see.

She answered it.

Not a bark and not a whine. She put her head up and gave voice on the beat, in the gap, the way the gallery would that night, and she did it first time with nothing shaped and nothing repeated, like a thing being reminded and not taught. He decided he had done that. He had three years of work with her and it was a fair thing to think.

Then the picket line answered her. All of it, one wolf after another after another, the long climbing chorus wolves had been throwing at each other across cold ground since before there were goblins to ride them.

Ilenne came out to see what the noise was and stopped in the mouth of the cave and went white.

“Vek. That is a choir.”

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He went down early and took the flat rock at the right of the fire, the one the teller stands up from. He sat with his bad leg out and his stick across his knees. The wolf lay against his hip facing the room. Ilenne sat at his left shoulder and the girl behind her, both of them small and quiet and plainly his.

Nobody told him to move. A few of them looked at it a long time.

The gallery filled. Forty, sixty, eighty. Everybody, because the water had been wrong all day and gobbos who are uneasy come to the fire. Rukh had the pot on. Somebody was laughing too loud the way people do when they do not know why they are nervous. Vharza stood at the back with her arms folded. Skell came up from the lower water late, wet to the shoulder, and found a place by the wall where she could see him, and gave him the smallest nod there is.

Drakmoor came down last, the way he always did, so that everyone was waiting.

He went to the middle. Then he rolled his sleeves up.

Vek heard it go through the gallery, that low ugly sound eighty people make at once, because they could all see the arms now in the firelight, wrist to elbow, both of them, ridged and layered and years deep, and not one goblin in that mountain had ever seen them.

“Right,” Drakmoor said. “You’ve all noticed the water’s gone strange.”

He told it plain and in order the way he ruled, with no cleverness in it. That there was water under the mountain deeper than the beds, in a drowned room nobody had ever stood in. That there was a thing in it. That he had found it the first winter and it was the reason, the only reason, that eighty gobbos had lived on top of each other for eight years without eating each other alive. That the peace they had all been quietly proud of had never been their good character.

That he had gone down every dawn for eight years and opened his own arms into the water and paid it in blood, and come up and lied to every one of them with his face, every day.

He held the arms up so the back could see.

“That’s what that is. That’s what I’ve been at while you slept.”

Eighty gobbos took it in silence. You could hear the fire.

And they took it. That was the thing. They took the secret and the lying and the eight years, because he had stood up in front of them with his sleeves rolled and said it in his own mouth, which was how it had always been done there, and there was not a gobbo in the room who did not understand paying. He had paid. He had never asked them to. Somewhere near the front an old orc said *chief* in a voice with a crack in it.

For about four heartbeats Vek thought it was going to be all right.

Then Drakmoor said the rest of it, because he had promised all of it and he was not a chief who said most of a thing.

“And I know what it is now. The human knows it. It’s got a name.”

He said it. Badly, in a hobgoblin’s mouth, out loud in the fire-gallery of Khorven.

“Ehrendil Beldroth.”

The room broke.

Eighty gobbos had just been told that the thing keeping them alive, the thing their chief had bled into for eight years, the thing under their children, was an elf god.

It came apart fast and loud. People got up. A bowl went into the fire. And out of the middle of it came Hrakka the Unfed, gnoll, one of the Twelve who walked out of Rotting Bridge, who had taken nothing off this settlement in eight years and said so often, and she was good at this.

“An elf? We’ve been fed by an elf. Our whelps have been drinking elf. And you’ve been on your knees to it in the dark for eight years and calling yourself a chief?” She turned to work the room and the room was ready for her. “That’s not a bargain. That’s a collar. He’s had us on an elf’s leash since the first winter and he never told us.”

It landed. Vek watched it land. Twenty who had been with Drakmoor half a minute before were not any more, because Hrakka had handed them a way to be furious that felt like pride.

Drakmoor stood in the middle of it with his ruined arms bare and had nothing to say. He had given them the truth and the truth was eating him. Nothing in his mouth fixed elf.

Ilenne's hand closed on Vek's arm hard enough to hurt.

"Now."

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He spat on the rock.

He hawked and spat on the stone at the fire's edge in front of eighty gobbos, which was the most goblin thing anybody had ever done to a god, and it stopped Hrakka in the middle of a sentence because she did not know what to do with it.

"IT'S NOT AN ELF GOD." Up on the stick, half off the rock, voice going. "They gave it an elf name. That's all they ever did. Milkskins found something and stuck their name on it like a mark on a sack."

And he gave it a new one, in Goblin, in front of everybody.

"I call him Vrakvenn. The wolf-singer.

"Those milkskins sit in their stone rooms singing the same boring song for a hundred years. Same words. Same tune. Never a word of it true, no life in it, no laughs in it, nothing. And he left. He walked out on the lot of them." He got his arm up and pointed at the chief standing bare-armed in the middle of the room. "And this is where Drakmoor took the wolf-singer out from under their noses —

"AND WE KEPT HIM."

It did not catch.

He heard it go out into eighty gobbos and not take. Maybe ten faces had it. The rest was swallowed, because the room was too loud and too frightened and he was still a slow whelp-tender on a rock with a

broken leg, and a new name shouted once by the wrong gobbo is only more noise. Hrakka tried to grab it back and could not either. She had overreached and somebody shoved her and two others were shouting at her now.

It hung there, ugly and turning, a second away from something nobody could undo.

He had shouted the refrain into that.

And the wolf answered it.

She came up off her belly beside him and put her head up and gave voice, right in the gap after *and we kept him*, on the beat, filling the hole the way a room is supposed to.

A dire wolf singing in the fire-gallery. Every goblin in the mountain turned.

And then, in through the mouth and down the throat from the picket lines in the freezing dark where nobody had taught them one thing, the wolf-lines answered her. All of them, one after another after another, that long climbing chorus rolling in through the rock and filling the gallery from outside.

The room went absolutely silent.

Eighty gobbos standing in a hole in a mountain listening to the animals answer a song they had not sung yet.

Skell had both hands over her mouth. Ilenne was weeping and did not know it. Vharza had come off the back wall two steps without meaning to. And Drakmoor stood in the middle of it with his bare ruined arms looking at the wolf, and Vek had never seen that face on him and neither had anybody else.

“Say it again, boy,” Drakmoor said.

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So he said it again.

He did it the only way he had ever been able to do anything, badly and loudly and with no clever word in it. He lost the tune at once. He came in early. His voice cracked in the same place it had cracked in the passage. It did not matter, because he was not singing at them. He was boasting at them, and every gobbo in that room had known how to do that since they could stand.

The twelve who went north. The eleven who said it could not be done. The hole in the mountain nobody wanted. The thing that was in the hole. The elves who had him a thousand years in their pretty stone rooms and sang him the same song every night until he walked out. The milkskins who came all that way in their good boots with their fancy hats on.

Every run climbed and every run dropped into the gap.

The first time the gap came it was him and the wolf.

The second time it was him, the wolf, and Skell against the wall.

The third time it was Drakmoor, bare-armed in the middle of the floor, with his head back.

After that it stopped being anything anyone chose.

And we kept him.

Eighty gobbos in a hole in a mountain roaring four words back at a rock, louder every pass, stamping it into the floor, banging bowls on stone. Rukh bellowing it. Prek bellowing it. The old ones bellowing it. Hrakka bellowing it, because her mouth got there before her politics did and by the time she noticed she was three rounds in and far too late. Whelps shrieking it who did not know what any of it meant.

Outside, the lines answered every time.

And the water changed.

They all felt it. In the stone and in their teeth and in the bowls. The hum came up through the floor of the fire-gallery and it was not the shape it had been for eight years. It had the goblin tune in it and it was not clumsy any more.

The room heard itself answered.

That was the moment it was real. Not because Vek said it, or the chief said it, or a human said it. Eighty gobbos felt the mountain sing back.

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Ghazrek came in through the mouth in the middle of it with the cold still on him and four riders behind him and a head in a sack.

He stopped at the bottom of the passage and looked at his settlement roaring a new god's name at the ceiling, and his chief standing bare-armed in the middle of the floor, and the whelp-tender up on the teller's rock with a wolf beside him.

Vek got off the rock and limped over to him through all of it.

"Hey, Boss. Did you get the fucker?"

Something in the old orc's shoulders came down half an inch.

"Aye."

He dropped the sack on the stone. It made the sound a head in a sack makes.

"Cut the road at the second ford, two days out. Bought himself a grey mare like I said he would and kept to the road because the road is fast. He saw us coming across the flat and tried to talk. Put his hands up and started saying words about who he was." A pause. "Made no odds. He'd already sent it."

He had stopped at a road-house the first night and paid a boy to run a letter on ahead. Three days' start. There is no catching a letter.

"I killed the man and it changed nothing. Valdenmark hears it anyway. Whatever your three weeks were, they're still three weeks."

Then he looked past Vek at the gallery, at all of it, and did not raise his voice at all.

"So that's what was at home. That I wasn't to be stood next to."

He turned back.

"I'll not do this in front of them tonight. He's earned that much and so have they. But you'll hear it now and once. You knew. Days ago. You stood at my lines and looked at me and gave me a spring on a shoulder, and I went, because I'm a rider and a rider goes." He nodded at the sack. "I rode four wolves half to death and put a churchman down on a road for you and I did it blind. Blind is how riders get killed, and I've got four out there who'd have gone anywhere I pointed them."

Nobody in the gallery had noticed him yet.

"I'm not owed an apology. I'm owed the truth, and I'm owed it in front of the same eighty that just got it about the chief. You made me nobody in my own mountain twice in one week. Once with a joke on a rock and once by sending me out the door." He picked the sack back up. "Now you'll tell me what I am."

Vek did not argue and did not defend himself, because the old orc was right.

"Okay, Boss. I'm still a whelp. You're still the best rider we've got." He got his weight onto the stick. "Let's tell 'em."

And he walked him to the rock. Through the middle of eighty roaring gobbos, on the bad leg, at his own pace, so that everyone saw where the rider was going and who was walking him. It took three goes to cut the noise. He got it.

"OI. This is Ghazrek. He's been out on the road three days while you lot were down here." He pointed at the sack. "There was a churchman coming to sell us to Valdenmark and Ghazrek went and got him. He didn't know why. He went because I asked him and I didn't tell him the truth. That's on me. That's mine. Everyone hear that."

He stepped off and held his arm out to the stone.

"Boss. It's yours."

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Ghazrek got up on the rock and did not perform, and that was why it worked.

He had spent eight years learning to report accurately, and it turned out that somebody who tells you exactly what happened, flat, in order, with nothing added, is the most dangerous storyteller a room full of liars has ever heard. He did not make the ford wider. He did not make the mare faster.

He told them about going over the shoulder in the dark. About cutting down the fall-line to get ahead instead of chasing. About lying up in the wet above the second ford a day and a night watching the road. About a grey mare coming round the bend at noon with a churchman on it who had never once looked behind him. About the man putting his hands up and starting to say words about who he was.

“And I let him get to his name.”

Eighty gobbos made a sound like a wave going out.

He tipped the sack and let it roll onto the stone and the gallery came apart, and it was for him, after eight years of watching trains he was not allowed to touch and coming home and being nobody. They gave him the refrain without anybody organising it, because it was the only shape the room had now.

And we kept him.

He stood up there and took it, and Vek watched something eight years old come off the old orc’s back.

Then he put a hand up and it went quiet, because he had earned quiet.

“Now hear the rest. I’ll not have you cheering half a story.”

And he gave them the bad half, flat and exact, the way he would report ground. The road-house. The boy. The letter with three days on it. No catching a letter.

“I killed the man and it changed nothing. Valdenmark hears it anyway, and they’ll hear that a canon of theirs died on the road doing it, which makes it worse and not better.” He let it stand. “So here’s what’s true. Three weeks. Maybe four. Then men in armour come up that pass for the water under your feet, and they’ll not be asking.”

He looked around the whole gallery. Then down at the chief with the bare arms. Then at Vek.

“Eight years I’ve watched roads and told you nothing’s coming.”

He stamped his foot on the teller’s rock, once.

“Something’s coming.”

And then he roared it himself, first voice, at the ceiling.

“AND WE KEPT HIM.”

Eighty gobbos roared it back at him like a war cry, because that is what it had turned into. Not a hymn any more. A muster.

Outside in the dark, the lines answered.

CHAPTER 7 — PAY THEIR KEEP



The gallery was still roaring behind him when he got the plank door open.

He came in on the stick with his leg gone past hurting into a kind of white noise, and he looked from one of them to the other, and he saw two milkskins sat on sacking.

That was all he saw. He would think about that afterwards.

Wenna was on her feet before the door was shut. Nineteen, filthy, wearing somebody's spare blanket, and she had her fist on her chest.

"And we kept him."

She had the tune. She had been three passes behind the room and after that she had been in it, and she had heard the hum change through the floor with everybody else.

She said something to llenne then, fast and bright, in Common, and none of it was for him.

Then she turned round and asked him something with her hands.

He did not get it. She did it again. He still did not get it, and she was shaking, and she did it a third time — two fingers to her lips, and then down at the floor, and then her eyebrows up.

Am I allowed.

She was asking to spit on the rock.

Ilenne had not moved. She was sat against the sacking with her splinted leg out and her hands loose in her lap.

She shut her eyes.

Then she opened them and said it in Goblin, so that he would have it too.

“Wenna. If you spit on that rock, you can never go home.”

The girl answered in Common. She did not stop to think about it first.

Ilenne put it into Goblin for him, and her voice did something in the middle of it.

“Sister. Neither can you.”

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“Stupid, stupid, stupid human,” Vek said. “Are you gobbo?”

Ilenne started to put it across. He kept going over the top of her.

“What if I rode into your temple. In your fancy fucking human city. On Vosh. And said can I learn your rites and your magic.”

He watched her face while that went into Common, and it went through four things on the way.

“Don’t forget everyone hates us. Everyone thinks it’s all right to kill us.” He leaned on the stick. “So don’t be so fucking stupid.”

“There’s a bunch of knights and fuckbags on their way here to kill us and rescue you. Help us figure that out. Then go and spit on your own fucking rock in your own fucking temple.”

She took it standing. She did not cry and she did not argue.

Then Ilenne got up off the sacking.

“Yes,” she said. “Everyone hates you. You are right. They will come and they will call it a rescue and you are right about that too. And you are right that she is a stupid girl who has never had to think about what she looks like from underneath. All of it. Right.”

She was close now and quiet, and that was worse than shouting.

“Two hours ago you stood on a rock and told eighty gobbos that the elves never owned him. That they only put their name on him like a mark on a sack. That he sat in their halls a thousand years and walked out because they thought he was theirs to keep.”

She let it sit.

“And now a girl says he answered me too, and the first thing out of your mouth is who is allowed.”

He had nothing.

“You cannot do the elf thing to him and expect him to stay. That is your own argument. You do not get to say who he takes. You get to say who you feed and who you trust and who you let near the water, and that is chief’s work and I will help you do it. But you do not own who hears him.” Her voice cracked. “I know. I come from the people who tried.”

She sat down because the leg would not hold her.

“She was in the room. She shouted it. Whatever he heard last night, he heard her in it.”

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Wenna got her blanket round her properly, and sat down in front of him, and started paying.

“They will not send the Duke first,” she said, through Ilenne. “They cannot. Canon law.”

A claimed manifestation had to be verified before the Church would act on it. That was what Canon Aurel Vane had been for, and Vane was dead on a road and his letter was already gone ahead of him saying I have found it and goblins hold it. But an unverified letter from a dead man was not a finding. A cathedral could not burn a mountain on it.

They had to send a second party to confirm.

So what would come up that pass was not, first, an army. It was clergy and a notary and an armed escort, and by their own law they had to be received, and shown the site, and it was their report that turned into soldiers or did not.

“They will come expecting monsters squatting on a holy thing,” Wenna said, and there was nothing warm in her face now. “They will not come expecting a priest, and a rite, and eighty who can be heard from outside the mountain.”

She held his eye.

“You do not have three weeks to prepare a battle. You have three weeks to prepare a service.”

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He went to Vosh, which is what he did when his head was too full, and put his forehead on the warm bone of her skull and shut his eyes.

She got up.

She waited until he had lifted his head, the way she did, and then she stepped over his legs and went past Ilenne and across the room to Wenna. The girl went rigid. Everyone in that mountain had been told what the wolf was. Vosh put her nose against her cheek, turned around twice, and lay down against her, hip to hip, facing the door.

Guarding her.

He had seen it before. On the north shoulder, four days ago, when she came round the rock with the flank open and a bleeding human in the scree and would not make the kill, and lay down beside her instead. And later, at the fire, he had said it out loud himself: Vosh chose you, so I chose you too, because she is never wrong.

Twice in one night he had been caught by things he had said himself. First the elves and the sack. Now the wolf.

He laughed. There was no other way for a gobbo to survive being right about a thing and wrong with it at the same time.

“What am I now, then? A priest?”

Ilenne did not laugh.

“Yes.” She let it land. “I have spent my life around priests. I know what one is. A priest is not the one who sings best — Wenna sings better than any of us and she is not one. A priest is the one who starts it. Who stands up when the room is turning ugly and puts the first line out where everyone can see it, knowing they might not come in.”

“You did that. Twice. The first time it failed and you did it again.”

“And a priest is the one who carries what it costs. You told a girl tonight she could not have him. Right or wrong, that was a ruling, and you made it in his name, and it stands until you unmake it. Chiefs rule about grain. You have started ruling about souls.” She smiled, tired and cracked. “So yes. You are a priest. I am sorry. It is a horrible job and nobody sensible takes it.”

Then the worst and funniest thing she said all night.

“And you are the only one there has ever been. There is nobody above you to appeal to. Whatever you decide about that girl is the doctrine, for as long as anyone remembers this.”

Vek looked at the girl on the floor with her hands in his wolf’s coat.

“Do what you want,” he said. He waved a hand, like a gobbie telling somebody where the latrine was. “Spit on the stone if you want. Welcome to Gobtown.”

Then he shook his head and winked at Ilenne.

That was the whole ceremony.

The girl asked where, because there was no rock in the seed store and the teller’s stone was up at the fire with eighty gobbos still round it, and Vek, who was tired and thick and did not care, said anywhere, it’s a floor, isn’t it.

Which was how the second point of doctrine got settled by accident forty seconds after the first. There is no consecrated ground. Any stone will do. A god that lives in the water under everything does not need you to walk to a special piece of it.

Wenna Dalrow got up onto her knees with a dire wolf's weight against her and spat on the floor of a goblin grain store, and said the name in Goblin, with the accent Ilenne had stopped correcting.

Ilenne made a sound like something coming loose, and said nothing at all about it, and caught the wink at the end.

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Vharza was at the cistern head with a tally-stick and a lamp, counting.

Of course she was counting. Eighty gobbos were downstairs roaring at a new god and Vharza was working out whether they could feed themselves through a siege. He had picked that spot because the water covered a conversation and it took him a moment to see she had picked it first, hours ago, for the same reason.

"Whelp-tender," she said.

She had called him Vek since the speech on the rock.

"Eight years." Not loud. She never was. "Eight years I ran this place for him, and every day I decided not to ask what he did down there. Not because I didn't want to know. Because a chief's owed one closed door and somebody had to be the one who didn't push on it." Her thumb went up and down the tally-stick. "I gave him that every day and he never knew, because the whole point of giving it is you don't tell him."

She put the stick down.

"And tonight I found out stood at the back with Prek."

She let the water run for a while.

"And you knew first. You and the koolinth and the human. A whelp-tender, an odd fish and a captive, and me at the back with the rest of them."

Then the one that was actually eating her.

"I sent Skell down this morning. Water sounded wrong, so I sent her to find the blockage. Sensible. Obvious." A short breath that was

not a laugh. “Two years I’ve kept that girl out of the lower galleries, four times, gently, always with a good reason, because he asked me to and I never asked why. And this morning I handed her the lot because I couldn’t hear what everyone else in this mountain could hear.”

She looked straight at him.

“So don’t come down here and tell me about music. Tell me this. If that thing in the water is why we don’t knife each other, then what have I been doing for eight years? The rota. The grain. Standing between the hunters and the chief. Every night going round the galleries making sure nobody’s got a reason to open somebody up.” She spread her hands. “Was any of that me? Or was it all water, and I’ve been a hobgoblin shouting orders at weather?”

“We didn’t knife each other,” Vek said. “But we’d have starved.”

And he shrugged.

It was not kindness. It was accounting, and she could check it herself, which was why it worked when nothing else would have. The thing in the water had stopped eighty gobbos opening each other up over grain and had never once put a grain in the store.

Vharza looked at the trough a long moment.

“Huh,” she said.

She picked the stick back up, which from her was practically weeping.

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He asked her whether, if she had known, she would have let it happen.

“No.” Flat and immediate. “Not like that. Not him stood in the middle with his arms out in front of everybody.” She turned to face him. “I’d have done it quiet. A few at a time. The Twelve first, then the old ones, then the rest over a month, so nobody’s ever in a room where they can find out they’re not alone in being angry. That’s how you move a settlement, boy. You never let eighty of them decide anything at once. That’s how warrens die.”

She stopped.

He watched a very hard hobgoblin follow her own sentence to the end and not like where it went.

“And it wouldn’t have worked. Would it.”

“No,” Ilenne said, very quietly.

“Because the thing wants a room.” She said it like tasting something bad. “You can’t give a god a room a few at a time. There’s no quiet version of eighty people shouting.” She sat with it. “Eight years I’ve kept this place alive by never letting everyone be in one place with one idea. And the one time it needed to happen I’d have stopped it. Would’ve been sure I was right, too. Would’ve had good reasons.”

Then she put the stick down properly and turned into the person the settlement actually needed, because that was who she was when she had finished bleeding.

Eight days short of what a hundred bodies needed to sit still for a month, because the beds got half-emptied when the nurseries moved. Eighty bodies and twelve who could fight. Hrakka would wake up in the morning having worked out she was tricked, and she would be right, and she would say so. And watch the chief. He was stronger that morning than she had seen him in five years, and she did not know what a chief like that does with all that back at once, and neither did he.

And her price, and it was one item and it was fair.

“I hear things first from now on. Not with Prek. Not at the back. If you three know a thing about that water, I know it inside the hour, or I’m no use to any of you and I’d rather go dig.”

She held her hand out, palm up, the goblin way, because a bargain wants a hand on it.

He took it.

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Then he told her the rest, and watched the best head in the mountain go to work.

She did not interrupt. She let him get all of it out, and the pitch on the end of it: if we let them look, they might not send the swords.

“That’s the first good news anybody’s brought me in a week,” Vharza said. “And it’s worse than it sounds. Sit down before your leg goes.”

One. They do not come to say carry on. A party that writes there is nothing here leaves us alone. A party that writes it is real means a cathedral knows for certain there’s a living god under a goblin mountain, and nobody in the history of the world has found one of those and left it where it was.

Two. We cannot hide it. Their man knelt at the seep and measured the rock and it is in the letter, and the hum is in every gallery and they will hear it from the pass.

Three, and this one kills us. Last night Ghazrek turned that chant into a war cry and they loved it. This morning you want me to tell those same eighty to open the gate and be polite to a priest in armour.

“Hrakka will call it what it looks like,” she said. “And what it looks like is the whelp-tender with two human pets telling gobbos not to fight humans.”

She picked the tally-stick back up.

“Whatever we put in front of those priests has to look right to people who do this for a living. And there’s exactly one person in this mountain who knows what right looks like.” She looked past him at Ilenne in the lamplight. “And she’s the one they’re coming to find.”

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He did not want to make nice and he said so.

“We don’t play nice and we don’t put our spears down. They send soldiers, we eat their bones. That’s not a bluff, that’s just true. But their god came here. He called to Drakmoor. Our chief, in our mountain.

Not their king and not their fat cathedral. He walked out on the lot of them and he came to us.”

“And that milkhide girl wants in and I said yes, because the Sister says that’s what he wants. He takes who he takes. So that’s what we tell them. Not a show. A trade. Humans can come and worship him, on our terms, in our mountain, our way, with our spit on the stone.”

He looked at Vharza.

“And they pay for it. Food. Coin. Every time.”

Vharza’s thumb started moving on the tally-stick and did not stop.

“Eight days short,” she said, to nobody. “Eight days short, and you want to charge admission.” She looked up and there was something on her face that was almost frightening because it was hope. “They’d pay it. That’s the thing. They’d pay it forever. You don’t get a living god twice, and there’s not a bishop born who’d let a rival have the only road to a real one.” Her eyes narrowed. “And the moment they pay us once we’re not vermin sat on their property. We’re the ones who hold the door. That’s a different animal.”

Ilenne had both hands over her mouth, and she had to sit down on the trough edge to say it.

“Vek. You have just invented pilgrimage.”

She said it like watching somebody whittle a wheel.

“Every great shrine in the world works exactly like this. The faithful walk, the faithful arrive, and they pay. In coin, in grain, in labour, in gifts to the house that keeps the place. That is not a cynical thing I am telling you, it is how a holy site has fed itself since there have been holy sites, mine included.” A cracked laugh. “You think you are being a bastard. You are describing the ordinary practice of the entire religious world, and you got there in one night by asking how to squeeze money out of humans.”

And then the thing that made it work.

“My Church will not accept a manifestation being withheld. That is the one thing it cannot tolerate and the one thing that brings soldiers.

But a manifestation being administered — there is law for that. Ugly law that nobody likes, but shrines have been held by the wrong people before, by heretics and foreigners and kings the Church despised, and the arrangement has always been the same for six hundred years. The custodian keeps the site. The faithful get access.”

“They want ownership. They will settle for access. They have always settled for access, because the alternative is a war they might lose and a shrine they might break.”

She stood up.

“So do not offer them a performance. Offer them what you said. A shrine with a rite and a priest and a congregation and an open door, and a price on the door. And when they ask whether a human may truly worship there, do not argue. Show them Wenna. She is the proof. A daughter of their own Church who came and heard him and joined, and was let in by your own mouth. You cannot fake that and they cannot dismiss it.”

She stopped.

“But understand what you are buying. The moment that door opens, Khorven is on a map forever. Pilgrims talk. Pilgrims write letters. There will be a road, and then traders on the road, and more people up that pass in a year than in the whole eight you have been here. You will never be hidden again.”

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The chief was in the first gallery in the grey hours with the fire banked, sat on his own with his sleeves still rolled up, looking at his arms.

He was not grey. That was the thing Vharza had warned about. Eight years of blood had come off him at a stroke and he had it all back at once and nowhere to put it.

Vek gave him the whole of it. Drakmoor listened without moving. Then he started laughing and it went on longer than was comfortable.

“Eight years,” he said, wiping his face. “Eight years on my knees to a thing I couldn’t talk to, paying whatever it asked because I never

knew what else to do. And you come up here and hand me priests.” He laughed again. “Priests I can do, boy. Priests want something. Anything that wants something can be dealt with.”

He got up and started walking and the deal came out of him in pieces.

First, we are not eight days short of anything. Vharza is right and nobody outside this fire ever hears it. You never deal from need. When they come up that pass they see full stores and fat whelps and a settlement that could sit here a year. If we eat the seed grain the week after they leave, we eat the seed grain.

Second, we offer them nothing. They ask. We open by telling them no, flat, get off my mountain. Let them get all the way to threatening us, and when they have said the word soldiers out loud in my gallery, somebody reasonable leans over and says well, perhaps there’s an arrangement. “That’s me. I’m the reasonable one. You’ll be the one who says no.”

Third, and this is the one that matters. They never see the water.

“Think, boy. What are we selling? Not the pool. Nobody sees the pool, nobody can, only the fish-girl. We sell the rite. They come to the fire, they hear him answer, they go home with it in their teeth like everybody in this mountain. And it isn’t even a lie, is it. He’s in the water. He answers at the fire. They’ll get the real thing and never stand where it lives.”

“They will bring a notary,” Ilenne said.

Everyone turned.

“An armed escort, clergy, and a notary, because the whole purpose of the party is to make a record. He will carry a seal. Whatever is agreed in front of him he is bound to write down exactly as it was agreed, and a sealed instrument out of a verification party is a thing even a bishop must argue with in the open.” Her eyes were bright. “They are bringing you the only weapon in the world that works on the Church, and they are bringing it because they cannot legally leave it at home.”

Drakmoor looked at her a long moment with enormous respect.

“Right,” he said softly. “Then here’s the price.”

Food. Coin. Every pilgrim, every time, and we set the rate. They come up unarmed or they don’t come up. Salt and iron once a year and call it a gift.

“And they write his name our way. In their record. With their seal on it. Vrakvenn. If they want the road to him, their own paper says who he is now.”

He sat back down.

“That’s a deal I can sell, boy. Best anyone’s put in front of me since Rotting Bridge.” A pause, and his voice changed. “And it’s yours, not mine. Remember I said that when it goes wrong.”

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He went down to the lines on his own, on the stick, in the grey before morning, because Ghazrek was his captain and he owed him that.

There was still a churchman’s blood dried on the orc’s boots. He looked up when he heard the stick and said nothing, because Vek had come to him and he knew it.

Vek gave him all of it, in order, the way Ghazrek had taught him. No chief’s mouth in his face this time. And what it cost. Khorvenn on a map. Forever.

Ghazrek listened all the way to the end. That was the first mercy.

“Eight years,” he said, very quietly.

“I know, Boss.”

“Eight years of my life. Every goat track on this mountain. Every place a Valdenmark surveyor stops to eat. I know the low road better than my own hands and the only thing I’ve ever done with it is make sure nobody found us.” He looked at his wolves. “And you want to put up a sign.”

He got up.

“And you’ll not just be found. You’ll be on a map. You know what happens to places on maps. Somebody comes with enough men, eventually. A hidden warren can’t be besieged. A famous one always is, and it only has to go wrong once.” His eyes were flat and yellow and he was completely correct. “Hiding wasn’t cowardice. It was the whole plan. It’s the only reason there’s eighty of us instead of a story about eighty of us.”

“We’re already found, Boss,” Vek said.

“That letter went. You said it yourself on the rock. No catching a letter. Hiding’s over. It was over the second his boy took the coin at the road-house and it wasn’t your fault and there was nothing you could’ve done. So we don’t get to pick found or hidden. We only get to pick what they find. Vermin sat on something holy — that’s soldiers. Or the ones who hold the door and set the price.”

And then the other thing.

“And you’ve spent eight years watching men you weren’t allowed to touch. That’s what hiding bought you. If we do this there’s a road, and the road needs holding, and there’s pilgrims to escort and bandits and rival lots and men who don’t want to pay. You don’t get less fighting out of this. You get all of it, in the open, forever, and everyone knowing your name for it.”

One of the four looked at the ground.

Ghazrek stood in the cold with his hands hanging and would not be talked into it.

“No. Not like this.” He turned. “You’re doing it again, boy. You’ve been at it all week. Down at the lines with the spring on the shoulder. Up top with the milkskin and your joke. Down here now. You come to me on my own in the dark and you talk me into a thing and then it’s done and everybody else finds out after.” He nodded slowly. “That’s how the chief did it for eight years. Look how that ended for him.”

He stepped in close.

“You want to put my mountain on a map. Fine. Maybe you’re right, I can’t answer the letter and I’ll not pretend I can. But you’ll not have it off me in the dark a second time in one week. Put it to the eighty. At the fire. Same as he did. And I’ll be stood right there saying no.”

He let it sit.

“If they go with you, they go knowing what it costs, and I’ll take it and hold your road and never say another word, and you’ll have it properly. And if they don’t, it was never yours to give away.”

Vek nodded.

“I’m not the same now, Boss. This thing isn’t just something in the water making us nice and ripe for the kill. It’s a massive fuck you to all of them and it’s ours. It chose us. It chose Vosh. It chose me. And it chose you too.”

“No, boy,” Ghazrek said. “It didn’t.”

No anger. Just the flat accuracy he had had since Rotting Bridge.

“I stood in that gallery same as everyone. I heard the water change. I’m not calling any of you liars, something’s down there and it answered and I’ve no argument with a thing I felt in my own teeth. But chose? Nothing has ever chosen me. Not once in my life. I’ve had what I’ve taken and nothing else, and I’m too old to start hoping otherwise because a whelp with a broken leg tells me a god’s got his eye on me.”

Then he said the thing that had been sat in him for three years.

“And that wolf of yours. I’ve said she’s an omen. Everybody knows I’ve said it. Nobody’s ever asked me which kind and I’ve never volunteered it.”

A pause.

“I’ve never once thought it was a good one.”

Then he took the job, because he was not a sulker, he was a soldier, and he had been asked for the one thing he was for.

“That I’ll do. If it comes to armour on my mountain I’m your war leader and I’ll be a bloody good one, and I don’t need a god’s

permission to be. I'll take it off the chief, mind. Or off the eighty. Not off you."

Vek started to say something and he held up a hand.

"Because here's what you've just done and I don't think you know it. You came down here and told me you're the priest now, not a wolf whelp." He let it sit. "Right. Then you're not mine."

It went through him the way the spear had gone through her.

"I told you at these lines you were still mine. Off the roster or on it, when I whistle you come. I meant it." He picked up a bridle, because he could not do this and look at him. "You can't be a priest and be somebody's rider. A rider does what he's told and doesn't ask why. You're the one deciding what things mean now. Those two don't fit in one gobbo."

He hung the bridle up.

"So you're released. Properly. Not because I'm angry, I'm not, and you did right coming down here alone and I'll not forget it." He turned round. "But don't call me Boss any more. I'll not have it be a lie between us. Chief calls me Ghazrek. So do you now."

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He did not want to plan. He wanted to sit down.

He took Ilenne to the cistern, which by then was the nearest thing that mountain had to a chapel, and got his back against the stone with his leg out and his wolf against his hip and said, just talk me through it, I dunno.

And Ilenne, who had been a captive and a tool and a healer and a theologian that week, did the one job she had actually been trained for and had not been allowed to do since she arrived. She sat with somebody who was frightened.

"He released you," she said. "That is the part that hurts and you have not said it out loud."

He found he could not answer that, and she let him not.

The water ran. The wolf's ribs went up and down against his side.

"May I tell you what you keep getting wrong? Not tonight. In general." She shifted her bad leg. "You keep trying to win arguments. You did it with Ghazrek just now and it failed and you did it with me about Wenna and it failed, and both times you were partly right and it made no difference at all. You have never won anything by being right. You won the gallery when you made them laugh. You won the naming when you spat on a rock and told them the elves were thieves. You won Drakmoor when you told him there was a song about him."

"So?"

"So stop preparing an argument. You are not a clever gobbo and you never will be, and every time you try to be one you lose. You are a teller. Go and tell them something true that they will enjoy."

Then he asked her the thing he had come down with. How do I beat him without breaking him.

She was quiet a long time.

"You are asking the oldest question there is. And the answer is that you cannot. Not really. Somebody loses tonight." Then: "But you have done it before. Once. Last night. You had the room. You had just been made a priest by eighty voices and you had every scrap of it in your hand." She watched him. "And you got off the rock and gave it to him."

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Then he did a thing he had never done in his life, which was listen to the water on purpose.

It had been there since he was eight. He was the priest now, which still sounded like a joke in his own head, so he shut up and put his head back on the stone and listened the way he had told Skell to listen.

He got water.

Cold water over stone, the same as it had sounded his whole life, a bit different since last night in a way he could not have described. No voice. No shape. No gap left open for him.

Skell heard it. Skell had heard it for two years and it held her down there. Vosh heard it, she had her head up off his leg right now. Ilenne had felt it change through a stone floor and wept.

He got water. And it hurt more than the leg.

He must have said some of it out loud, because Ilenne turned her head.

“Vek. Think about what you have built.” She actually laughed, wetly. “You told eighty gobbos that one voice alone is not a rite. That a boast on its own in a cave is a gobbo muttering. That he answers nobody on their own, he holds out half and waits for a room. And now you are sat in the dark on your own, hurt that he will not whisper to you privately.”

She let it sit.

“He is not withholding from you. You are asking him to do the one thing your entire faith says he does not do.”

He almost left it there. He was half asleep and it was not a decision so much as a refusal to be finished, the same stubbornness that had kept him conscious in the pine litter with a smashed leg, because no was not an answer he took from anybody, including a god.

He pushed once more.

And he heard the call.

Not a voice. Nothing he could carry up a ladder and repeat to Vharza. The actual shape of it, running under the cistern-noise the way a wolf’s track runs under fresh snow, so that once he had it he could not understand how he had missed it for eight years. It went out, and it climbed, and at the top it stopped, and left a hole.

And waited.

He was one gobbo on a floor and he could not fill it. He knew that. He had built the whole thing on it. So he lay there and let the gap go past him and it was the loneliest and least lonely he had ever been at the same time.

Then it came round again, and he knew the tune.

It had his boast in it. The run about the twelve who went north, the shape of the thing he and Ilenne had stitched together in a fungus cellar over three days, and the enormous slow patient thing under the mountain was singing it back. Learning it. Working at it the way he had worked at seeing for four years while people laughed at him for it.

And it was doing it wrong.

It came in early. Right where he came in early, every time, on the big line, because he got excited about it. There was a scrape in the middle where his voice cracked and it was reproducing the crack, faithfully, carefully, like a thing that had never heard the song done properly and had no idea it was copying a mistake.

It had learned the song off him and Skell, the two worst singers in the mountain.

It had a goblin accent.

He lay in the dark and laughed with his face in his wolf's fur until his eyes ran.

He spent the rest of the day at the cistern with his leg out and his back on the stone and one hand in her coat, and at some point went properly under for the first time in three days, with a dire wolf's ribs going up and down under his hand and a god he could not hear running past his ear in the dark.

Vosh did not move for four hours. Somebody put a blanket over the pair of them and did not say who.

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The fire-gallery was full and it was nothing like the night before.

The night before, eighty gobbos had been drunk on a god. Tonight they had had a day to think, and the pot was on and nobody was laughing, and they had come down to watch two of their own have it out in front of everybody, which that mountain had never done, not

once, because for eight years Drakmoor did the deciding and everyone else did the hearing.

That was new too, and it was his doing.

Drakmoor stood up with his sleeves rolled — he had not rolled them down since the night before and Vek suspected he never would again — and said eleven words.

“The whelp-tender’s got a thing to say. Then Ghazrek. Then we shout.”

Vek took the rock and told them the offer, plain. Then he got down, because that was the deal.

Ghazrek did not perform, and it worked the same way it had the night before.

“Eight years. That’s how long this mountain’s been alive and I’ll tell you the only reason. Nobody knows we’re here. That’s not a reason I made up, it’s just true. Eighty of us instead of a story about eighty of us.”

“He wants to put us on a map. A place on a map gets visited and then it gets counted and then one day somebody comes with enough men, and it only has to go wrong the once. A hidden warren can’t be besieged. A famous one always is. That’s not fear talking, that’s eight years of watching roads.”

Then he went for the theology, and he had a right to it.

“And here’s what I can’t get past. He stood on this rock last night and told us the elves never owned him. That they stuck their name on him like a mark on a sack and he walked out on them because they thought he was theirs to keep.”

A beat.

“And tonight he wants to sell them tickets.”

The gallery made a low ugly noise and it was the worst sound Vek had heard all week, because it was agreement.

“He came to us. Not to a cathedral. Not to a duke. To a hole in a mountain with eighty gobbos in it. And the first thing we do is put a price on the door and let the ones who lost him come and look for coin.” He stepped off. “I’ll hold your road if they say so. I’ll die on it. But don’t tell me it’s not what it is.”

Then Hrakka took the stone, and she was worse, because she was not reasonable and did not need to be.

Gnoll, one of the Twelve, big as a bugbear and lean as winter, and she had never eaten one mouthful that came out of Khorvenn.

“I take nothing from anyone. Everybody knows it. Eight years I’ve eaten what I killed and drunk what fell out of the sky, and there’s not one gobbo in this gallery can say I’ve had a bowl off them.” It landed, because it was true and they all knew it was true. “That’s why you’ll listen to me. I’ve got no debts. There’s nobody in here I owe.”

She turned on him.

“You know what a payment is, whelp-tender? It’s a leash with better manners. The day you take their coin you owe them a service. Then you owe them the door open on the day they want it, not the day you want it. Then a road kept nice and quiet whelps when they visit and no trouble ever, because trouble’s bad for trade.” She spread her arms. “Eight years we’ve been nobody’s servants. You want to make us doorkeepers. Gobbos in a nice clean hole holding the coats of the ones who came to spit on us.”

And the last, for the old ones.

“He had us on an elf’s leash eight years and never told us. Now this one wants to hand the other end to a cathedral and charge us rent for the privilege of being useful.”

The gallery split, and he could see the line running through it. The hunters were hers, solid, fifteen. Three of Ghazrek’s four were with him and one was looking at the floor. The old ones were with Ghazrek. But the diggers and the whelp-tenders and the mothers, the ones Vharza fed, the ones who had counted the stores, were quiet

in a way that meant arithmetic. Murga was watching him. Rukh had not moved.

About even. A little against him.

Drakmoor said nothing at all. That was deliberate.

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Vek got on the rock and gave them the joke before anyone else could use it.

“I’m the whelp-tender. Yeah. That’s me.” He leaned on the stick so they could all see it. “The slow one, on the strange wolf, that can’t track proper and can’t hit hard.”

Somebody laughed. It was nervous and he took it.

“But since I started listening to that hum under your feet and the way the wolves sing, turns out I’m the one who gets to choose which way we go. I spat on this rock last night because I chose to. I said the thing in the water’s got a goblin name.”

He let the gallery go quiet.

“And you know what it did? It started singing our songs. The way we sing them.”

“I sat at the cistern all afternoon and I heard it. It’s down there right now on its own in the dark learning my boast, and it’s getting it wrong in the exact places I get it wrong. Comes in early on the big line. Same as me. Cracks in the middle where my voice goes. Same as me.” He spread his hands. “A thousand years of elves singing at it perfect in their pretty stone rooms, and it’s spent all day practising a bad goblin boast off the two worst singers in this mountain, because that’s the version it likes.”

“It’s not learning to sound like them. It’s learning to sound like us.”

The gallery made a sound he could feel through the rock.

“So we hide? Run off up the pass every time a knight comes knocking? Or sit in the dark and snarl at them through the door?” He looked at the hunters. “Neither of those is us.”

“This is where I stand. And it’s different from my captain, and different from the great Unfed, and they’re both better fighters than me and both been here longer, and neither of them is soft, and anyone who says otherwise can say it to me.”

“But I say let them know who we are and where we are, and let them fucking come and see. We deal with them the way we deal with each other. You do your job and you expect people to try it on anyway and you’re ready when they do. That’s how it works in here. That’s all I’m asking for out there.”

“We’re gobbos. We sing this god’s song. Anyone wants to join in, no reason they can’t.”

Then the last of it.

“But if they come to our home, they behave by our rules. And they pay their keep. Just like anyone.”

That was the one that did it, and he watched it move through the room.

Because pay your keep was not a treaty and not tribute and not a leash. It was the oldest and dullest and least arguable rule any warren had ever had. You eat here, you carry something. Hrakka had built eight years of philosophy on exactly that principle, and he had just applied her own rule to humans, and she had nowhere to stand.

He watched her work it out. He watched her mouth open and shut.

Rukh stood up. Ancient, slow, the one who had put the good end of the pot down beside a wounded human without being asked. He did not make a speech, because he never had.

He said, “Pay their keep,” and sat back down.

And Murga said it, and two of the mothers said it, and then it had the shape of a refrain, and that mountain now knew exactly what to do with one of those. It went round the gallery like fire in dry grass,

banged on bowls and stamped into the floor, and half of Hrakka's hunters were shouting it before they noticed whose side it was on.

Outside, faint, the lines answered.

Drakmoor let it run and put a hand up.

"Right. It's carried, then." With his own mouth, in front of everybody, so everybody heard the same thing.

Then he looked at Ghazrek.

And Ghazrek, who had lost in public and whose life's work had just been voted away, came off the wall and did the thing that told you what he was.

"Aye," he said, loud enough to carry. "It's carried."

He looked round until it was quiet.

"I said my piece and I was beat fair and you'll not hear it from me again. But you'll hear this once. They come up that pass unarmed or they don't come up it, and I'll be the one who checks. Every one of them. Every time." His eyes came to Vek. "And the day one of them lies to me about a blade, the deal's done and it's my mountain again."

He nodded once.

Hrakka did not shout it and did not leave. She stood at the back with her arms folded and her jaw set and watched Vek the whole time, and he had no idea at all what she was thinking.

CHAPTER 8 — THE TWO WEEKS



The vote carried, and then the hard part started, which was that they had about two weeks and a settlement that had just agreed to do something none of them had ever done.

Vharza began lying the next morning.

She had diggers moving sacks between stores so the same grain got counted twice by anybody walking past, and she had told the mothers to keep the whelps out of the cold galleries and fed, visibly, in the first gallery where a visitor would see it. She caught Vek's eye once and said nothing. A hobgoblin who had spent eight years refusing to deceive her own chief was now running a deception on an entire church, cheerfully, and enjoying it more than she should.

Ghazrek had gone up. He and his four were on the shoulder and the pass and the low road and he had stopped coming down to the fire. Not sulking. Working. He was building the checkpoint, and word came back that he had chosen the bend below the north shoulder for it, which was the same bend where Vek had put a spear through Ilenne, because it was the best ground on the mountain and Ghazrek was not sentimental.

Drakmoor was a problem. He was not grey any more and he could not sleep. He was up at all hours, walking galleries, talking, planning, three moves ahead of everybody, and Vharza's warning was turning

out to be right. A chief with eight years of blood back in him and no rent to pay was a chief with nothing to spend himself on.

Skell was in the water constantly, legitimately, on Vharza's orders, and she had stopped being frightened of it. She came up with things. The shape had changed again. It had the whole first run now. It was faster. She reported it to Vek the way a rider reports.

Wenna sang.

That was the thing nobody had planned for.

And Hrakka had not spoken to him once. Her hunters went out and came back. She took nothing. She watched.

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He asked Skell first whether the seep could be stopped.

She took the question seriously, which was more than he expected, and then went away for a day and a half to actually look. She swam the lower channels and followed the run from the cistern head back into the rock and walked the outside of the mountain to the seep twice. Then she came and sat down in the seed store, dripping, and gave him a proper answer.

The short answer was no, and she could tell him exactly why.

"It's not a leak," she said. "That's what you've all got wrong. A leak's got a hole in it. This hasn't."

She laid it out with wet hands on the floor. The pool at the bottom was not a tank with pipes. The whole mountain was full of water — the drowned chamber, the run to the cistern, the beds, the flooded lower galleries, the seep on the shoulder — all one body of it, sitting in the rock, finding every crack it could. The seep was not the pool spilling. It was the same water reaching daylight at the one place on that side where the stone was thin enough to let it through.

"So you plug it, and it doesn't stop. It finds the next thinnest bit of rock and comes out there instead. Might be twenty feet along. Might be halfway down the south face where we've never had a reason to

walk.” She looked at him. “And then it’s leaking somewhere we’re not watching, and we won’t know where for a year.”

Then the part that decided it.

“And the cistern’s off the same run.” She tapped the floor. “You start damming and packing that side, you’re playing with what comes out of our own trough. I’m not doing that. Not for anything. That’s the whole settlement’s water and I’m the only one who can get in there to fix it if it goes wrong.”

You could make a mess of a mountain. You could not cork one.

What you could do, she said, was take it. “Can’t stop the water. Can build round it.” Cut the basin properly instead of letting it weep down a rock face. Put a lip on it, a channel, a step. Wall the approach. Hang a gate.

“It’d still be leaking,” Skell said. “It’d just be leaking somewhere that’s obviously *ours*.”

Ilenne liked it. She talked about how shrines get made — a spring, a step, a wall, and in fifty years nobody remembers it was ever just a wet rock. She was enthusiastic and she was right about all of it.

What she did not raise, and what Vek had no way of knowing she had not raised, was anything at all about how a verification party would read a site that had been altered before they arrived. She was tired and she had been working the queue and the connection simply did not come to her. She would have caught it on a better day.

So he was working with good engineering and incomplete law.

And there was the other thing, sitting right in front of him: Ghazrek had already chosen that exact bend. The seep was thirty feet below it on the same shelf. Two of his people were independently building things in the same place for opposite reasons — one a place to stop people, one a place to let them in.

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He put Ilenne in a room with the chief and got out of the way.

He was not there for most of it, which was the point, but he heard about it and he saw the results and both were worth having.

She refused to teach him Common.

That was the first thing. Drakmoor sat down expecting vocabulary and she told him no, and he had not been told no in that mountain in eight years, and Vek would have paid money to see his face.

“You do not need their language,” she told him. “You need their *manners*, and the two are not the same thing. If you speak good Common they will decide you are a clever animal that has learned a trick. If you speak bad Common through an interpreter, slowly, and know exactly which of them to look at while you do it — they will decide you are a *power*. And a power is a thing they have procedures for.”

So she did not teach him words. She taught him the room.

There was a moment on the third day when he stood up to leave. She had made him do something twice and told him it was still wrong, and eight years of nobody correcting him came up his back like a hackle. He got as far as the doorway.

And then he did not go.

Because here was the thing about Magnificus Drakmoor that nobody in Khorvenn had ever properly noticed, including Vek. He was, by a distance, the cleverest creature in that mountain. And he had spent eight years surrounded by diggers and outriders and whelp-tenders with nobody at all to be clever *with* — running a settlement of eighty on instinct and bluff, bleeding into a pool every dawn because he had nobody to think out loud at.

And a human woman had just told him he was doing something wrong, and explained why, and been right.

Ilenne was careful about how she put it afterwards. “He is the fastest study I have ever taught. And I do not think anyone has ever taught him anything.”

By the end of the week he had a posture. He sat. He did not stand and he did not loom. He let her render him slowly while he watched the notary rather than the priest, because she had explained that in a verification party the cleric decides what he *thinks* and the notary decides what *exists*.

He had two sentences of Common and only two, both of them terrible on purpose. One was a greeting. The other was *you are welcome to drink*.

He had the refusal. They rehearsed it. He would open with no — flat, bored, get off my mountain — and then he had learned to wait, which is the one thing goblinoid negotiation never does. Let them fill it.

And on the fifth day he asked her for something himself, which she reported with an odd expression. He wanted to know what a bishop is frightened of.

She told him. It took an hour.

He was dangerous in a way he had not been a week earlier, and Vek was the one who had arranged it, and Vharza had noticed and said nothing.

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Vek spent the week with Wenna. Guarding, mostly, which turned out to be the right call inside two days.

It was not what he expected. Nobody tried to knife her.

It was the singing.

She worked — she was genuinely good, and she had taken over the boiling and the bandage-rolling and half the queue while Ilenne did the doctoring — and while she worked she sang, because she had sung while working since she was nine and did not know how to stop.

Khorvenn had never heard anything like it. Not badly-sung boasts round a fire. Not the wolf-lines. A trained voice in a rock passage, doing a thing gobbos had not known could be done to air.

By the third day people were sitting in the second gallery outside the seed store to listen. By the fifth there were twenty of them and they were bringing their food down to eat it there, and Vharza had to move a work party because the passage was blocked.

Nobody was threatening her. That was what made it hard to police. They were just there, in numbers, wanting more, and a crowd of hungry goblinoids wanting something from one nineteen-year-old human is dangerous in a way that has nothing to do with anybody meaning harm.

Then on the sixth day one of Hrakka's hunters tried it on.

He did not touch her. He was not stupid. He stood over her while she sat rolling bandages and told her to sing something, and when she did not understand he said it louder, and when she still did not he put his boot on the bandage roll.

Testing. Seeing whose she was, and whether the rule about her was real, and whether the whelp-tender would do anything about it.

Vek was right there, because that was why he had spent the week there.

He did not get up. He could not. He took the stone out of the pouch and seated it and put it into the wall about four inches from the hunter's ear.

The crack of it in a stone passage was enormous. Grit went down the side of the hunter's face. He did not move for a full second and neither did anybody else, and then very slowly he took his boot off the bandage roll.

Vek did not stand and did not shout. He worked another stone out of the pouch and started turning it over in his fingers while he looked at him, and said it flat and bored, loud enough for all fifteen of them.

"She's mine."

And then, because he was a priest now and it was four seconds of work:

"And she spat on the rock. Same as you."

The first one they already knew. The milkskins were Vek's; everybody had heard it at the mouth. The second was new, and it went round that passage like cold water, because it made her one of them, and by the mountain's own law of a week before, agreed in front of everybody, that was now simply true whether they liked it or not.

The hunter looked at the wolf. He looked at the second stone. He looked at fifteen gobbos who had come down there to listen to her sing and were now looking at him as though he had ruined the evening.

That was the thing that actually beat him. Not Vek. Them.

He went. He did not apologise, because nobody there did, but he went, and Vosh sat back down.

Wenna had not moved. She was very white and she had the bandage roll clutched against her chest and she had understood perhaps six words of any of it.

Then she picked the roll back up and sat down and started singing again. Straight away, same place she had left off, voice thin at the start and then not.

Fifteen gobbos sat back down in the passage.

Two useful things came out of that and he had planned neither.

The whole settlement now knew the ruling — not as doctrine, not as a speech, but as a thing that happened in a passage, which is the only way anything is ever really learned there. *She spat on the rock, same as you.* By the end of the week he heard a whelp-tender say it to somebody else as though it were obvious.

And the crowd became a guard. Not out of virtue. They wanted the singing, and the singing stopped when somebody frightened her, so the sitting-in-the-passage crowd had quietly turned into the thing that protected her, and it cost him nothing and needed no rota.

Vharza noticed before he did, and gave him a very dry look, and said: "Cheapest watch I've never had to set."

One week gone. One week left.

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"I need to learn the lore," he told Ilenne. "What do these fuckers teach about the god? What's the message? What do they say about us?"

She went quiet. Then: "You should have asked me a week ago. Sit down. This will take a while and you will not enjoy the second half."

She taught him the way she had taught the chief — not the words, the shape — and made him say it back until he could hold it.

Their god was the Maker. He had not built the world, he had *sung* it, sung it into order out of something that had no order in it. Everything well-made and everything well-sung was his. That was why the marks at the cave mouth were music.

Then the part that mattered.

Their teaching was that he had stopped. After the making he withdrew, and had not spoken in an age, and the whole Church was built on top of that silence — on interpreting and preserving and ruling on behalf of a god who did not answer.

Vek worked at that for a while, slow as he was, and got there.

"So," he said. "If he starts talking again, they're out of a job."

"Yes." Very quietly. "That is what nobody at Valdenmark will say out loud. A verified manifestation does not make them stronger. It makes them *unnecessary*. Six hundred years of men deciding what he would have wanted, and then he turns up in a mountain and tells a goblin himself."

"That is why my order was laughed at for a century. Not because we were wrong. Because if we were *right*, everything they have is a chair nobody needs any more."

Then he made her tell him the other half, and she did not want to.

If their god was the god of song and making, then in their scripture goblinoids were the Discord. Not his creatures. Not made by him at all. The noise that got *into* the song while it was being sung. The wrong

note. The marring. Their own word for it meant, near enough, *the unmade*.

“That is why they do not think killing you is a sin,” she said. “It is not cruelty in their doctrine. It is *tidying*. You are not part of the music. You are the fault in it.”

Vek thought about eighty gobbos roaring at a ceiling. He thought about a thing in black water learning his cracked note.

“So their god of songs,” he said slowly, “come and lived with the noise. And started singing like it.”

Ilenne put her face in her hands.

“Yes.”

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And then she could not find him the weapon.

She tried for two days. He watched a scholar with no books, a year off the road, running on memory and no sleep, trying to produce the exact thing she knew existed — a verse, a citation, something she could put in front of a notary, *because they will not care what I argue, they will care what I can quote*.

She could not get it. She circled it and got fragments and got the sense of it and could not land the words, and it made her angrier than the spear had.

“It is *there*,” she said, hitting her own knee. “I have known it since I was fifteen. I cannot get it whole.”

And then Wenna said it.

From the corner, where she had been rolling bandages and listening to a conversation she was only half following for two days. About nine words of Common, flat, without looking up, the way you say a thing you were made to memorise and have never once had cause to think about.

Ilenne went absolutely still.

Because that was it. Wenna was fourteen months out of novice training, and novices are drilled — catechism, verse, chapter, hammered in by rote before anybody lets them think. Ilenne was a scholar and scholars synthesise. The girl still had the text nailed to the inside of her skull.

Ilenne made her say it three times, and then translated it slowly, and her hands were shaking.

“He turned His face from the ordered choir, and went out into the noise.”

“They teach it as the *Silence*,” she said. “It is the verse for his withdrawal. He turned away from the world in sorrow and went into the void. That is how it is preached. That is how it has been preached for six hundred years.”

She looked up.

“But that is not what it says.

“It says he *left the choir* — the ordered singing, the perfect thing, the elves — and he *went out into the noise*. On purpose. Toward it.” Her voice cracked. “And their own word for the noise is the word they use for *you*.”

Six hundred years of a church reading its own scripture as a god’s despair, when it read at least as well — better, more literally — as a god’s choice of address.

Vek did not need the doctrine. He had lost every detail of it as she gave it to him.

He only needed the one line, and that one he would keep.

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He spent the last week on four things and three of them failed.

The leg did not knit. Ilenne reworked the splint and packed it and made him keep it up, and it simply did not take, and some of that was him, because he had spent a fortnight walking on it up and down ladders when she had told him not to, and she said so. It came up to

three-fifths of a working leg. He could stand a while. He could walk slowly on the stick. He would face the verification party leaning on the healer's staff.

Ilenne's magic was gone.

He asked her what her magic actually was and she went very still, and he understood he had walked into something. She was a trained cleric of a real god with real divine workings, and she had not attempted a single one since the day she came up that mountain.

She tried, for him.

Nothing came. Not weak. Absent.

And the reason was the one he already knew in his bones: she was a priest with no order, no rite and no congregation, praying alone. The same wall he had hit at the cistern. Her power had never come from being devout. It had come from being part of something, and she had left that on the floor of a grain store.

The fix was obvious and she could not say it out loud.

And he failed to hear the god again. He had asked four times now and got it once, and he kept asking, and it kept not being that kind of god.

The one thing that worked was the wolves.

He could not ride, so he sat at the lines with his leg out and Vosh beside him and listened the way he had told Skell to listen. And what he found was that the wolves were not making one noise. There was a shape to it. One opened, and the others did not just join in — they came in *underneath*, and held, and the first one climbed off the top of them.

Call. And answer. They had been doing it his whole life, out on that flat, every night, and he had ridden past it for three years and heard wolves howling.

By the end of the week he could start it. He could not command them — he could not have made them do anything — but he had learned the note that opened it, and if he gave them that, sixteen

picketed dire wolves and one bonded one would come in under him and hold, and the sound would come into the mountain through the mouth and down the throat and fill the fire-gallery from outside.

He could do that on purpose. Nobody in the history of that settlement had ever been able to do that on purpose.

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Hrakka was not in the mountain.

There was a fire on the flat outside the mouth, thirty paces past where the wolf-lines ended, in the cold, and it was hers. Her own wood, that she had cut. Her own meat on it, that she had killed. Eight hunters round it and not one of them eating anything that had come out of Khorvenn.

He came out on the stick and it took him a long time and everybody watched him do it. Vosh came as far as the edge of the firelight and stopped, because gnolls and wolves have an arrangement and it is not friendship.

Hrakka did not get up. She did not tell him to sit either.

“Whelp-tender.”

“Hrakka.”

She turned the meat. A long time. The fire was small and mean and efficient, like everything about her.

“You beat me with my own words,” she said at last. “In front of everybody. *Pay their keep.*” She looked up. “That was well done. I’ve been chewing it a fortnight and I still can’t get round it. You took the one thing I’ve got — the one thing nobody in that hole can say to me — and you handed it to *humans.*”

“Wasn’t trying to—”

“You *were.*” No heat. “You’re not clever, but you’re not stupid either, and I’m tired of people using the first to hide the second.” She turned the meat again. “So. Say what you came for.”

And before he could, she told him the thing she had been sitting out there with for a fortnight.

“Do you know what it’s like,” Hrakka said, “being the only one who hasn’t changed?”

He did not answer.

“Eight years I’ve watched that mountain go soft. Not fast. You wouldn’t see it if you were in it.” She stared into the fire. “First year we came north, Rukh gutted a lad over a ration and nobody thought twice. That’s *normal*. That’s how it’s always been, everywhere, since there’ve been gobbos. Now there’s a pot on all night for anyone who turns up and they hand the good end to a *human*.” A hard breath. “And nobody remarks on it. That’s the bit. Not that it happened. That *nobody remarks on it*.”

“You all changed and none of you noticed and I watched every step of it.”

She looked at him properly.

“So don’t tell me I’m the one that’s wrong, boy. I’m the only fixed thing on this mountain. Everything else has moved and I’m stood exactly where I was, and somehow *that* makes me the problem.”

She was right about every observable fact and wrong about why, and she could never find out, because she drank from streams and everybody else drank from the trough.

He had no idea what to do with that. He had never been able to read a face in his life and he knew it.

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“Here’s where I’ve landed,” she said, and set the knife down. “I don’t say you’re lying. I heard the water change same as everyone. Something’s down there. I’m not a fool.

“But I never spat on that rock. And I never will — not on somebody’s *say-so*, not because eighty gobbos were shouting and my mouth got there first.” Her jaw worked; that was still raw. “I take

nothing from anyone. Not food, not water, not a god off a whelp-tender.”

She leaned forward.

“So prove it. Not to them. To *me*.

“Let it answer *me*. Not the room. *Me*. I’ll stand where you like and I’ll listen, and if that thing says one word to Hrakka the Unfed I’ll spit on your rock in front of the whole mountain and I’ll hold your road and I’ll never say another word against you.”

She sat back.

“And if it won’t — then it’s a thing that talks to crowds and not to gobbos who ask straight, and I’ll know what I’m dealing with, and so will you.”

She had asked him for the one thing his whole faith said was impossible.

It did not do private audiences. He could not get one and he had tried four times. Drakmoor had knelt alone for eight years and got a bill. Skell had sung alone and it had only started *learning*. Ilenne was a real cleric and her magic had gone silent for want of a congregation.

The god only ever answered a room.

And the only way Hrakka got a room was to stand in one with everybody else — which meant taking something from somebody, which was the one thing she had built her entire life on never doing.

That was the trap, and he had not set it. She had walked into it herself and did not know it was there.

Eight hunters were watching him. The fire popped.

“You ever stood on the flat rock,” Vek said, “and told a tale to the room?”

And then the part that mattered, and he did not know he was doing it.

“You wouldn’t be *taking* anything, Hrakka. You’d be *giving*.”

He told her what the first song had been — three notes, a call, put into the dark for years and years with nobody to sing it back, and answered at last the second they answered it. “So tell us a story. Get on the rock and tell us about Rotting Bridge and what *you* did in it. Eight years and I’ve never heard it off you once, and there’s not a gobbo in that mountain’s got a tale like it.”

“You want it to say something back? That’s the tale that does it.”

She was quiet a long time.

“Giving isn’t taking,” she said. Slowly. Testing it the way you test ice.

“No.”

“...No.” And he watched a gnoll who had built eight years of iron discipline on one rule find the door in it she had never noticed, and understand she had been stood next to it the whole time.

Then, quieter, and it cost her:

“Nobody’s ever asked me.”

And there it was. Eight years. One of the Twelve who walked out of Rotting Bridge and went north when nobody goes north, same as Ghazrek, same as Drakmoor, same as Vharza — and every one of *them* had got something out of it. Drakmoor got the chief’s rock. Vharza got the settlement to run. Ghazrek got the screen, and last week he had got sung.

Hrakka had got to be the one who takes nothing, and everybody had learned to leave her alone, and being left alone was exactly what she had asked for and exactly what had been eating her for eight years.

She had never wanted to be fed. She had wanted to be asked.

“It’s not a small tale, boy.” Her voice had gone rough. “Twelve of us came off that bridge. There were nineteen went onto it.” She looked into her own fire. “There’s seven I’ve never said out loud. Not once. Not to Drakmoor, and he was stood next to me for two of them.”

“Then that’s the one,” Vek said.

She turned the meat again and did not look at him.

“When.”

Not *if*.

“Before the milkskins come,” he said. “Has to be. It’s ours. That one’s got nothing to do with them and I’ll not have them stood in the room for it.”

And that — that he did not want the humans to see it — was the thing that settled her, and he watched it land. She had assumed he would want her tame and on display for the priests.

“Tomorrow night, then.” She picked the knife back up. “And whelp-tender. If it doesn’t answer, I say so. Out loud, in front of all of them, and you don’t get to talk me round after.” The old flat hardness came back over her like a lid. “I’ll give the tale. I’ll not give the verdict.”

Fair. Fairer than he deserved.

He went back in on the stick, slower than he had come out, with his wolf falling in beside him at the edge of the firelight.

Tomorrow night one of the Twelve would get on the boast-teller’s rock for the first time in her life and tell the mountain about the seven who did not come off the bridge, and ask a god a straight question in front of everybody.

And he had no idea what would happen, because he was the worst priest that had ever lived, and he had asked four times and been answered once, and he had never in his life been able to make that thing do anything at all.

CHAPTER 9 — THE OPEN HAND



The night before they came, Hrakka the Unfed stood on the boast-teller's rock for the first time in her life and did not know what to do with her hands.

There was no pot on. Rukh had taken it off and nobody had asked him to, which was how the mountain said this one was different. Eighty of them and no humans; Drakmoor had told the humans to stay in the seed store and Vek had told them why, and Ilenne had not argued, and it was that — the fact that he did not want the priests in the room for this — that had settled her the night before, out at her own fire on the flat, when he came to ask.

She did not open. She had no idea how, so she just started talking, flat, like a report, and that was worse than a bad opening because it made everybody lean in.

"Nineteen went on that bridge," Hrakka said. "Twelve came off. I've never told anybody the other seven and I've had eight years to do it in."

Then she said their names.

One at a time, and after each one she said what they did. Not how they died. What they did. The one who went back for a standard that was worth nothing to anybody because it was theirs. The one who held the left for a count of forty on his own so the rest could get onto

the stones — she had been there, she had counted it, and she said the number out loud.

The two who died stood next to Drakmoor.

She said that one to him, from the rock, in front of everybody. Named them. Told him where they were and what they had been shouting. And eighty gobbos watched the chief of Khorvenn put his ruined arms on his knees and his head down, because he had not known. He had been fighting. He had never known who was on his left and he had carried it eight years and never had the nerve to ask her.

It was not a boast. It was made, and it was sung, and it was new — she fell into a rhythm about the third name and never came out of it — and it was the first goblin lament that had ever been performed, and she had made it up standing on a rock because nobody had ever asked her for one.

The room did not shout anything. There was no refrain in it and nobody tried to put one there.

They came in underneath. A low sound from everywhere that was not words, the noise you make when a thing is true, and it held under her the whole way — one opens, the rest come in under and hold — the exact shape Vek had spent a week learning off animals, done by instinct, in grief, by a settlement that had needed wolves to teach it.

Then she got to the end of the seven and stopped.

“Right,” Hrakka said. Her voice was not steady. “You in the water. I’ve never taken a thing off you and I’m not starting now. I’ve just give you seven names nobody’s ever said, and that’s mine, and it’s the only thing I’ve got.”

A long breath.

“So say something back. To me. Not to them.”

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Nothing happened.

Ten heartbeats. Twenty. Eighty gobbos in a hole in a mountain and the only sound was the fire and somebody's whelp shifting.

And Vek could have made something happen.

He had learned the note that week. He could put it up the throat and sixteen dire wolves on the picket lines would come in underneath and hold, and it would roll in through the mouth and fill that gallery from outside, and every gobbo in the room would hear the mountain answer Hrakka the Unfed. She would spit on the rock. She would hold his road. She would never speak against him again.

He reached for it.

He did not hesitate, and that was the part he would think about afterwards.

And it did not come.

His voice was wrecked from a fortnight of shouting on rocks and it was indoors and the whole mass of the mountain stood between him and the lines, and the note came out of him thin and cracked and landed on the fire like a dropped bowl.

And the wolves did not answer, and here was why, and he understood it before the night was out.

The wolves come in underneath a room that is singing.

That was the whole shape of it. That was the thing he had built the faith on. And there was no singing in that gallery — there were eighty goblinoids sat in a grieving silence with seven names in the air, and there was nothing for the animals to come in under.

He had made it himself. He reached for the trick anyway and the thing he made refused him.

Nobody noticed. To the room it was the whelp-tender making a small noise and stopping.

And the god said nothing either.

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Hrakka waited longer than she needed to. That was the part that hurt. She gave it every chance.

Then she nodded once, to herself.

"It doesn't answer. Not to me." Flat, and steady, and not cruel, which made it ten times worse. "Whatever's in that water, it'll talk to a crowd. It'll not talk to a gobbo who asks straight and takes nothing." She looked round the gallery. "You lot can make of that what you like. I've give my tale and I'll not give the verdict, and that's me done."

She got off the rock.

And then Drakmoor stood up, and did not take the rock, and said it to her across the fire with his arms bare.

"Hrakka. You said two of them died stood next to me. I never knew who they were. Eight years I've had of not knowing who was on my left and I never asked you, because I'd have had to say out loud that I didn't know." He swallowed. "So."

He thanked her. In front of everybody. Nobody in Khorvenn had ever seen him do it.

Then he said the true thing, which was the only thing in the room worth anything that night.

"Your god didn't answer you." A long pause. "We did."

"Eighty of us. You were up there and we come in under you the whole way and not one of us decided to. It just happened, because it was true, and there's not a gobbo here could've stopped themselves." He looked round. "You wanted something to answer you straight. Something did. You just weren't listening for it, because you'd decided in advance what counted."

Hrakka stood there. She did not argue and she did not agree.

"...Huh," she said.

And she went out through the mouth to her own fire on the flat, in the cold, and did not spit on the rock, because she had said she would not and she did not.

By morning her hunters had left four deer at the mouth without a word to anybody, which was the first thing Hrakka the Unfed had ever given that settlement, and Vharza counted them into the store with a very strange look on her face.

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Vek lay awake with his leg throbbing and his wolf against his back, and thought about the fact that he was the only creature alive who knew he had tried it, and that the only reason he was not a fraud was that he had not been good enough to be one.

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They came up the low road at midday.

Twenty-one. A Canoness on a grey horse who had not spoken to anyone below her own rank since the low road. A notary on a mule with a locked writing-box and a seal on a chain. A knight and twelve men-at-arms in mail on real horses. Four servants walking.

And a Chorister called Damaris, who knew both of the humans in that mountain by name.

“They did not send an investigator,” Ilenne said, when the description reached her, and she went white. “They sent a judge.”

She said the other thing too, about the small damp man on the mule that nobody in the party looked at twice.

“He is the only one who matters. Look at him when you speak and it will unnerve every one of them.”

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At the bend, Ghazrek did his job.

He stopped them above the seep, on his ground, at the place he had chosen — the same bend where Vek had put a spear through a woman seven weeks before — with four riders and eleven of Hrakka’s hunters that he had borrowed and never mentioned to anybody.

He told twenty-one humans that nobody came up the pass carrying steel.

Ser Halvard Crane told an orc that the Church's escort did not disarm for vermin, and there was a long silent minute on a mountain-side with twelve mailed men and fifteen goblinoids and nobody's hand anywhere good.

And Ghazrek, who had lost a public vote a fortnight before and had not said one word about it since, did exactly what he had said he would do at the fire.

He told them to go home. And he sat down on a rock.

Solm said he actually sat down.

It was the Canoness who folded. She sat her grey a while, looking at a wet streak of rock that a dead man's letter had told her about, and then gave the order in two words, and twelve men-at-arms handed their swords to goblins on a mountain.

And the notary wrote it down.

That was the part Ilenne seized on when the runner reached her. The first entry in the official record of the whole affair was that the custodians set a condition and the Church complied with it.

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Vek did it right, and the difference was everything he had learned two nights before when it failed.

The wolves come in underneath a room that is singing. So he did not start with the wolves.

He was on the rock when the first of them came off the ladder and he did not look at them at all. He put the refrain up — four words, no explanation, into a gallery of eighty gobbos who had been waiting all morning for something to do with their nerves.

They took it in one pass.

And then he put the note out, up the throat, toward the mouth, with the whole gallery roaring underneath to carry it.

Sixteen dire wolves on the picket lines answered.

It came back down through the mouth and along the rock, that long climbing chorus, one opening and the rest coming in underneath and holding, filling the throat and pouring into the fire-gallery from outside — and it arrived on the verification party of Valdenmark while they were still on the ladders.

There is no worse place in the world to be than halfway down a ladder in the dark of a strange mountain when that starts.

Vek watched twenty-one humans come off the last rungs, and got to see on each of their faces exactly what they were.

Crane went for a sword a goblin had taken off him at the bend, and his hand closed on nothing, and every gobbo in the gallery saw him do it.

The men-at-arms bunched.

Damaris stopped dead at the bottom of the ladder with her hands at her mouth, and she was not frightened. She was weeping. She had walked north for months on a claim her order had been laughed at for a century for making, and she had walked into a mountain that was singing an antiphon, and whatever her Church said about the Discord, she knew the shape of a call and response when she heard one and had never heard one that size.

The Canoness did not react at all. She came down, straightened her habit, and looked round the room — the fire, the stores, the fat whelps, the number of bodies, the exits — the way you value a property. Then she found the rock, and the goblin standing on it with a stick and a wolf, and her eyes stopped.

And Brother Edrin Poole put his writing-box down on a rock without being told, opened it, and started writing.

He was the only one of them doing his job. Vek looked at him instead of at her, the way Ilenne had taught him, and the notary

glanced up and caught him at it, and for a quarter of a second a small damp man from Valdenmark and a goblin with a broken leg looked straight at each other and each understood exactly what the other one was for.

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Drakmoor did not get up. By not standing he made twenty-one humans walk to him.

"I am Miriam Vault," she said, and waited, and when nothing happened said it again through her interpreter.

Drakmoor let the silence sit exactly as long as he had been taught.

Then he gave her the two words he had been practising for a fortnight, in Common, badly, on purpose.

"Go home."

And sat back.

She turned and spoke past him to the rock, which was the first mistake anybody in her party made, and Vharza's eyes narrowed because she had seen it too.

"You. You are the one they call priest."

"Me?" Vek shrugged. "I'm a whelp-tender."

And then he got down off the rock and walked to her, and it took a while.

That was the whole move. He was small and young and his right leg did not work, and he crossed that gallery on the healer's staff at the speed of a broken thing, in silence, with a dire wolf pacing him. Twenty-one humans had to stand and wait for him. The Canoness had to watch a crippled goblin come to her one step at a time and could not hurry it and could not look away, and could not decide whether she was being shown weakness or being made to kneel.

Poole wrote something down.

Vek stopped in front of her and looked up.

“What do you want?”

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“Direct,” she said. “Good.”

And she answered him, which surprised her own party, because a judge who explains herself has already conceded that somebody is owed an explanation.

She would see the site. She would hear what they claimed happened here. And she would decide, in the name of the Church of Valdenmark, whether what was in this mountain was a manifestation of Ehrendil Beldroth.

“Brother Poole records everything. What he writes is what happened, and nothing that is not written happened. You should understand that before we go further, because it will matter to you more than to me.”

She had handed him the map because she did not believe he could read it.

Then she did the thing she had come to do, immediately, before anybody was settled.

A Sister named Ilenne Vasch, seven weeks unheard of. A novice named Wenna Dalrow, three. A canon of her cathedral, Aurel Vane, murdered on the Valdenmark road eleven days ago with his throat opened.

“So. Before we discuss gods.” Her eyes came down. “Where are my people?”

Drakmoor moved one finger against his knee. It meant: this is yours, boy.

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“Well, we took his head,” Vek said. “Not just his throat. His head. It’s in a sack.”

“He ran. Left the girl on the mountain on her own with us and ran down the hill for his horse. And we didn’t want you lot up here.”

Then, before anybody could breathe:

“Wenna’s here. She’s been helping us. She sings beautiful.”

He turned his head and beckoned her forward, and said to the small damp man with the seal, looking right at him and not at the Canoness:

“Write that down, brother.”

It came apart for four seconds. Crane got two steps before one of his own men caught his arm. Damaris made a sound.

And the Canoness was, for the first and only time, genuinely off balance, because she had come up that mountain with a hundred prepared answers to denial and did not have one for yes, and here is how, and write it down.

Poole wrote it down. Fast, all of it, head down, pen going, and what went into the official record of the Church of Valdenmark at that moment was that Canon Aurel Vane had abandoned a nineteen-year-old novice alone on a mountainside and fled; that the goblinoids of Khorvenn had killed him for coming uninvited; and that the novice was alive, in the room, and being produced voluntarily.

Ilenne had said the notary decides what exists. He had just made three things exist.

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Wenna came out of the passage with fifteen gobbos following her because they always did now, in goblin-mended clothes and somebody’s blanket, thin and filthy and entirely unharmed.

Damaris said her name.

And Wenna looked at her own order, and then at the Canoness, and then very deliberately at Brother Poole, because she had spent a fortnight listening to Ilenne coach Drakmoor and she had learned.

She said she was left. She said that first. That Vane had knelt at the water and not prayed at it but measured it, marked the rock, counted his steps to the road; and that when a stone came down the slope he ran, and did not call her, and did not come back, and she was still on her knees at the pool when the goblins found her.

She said she was not harmed. She said it plainly and said it again when Poole asked her to. Not touched. Not starved. Fed out of the chief's own store. That she had been working — the queue, the bandages, the sick children — and that a goblin had put a sling-stone in a wall beside a hunter's head for standing over her, and that she had been safer in this mountain than she had been on the road with a canon of their own cathedral.

And then she told them the rest.

That she had heard him. At the seep, before any goblin touched her, on her own, and had wept, and had never been so certain of anything.

That she had heard him since, in this gallery, in the water under the floor, answering eighty goblinoids who sang at him badly.

That nobody had made her do anything. That she had joined them of her own will and would do it again.

Then she said the verse, in the original, the way it had been hammered into her at fifteen, and every cleric in the party knew it cold.

He turned His face from the ordered choir, and went out into the noise.

"We are taught that as the Silence," she said, to the pen. "It is not the Silence. It says he left the choir. It says he went out into the noise. Toward it."

She looked at her Canoness for the first time.

"And your own word for the noise is your word for them."

The gallery had no idea what had happened. Eighty goblinoids had watched a human girl say some human words and could tell from the faces of the other humans that something enormous had landed.

Brother Poole had stopped writing.

That was the frightening thing in the room. He sat with his pen up, looking at the page and then at the girl, and asked her — quietly, the first time he had spoken since he arrived —

“Say the line again, sister. Slowly.”

And wrote it into the record of a verification party with the goblin reading attached, spoken by an ordained novice of the order that had made the claim.

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Then the Canoness moved, and she was very good.

“Brother Poole. Note also that the witness has been in the custody of these creatures for four weeks. Note that she is the sole survivor of her party. Note that she was nineteen and unaccompanied and frightened, and that captives commonly come to love what they cannot escape. Note that her testimony is offered in the presence of her captors, in their hall, with their armed men at every exit.”

“I am not lying,” Wenna said.

“I have not said you are lying, child. I have said your testimony is worthless, which is a different thing, and kinder.” She turned back to Vek. “A broken girl and a dead man’s letter. That is what I have.”

Then: “So. Produce Sister Ilenne Vasch. Unless she is dead, in which case say so now and we will all save a great deal of time.”

Drakmoor’s finger did not move.

*
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“Sister,” Vek said, without looking round, and waved her forward with the back of his hand the way you wave a rider up.

And as she came past him he did two things.

He handed her the staff. Her staff, the one he had gone two hours up a mountain for and broken his leg fetching and leaned on every day since. He put it in her hand and let go of it, and then he was standing

on a leg that did not work with nothing under him, and it hurt, and he kept his face still.

And he put his fist to his chest. Her sign. In front of her entire Church.

And he smiled at her.

Poole wrote for a long time. What he had watched, in front of twenty witnesses, was a goblin hand a supposedly captive woman a five-foot ash staff and then take away his own ability to stand, and stand there smiling at her while she held it.

You cannot fake that. It is not an argument. It is a thing that happened.

*
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Ilenne Vasch walked out into the firelight on her own two feet with her own staff, and eighty goblinoids moved aside for her without being asked.

She looked at the Canoness of Valdenmark and said, in perfect Common:

“Miriam.”

Not your Reverence. Her name.

“You said a broken girl and a dead man’s letter. You have neither. You have the claimant. I am Ilenne Vasch. It was my report Aurel Vane came north to verify. Verify it.”

And she lost.

The Canoness took her apart. Not cruelly — procedurally, which was worse. She let Ilenne get three sentences into the theology and then began asking the questions a judge asks. How long have you been in this mountain. Who feeds you. Who decides where you sleep. Were you injured by these creatures. By whom specifically. Is that creature in this room.

Ilenne had to answer yes four times, and *the boy with the wolf* once, and Vek watched a scholar with no books and no sleep get walked backwards into a corner by a professional.

“You were speared, held, and kept. For seven weeks. Sister, I do not doubt you believe every word. I doubt that you are free to say otherwise, and so will Valdenmark, and so will the record.”

Ilenne stopped.

And Vek watched her understand that she could not win it with words. That she had spent her whole life in a world where the argument decides, and had just been beaten by somebody better at arguments in front of the only thing that mattered.

So she stopped arguing.

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She had not been able to do it for seven weeks. She had tried, alone, in a store room, at his asking, and got nothing — not weakness, absence — and had carried it since as proof that she was damned.

She had never been damned. She had been alone. A priest with no order, no rite and no congregation.

She was not alone now. She was stood in the middle of a fire-gallery with eighty members of a rite she had helped build, in a mountain with a god in the floor, and the conditions of her own faith were met for the first time since she left home.

She turned her back on the Canoness of Valdenmark, mid-sentence, and went to Vek.

And knelt down in front of a goblin, with her staff in her hand, and put both palms on his ruined leg.

And Channelled.

It went through the bone like cold water into a dry crack. It was not gentle and it was not a warm light. Something enormous and impersonal arrived in his leg, found the place where the mountainside

had broken it and where a fortnight of walking had made it worse, and pulled it straight.

He made a noise he would be ashamed of for years. Vosh was on her feet. The whole gallery was on its feet.

And then it stopped, and he was standing on it. Both feet. No stick.

The staff was in her hand and his leg was underneath him, and he shifted his weight onto it because he could not believe it, and it held.

Nobody in that gallery made a sound. Eighty goblinoids who had watched him hobble up and down ladders for a fortnight were looking at him standing.

Crane had gone the colour of ash. Damaris was on her knees. The Canoness was staring at Ilenne's hands.

And Brother Edrin Poole, the small damp unregarded man who decided what existed, was writing so fast his pen caught, and what went into the official record of the Church of Valdenmark was that an ordained Sister of the Chorister order, standing inside a goblin congregation, had invoked and received a divine miracle of Ehrendil Beldroth in the presence of twenty witnesses and a sworn notary.

Not a goblin's word. Not a broken girl's testimony. Not a dead man's letter.

A working, done by their own clergy, in front of their own judge, recorded under their own seal.

Ilenne got up off her knees using her own staff and turned to face her Canoness and did not say one word, because she did not have to any more.

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“Oi. Judge.”

Vek said it standing on two legs, which nobody in that gallery had seen in a fortnight, and the room went quiet for that alone.

“I heard a lot of words. Empty human words. A lot of talk.”

“You heard us sing. And you’ll not know this, so I’ll tell you: until I met her —” he pointed, straight-armed, at Ilenne with her staff — “there wasn’t a gobbo on this mountain had any use for a song. Not one. Not for singing, not for you, not for any of it.”

“And now, because of her, and because of the song — our whelps don’t cough so bad. And we’re not chopping you up and feeding the bits to the maggots. And we’re talking.”

“That’s more than’s ever happened between gobbos and humans. Ever.”

“So shut it with your words.”

It got through because it was the only thing said in that gallery all day that nobody could dispute. Not theology. Not law. Not testimony a judge could call worthless. Two facts, said flat by a small goblin standing on a leg that had been broken twenty seconds before. Fewer children die here now. You are alive and being spoken to.

The Canoness had an answer for a miracle. She had none at all for we did not eat you and the babies stopped dying, because the first was happening to her personally as she stood there and the second was the kind of thing the Church had spent six hundred years claiming as evidence of grace when it happened to anybody else.

Poole wrote it down.

“Chief. You got anything else you want to say to these fuckers?”

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Drakmoor got up.

He did not loom and he did not shout. He walked to the middle of the floor and waited — waited, the thing no goblinoid negotiator has ever done — until the silence was so heavy that she had to fill it, and she opened her mouth—

—and he spoke first, in Common, badly, on purpose, looking not at her but at the notary.

“You are welcome to drink.”

Four words. The second of the two sentences he had been practising for a fortnight. And he let it sit, and let them work out what it meant: that he was not offering hospitality, he was offering access to the water, in front of a sworn seal, from the custodian's own mouth, unprompted, before anybody had asked him for it.

Then he sat back down on his rock and folded his ruined arms and said, through his interpreter, flat and bored:

“Now. Somebody tell me what it's worth to you.”

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Vek stayed on his rock. It was the chief's floor.

He never argued theology. She tried to take him there twice and both times he answered with a number — how many bodies in this mountain, how many winters, how many whelps buried before the healer came. He was a chief discussing a property he administered. She was a judge who had come to rule on a miracle and found herself haggling with a landlord.

He watched Poole. Every time she said a thing that mattered he looked at the notary, and after the third time Poole began looking back — and once, when she overstated something, Drakmoor did not object at all. He tilted his head toward the writing-box and waited, and she corrected herself.

And he let the silences run. She filled them three times, and each time gave away a little more of what she wanted.

It nearly broke on the site. She came back to it and would not move.

“I will see the site.”

And Drakmoor, with nothing prepared, stood up and rolled his sleeves the rest of the way and held out both arms, wrist to elbow, ridged and layered and eight years deep, close enough for her to see every seam in the firelight.

“You want to see it,” his interpreter said. “Nobody sees it. I have been going down to it every dawn for eight years and I have paid for

it, and this is what it cost, and it is the only reason any of you are stood in a warm room instead of a butcher's."

And then, flat: "You have heard him answer. Every one of you heard it on the ladders. That is what there is."

She folded on it. Not because she was convinced, but because Poole had written down the arms and the wolves and the working, and she could build a finding on those and could build nothing at all on being refused.

They argued the terms for two hours.

Khorvenn recorded as custodian — not owner, not tenant; Ilenne fought for the word. Pilgrims might come, unarmed on the pass, checked at the bend, and the check was Ghazrek's by name. A fixed toll per pilgrim in food and coin at a rate the custodian set, which the Canoness fought hardest and lost. Salt and iron once a year, entered as a gift, because tribute had a legal meaning she would not accept and Drakmoor took the word rather than the fight. The site closed to every outsider; the rite at the fire.

And the name. She would not endorse it. What Poole entered instead was that *the custodians name him Vrakvenn, the Wolf-Singer* — attributed, not affirmed, and in the sealed record of the Church of Valdenmark for ever.

Drakmoor had wanted their own paper to say who he was now. He got their own paper to say who says so. Ilenne told Vek afterwards that it was worth more, because it was unfalsifiable, and no future bishop could argue it away.

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She got one thing, and asked for it last, when everybody was tired, which told them she was as good as he was.

The Church would leave a resident. One cleric, in Khorvenn, permanently, to observe the rite and report. It is the oldest move the Church has and it is how every uncomfortable shrine in six hundred years has been slowly and patiently digested from the inside.

Sister Damaris got up off her knees, where she had been since the wolves came down the throat, and volunteered before anyone asked her.

“Can she speak goblin?” Vek said.

No. And not one of them could. They had brought an interpreter who had trade-tongue and that was all. And when he asked why, the Canoness answered it herself without a flicker of embarrassment, because to her it was not an insult but a category.

Nobody in the Church learns Goblin. There is no grammar of it, no primer, no chair for it in any school in Valdenmark. Because if goblinoids are the Discord, the noise that got into the song, then what they make is not language. It is noise. And a scholar does not sit down and learn to conjugate noise.

Vek looked round at eighty gobbos and thought about that for a while.

“So how’s she supposed to report on us,” he said, “if she can’t understand a word we say?”

Brother Poole looked up from his box and wrote something down without being asked.

“I have just heard eighty voices answer a god,” Damaris said, and her hands were shaking. “I do not know what they said. I have given my whole life to a thing I have never once heard properly and I heard it today in a language I do not have. Teach me and I will stay. Refuse me and I will stay anyway, if they let me, and be useless. I would rather be useful.”

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“What about Ilenne?”

And it stopped the room, because it was the one question nobody in that gallery had asked all day.

Everyone had been deciding about Ilenne Vasch since midday. The Canoness had come up a mountain to recover her. Poole had written

her into a legal instrument. Drakmoor had held her back as a card and Vek had played her. He had handed her a staff and used her to break a judge's case.

Nobody had asked her what she wanted.

The Canoness saw where the floor had moved and stepped onto it at once, and she did not threaten, which was what made it dangerous.

"Sister Ilenne. Look at me. Not at them. You were right."

She let it land, and it went in like a spear.

"Your order has been a joke in Valdenmark for a hundred years. Women in cold chapels singing at a god who does not answer. I have sat at tables where they were laughed at and I did not stop it. And you walked out past the last road and you were right, and there is a sworn instrument in that box which will be read in the cathedral by men who mocked you."

"Come home with me and you will not be a footnote. You will be the Sister who found him. Your order restored inside a year — I will do it myself. Books. Students. A chair. You would be Prioress of the Choristers before you are fifty and you know it."

"Or stay here." She looked round the gallery, unhurried, at the smoke and the bones and the fungus-smell and the eighty goblinoids. "Stay here and be a heretic in a hole, with no order, no books, no sisters, mending goblin children by firelight, and in thirty years nobody in the world will know your name and there will be nobody to say it."

And then the cruellest thing said in that room all day.

"You have a gift, Sister. I watched you use it. Do not bury it in a mountain because a goblin was kind to you."

Nobody translated that part for the gallery.

Ilenne looked at the Canoness for a long moment. Then she turned her head and looked at Vek. Not for permission. She was waiting to see whether the one who had spent all day using her was going to say anything at all now that there was nothing in it for him.

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“Sing your song, stupid human.”

He said it without getting off the rock, and there was nothing clever in it, and he did not look at the Canoness once.

“Sing it the way you want to sing it.”

A shrug.

“Come back any time.”

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No claim. No argument. No you’re mine.

He had taken and held everything he had ever wanted since the day he speared her — a human, all humans, a god, a rock, a room, a name — and the one thing he cared about most he opened his hand and let go of in front of everybody, and asked nothing back.

It undid the Canoness completely and she never saw it coming, because she had just spent five minutes making the finest offer of her career and every single word of it was conditional. Come home and be restored. Come home and have books. Come home and be Prioress. All of it hers to give and hers to take away.

And a goblin with a mended leg had made a better one. Go, and it costs you nothing, and the door stays open.

Ilenne made a sound and put her hand over her mouth.

Then she did three things, and each was worse for the Canoness than the last.

She turned to Brother Poole — not to Vault, to the box and the seal — and said, “Brother. Enter this as spoken and sworn.”

And Sister Ilenne Vasch resigned her order, aloud, formally, in the correct words, which she had known since she was fifteen and never expected to use. She released the Choristers from any duty to her and herself from any obedience to them.

She was not a heretic. Not apostate. Not a missing sister, not a captive, not a body the Church could recover or discipline or ransom or claim. She had walked out, with her own mouth, before a sworn seal, in the presence of her Canoness, and there was nothing left in canon law for anyone at Valdenmark to grip.

She took away their handle on her with the same instrument he had used against them all day.

Then she asked for one thing, and only one.

“Books.” And to the Canoness, level: “You said I would have books again. Send them. Not to me — to the custodians. Enter it in the instrument as part of the annual gift, with the salt and the iron.”

Drakmoor’s head came up, and there was something on his face very close to delight, because he had just watched a human he had coached for a fortnight extract a fourth term out of a settled deal at the very end when everybody was tired, which was exactly the trick the Canoness had pulled on him about the resident.

Vaulk agreed to it. She had nothing left to refuse with.

And then Ilenne came over to his rock with her staff and stood in front of him.

She did not thank him. She did not say anything about staying, because it was already done and everyone in the room had seen it.

She put her fist against her own chest — the oath sign, the private one, the one she had made for him in a cistern-room seven weeks before, that meant *I have said a true thing and cannot take it back*.

And then she reached out and put her flat palm against his chest.

“Then I will sing it my way,” she said. “Here.”

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Behind her, Damaris was laughing and crying at the same time. Wenna had both hands over her face. Brother Edrin Poole wrote and wrote and wrote.

And Canoness Miriam Vault of Valdenmark stood in a hole in a mountain having got a resident, a report, and nothing else she had come for, and looked at a goblin whelp-tender standing on a mended leg.

“...I see,” she said quietly. “You are not simple at all, are you.”

He was, in fact, simple. He had no idea what she meant.